

The Indian EXPRESS

JOURNALISM of COURAGE

₹7.00 (₹8 RAIPUR, ₹15 SRINAGAR) • www.indianexpress.com

DAILY FROM: AHMEDABAD, CHANDIGARH, DELHI, JAIPUR, KOLKATA, LUCKNOW, MUMBAI, NAGPUR, PATNA, PUNE, VADODARA

ON HIS FIRST VISIT TO VALLEY, ENVOY SAYS 'INCREDIBLE STEPS' TAKEN TO MAKE UNION TERRITORY SAFE

J&K important part of India, will relook at travel warnings: US envoy in Srinagar

Conversation will be taken forward between Gor and Washington, and New Delhi and I, says Omar after meeting

Naveed Iqbal
Srinagar, August 19

IN A strong endorsement of New Delhi's long-standing position on Jammu & Kashmir, US Ambassador Sergio Gor, who was in Srinagar Wednesday on his maiden visit to the Valley, described J&K as "an important part of India" and signalled that Washington would review the situation in the Union Territory to downgrade and ease travel warnings for US citizens.

Gor met Chief Minister Omar Abdullah at his Gupkar Road residence, marking the

first standalone visit to the Valley by a serving US Ambassador since the abrogation of Article 370 in August 2019. In January 2020, Kenneth Juster, the then Ambassador, had visited the Valley as part of a government-facilitated delegation of foreign envoys.

Stating that he was "thrilled" to be in the Valley, Gor said, "This is an important part of India. I am here, visiting for the first time. It's an incredibly beautiful place."

He is expected to travel to Ladakh Thursday.

He said he had "a very

CONTINUED ON PAGE 2



US Ambassador Sergio Gor with Jammu and Kashmir Chief Minister Omar Abdullah in Srinagar on Wednesday. ANI

Post-Op Sindoor chill, message underlines Delhi stand, signal to Pak too

Shubhajit Roy
New Delhi, August 19

US AMBASSADOR Sergio Gor's declaration from Srinagar that Jammu and Kashmir is "an important part of India" is not just Washington's public affirmation of New Delhi's long-standing position on J&K, but it is also being seen as a message to Islamabad and Beijing, especially post the Pahalgam terror attack and Operation Sindoor.

A close confidant of President Donald Trump, Gor is also

his special envoy to South and Central Asia. His meeting with Chief Minister Omar Abdullah signals both acknowledgement and engagement with J&K's first elected government post the 2019 constitutional changes.

For New Delhi, this has significance given that the India-US chill was precipitated by the India-Pak conflict amid Trump's repeated claims of brokering the ceasefire following Operation Sindoor last year.

From Srinagar, however, CONTINUED ON PAGE 2



Congress leaders Sonia Gandhi, Mallikarjun Kharge and Rahul Gandhi at the CWC meeting in New Delhi, Wednesday. ANI, SHARMA

Cong invokes Tagore, Mahatma: Will sing only first 2 stanzas of Vande Mataram

Party firms up strategy to corner Govt over paper leaks, 'theft' at Ram temple

Asad Rehman
New Delhi, August 19

DAYS AFTER the Congress was embroiled in a controversy over the rendition of the national song, the Congress Working Committee (CWC) on Wednesday decided that the party will only sing the first two stanzas of Vande Mataram at its programmes.

The Congress's highest decision-making body cited a 1937 CWC resolution to back its stand, arguing that the leading lights of the freedom movement, including Mahatma Gandhi and Rabindranath Tagore, had backed limiting the public rendition of Vande Mataram to its first two stanzas.

Following a CWC meeting convened by the All India Congress Committee (AICC) chief, Mallikarjun Kharge, at the party

INSIDE PAGE 6
BJP HITS BACK: 'CONG NEW MUSLIM LEAGUE'

headquarters Indira Bhavan in Delhi, AICC general secretary in charge of organisation K C Venugopal told a press conference that there was "no confusion" over the rendition of Vande Mataram within the Congress.

"The Congress president (Kharge) categorically said it yesterday. It was clarified. But again today, it was discussed by the Congress Working Committee. Our stand is very clear. The CWC resolution of 1937... Mahatma Gandhi, Pandit Jawaharlal Nehru, Rabindranath Tagore, Subhas Chandra Bose and Sardar Patel. We will abide by the decision taken by them."

CONTINUED ON PAGE 2

GS-II
BY DR. SATVIK BHAN
Starting from
23rd
August, 2026
9540886666
B-20, 2nd Floor, ORN, New Delhi

Happening today

● **UNION HOME** Minister Amit Shah will chair the 31st meeting of the Southern Zonal Council in Tamil Nadu's Mamallapuram.

● **A NINE-JUDGE** Constitution Bench will pronounce its verdict on reference against expansive definition given to "industry" in Industrial Disputes Act, 1947.

● **FINANCE MINISTER** Nirmala Sitharaman will lead a ministerial delegation for the fourth India-Singapore Ministerial Round-table, a key platform for discussions on bilateral economic and strategic cooperation.

TRACK THESE AND MORE ON
WWW.INDIANEXPRESS.COM

Business as Usual

By EP UNNY

Bytaries from United States will be duty received by the Unrestored State of India.



EXPRESS investigation

Workers protesting for higher wages got over 50 days on average in jail — until courts stepped in

April protests in Noida met with police crackdown; courts granted relief in 84% bail pleas on FIRs with substantive allegations: 'mere presence not enough to deny bail, specific evidence needed, can't equate workers with instigators'

Drishhti Jain & Kaunain Sherif M
New Delhi, August 19

IT'S A tale of two protests — and two very different outcomes.

Last month, the Jantar Mantar protest demanding a leak-proof exam system ended with the Union Education Minister's resignation and an assurance by the Centre and states that the police will not pursue any case against the protesters.

In sharp contrast, the week-long protest starting April 10 by factory workers in private firms in neighbouring Noida, demanding higher wages, got no such assurance. Indeed, a police crackdown saw up to 200 people taken into custody, including two booked under the stringent National Security Act (NSA), which allows detention without trial for up to a year. On April 14, the UP government raised the wages (see page 7) but it took the courts to grant relief to most of the jailed protesters.

The Indian Express investigated 106 arrests with substantive allegations, ranging from rioting and arson to attempt to murder — the average period a protester spent in custody was 53 days. These arrests led to 222 bail orders linked to seven FIRs. The investigation revealed that relief was granted in as many as 188, or 84 per cent. Significantly, the orders had a consistent



ON BAIL: 19-year-old says stepped out for food, was arrested; (right) 20-year-old says picked up from lane outside home. PHOTO: KAVANNA

106 arrests, days in jail

FIR No	Max	Min	Avg
151	74	8	32
149	81	25	36
164	118	49	89
165	105	34	71
169	120	25	54
172	81	27	35

DATA FOR FIR NO. 163/2026 NOT AVAILABLE

pattern. Judges repeatedly found that the police case rests on treating a crowd as the accused, rather than establishing what any one worker actually did.

CONTINUED ON PAGE 2

Where bail denied: Govt slapped NSA, cited book, library, articles and Gaza

Drishhti Jain & Kaunain Sherif M
New Delhi, August 19

IN THE Noida labour protests, where nearly eight of every 10 people arrested have got bail, those denied relief face a common accusation: an alleged role in the conspiracy.

Books read, WhatsApp texts, and participation in Gaza and NRC protests have all been cited as evidence, with police even using the term "andolan

jeeri" in one case.

Those denied bail include activists, a former journalist and a Delhi University graduate — the latter two held under the draconian National Security Act (NSA), which permits detention of up to a year without trial.

On May 13, nearly a month after the protests turned violent, UP invoked the NSA against Satyam Verma, a 60-year-old former journalist from

CONTINUED ON PAGE 2

'CONFLICT OF INTEREST'

Can look at more safeguards: Ministry on deep tech fund

Amitabh Sinha
New Delhi, August 19

WHILE MAINTAINING that the safeguards on avoiding conflict of interest in the disbursement of Research, Development and Innovation (RDI) Fund were fairly robust, Science and Technology Minister Jitendra Singh on Wednesday said the government was open to considering suggestions for strengthening the process further.

Singh's remarks, made at the monthly meeting of Secretaries of scientific departments under his charge, come in the wake of an investigative report by The Indian Express earlier this month that showed that 15 of the 22 private companies selected for the first round of funding from the RDI Fund had investment ties to seven members of the selection panel, raising questions of conflict of interest and propriety.

Though the panel members concerned had declared their interest and recused themselves from evaluating the company they had a stake in, as per the guidelines, the matter underlined the need for additional safeguards in the system. At Wednesday's meeting, Singh reviewed all the procedural safeguards being adopted to avoid a conflict of interest situation, and emphasised that due diligence and verification

CONTINUED ON PAGE 2

NATION

PAGE 8

BANGLADESHIS AMONG 9 KILLED IN KOLKATA HOTEL BLAZE

to coach: her own son.

One of Indian sport's earliest superstars, Pritam never stopped going to the hockey ground throughout her pregnancy — initially training lightly before coaching the players there. Seven months after Yashdeep was born, she was back chasing her own dream. She was summoned for the Manchester Commonwealth Games selection trials after deciding to make a comeback to the national team. She shed 18 kg in three or four months to earn her place in the squad that went on to win India's famous gold medal.

Pritam eventually set up the academy in Sonipat. But when it came to her son, she wanted

a different path.

Yashdeep occasionally accompanied her to the training ground, but she encouraged him to try other sports. She also worried that if he made the national team, his selection would be viewed through the prism of his mother's influence, even if he had earned it on merit.

So, Yashdeep turned to swimming. Given the sporting genes in the family — his father was also a hockey player and his sister, Kanika, currently plays for India — it was hardly surprising that he excelled. Then, one winter, the swimming pools shut. Yashdeep picked up a hockey stick to pass time, and soon found himself hooked.

Yashdeep may have been late to structured hockey, but the sport itself was hardly new to him. "Since childhood, I have been surrounded by hockey. At home, our dinner table conversations would revolve around the game and if I accompanied my parents to their work, it would be at a hockey field," he had told The Indian Express in an earlier interview. "That atmosphere really helped me grasp the sport faster."

MEANWHILE, Pritam and Kuldeep continued to scout and train players from across Haryana, moulding them into India stars. Many like Neha, whose mother worked at the

CONTINUED ON PAGE 2

● SONIPAT ACADEMY SET UP BY FORMER INDIA PLAYER PRITAM RANI SIWACH SENDS FOUR WOMEN TO ONGOING WORLD CUP

She captained Team India, now son in Hockey World Cup — via her academy

Mihir Vasavda
Mumbai, August 19

THE 1998 Hockey World Cup in the Netherlands gave former India captain Pritam Rani Siwach one of the fondest chapters of her career. Twenty-eight years later, the same tournament and the same country have given her another memory to cherish: watching her son, Yashdeep, make his World Cup debut, making them the first mother-son duo to play in the marquee event.

Pritam has another reason to cheer. Besides Yashdeep, a defender, there are four players in India's women's squad at the

ongoing Hockey World Cup — defender Jyoti, midfielders Neha Goyal and Shilpi Dabas, and teenage forward Sakshi Rani — from the academy that she and her husband, Kuldeep, set up in Haryana's Sonipat. Five World Cup players. One academy. One hockey family. "It's a big tournament. Yashdeep is playing in the same country where I also played my first World Cup. It is special," Pritam, 51, tells The Indian Express. "Mazdoor jab ghar banana hai, hota hai rehta hai (When labourers build a home, they just keep building). That's what I am doing. Coaching is my

passion. I don't see it as my son playing the tournament. My daughters are there, too. There's no difference for me." Over the years, Pritam and Kuldeep have quietly built one of India's most productive talent pipelines for women's hockey — Yashdeep, too, trained at the academy in his early years, before moving on to a men's academy. The Pritam Siwach Academy, which once stood on land used for grazing cattle, is now a breeding ground for elite players, producing internationalists such as Neha Goyal, Nisha Warsi and Sharmila Devi.

The couple have relied less on infrastructure and more on persistence, providing young



Yashdeep Siwach with mother Pritam, a former India captain, and father Kuldeep, a hockey coach.

players with coaching, equipment and, just as importantly, a space to train consistently.

Yet, for all the players she has helped shape, there was one who Pritam never intended

3 CNG station employees killed as truck's tank explodes during refuelling

Pragynesh
New Delhi, August 19

THREE EMPLOYEES at a CNG station died in Outer Delhi's Tikri Kalan on Wednesday afternoon and three people were injured as the gas tank of a truck exploded when it was being refuelled.

The employees, their families claimed, were not rushed to hospital despite the seriousness of the injuries until they arrived at the station. While relatives of the staff have also claimed that the fuel station was recently closed for repairs due to incidents of CNG leak, police said that they are still verifying whether the blast happened due to a malfunction in the vehicle or a leak. A case would be registered as per the findings of the probe, said officers.

According to the Delhi Fire Service, the incident was reported at 3:47 pm at the CNG pump. Officials said that the truck's gas tank exploded when a CNG pipe was connected to it. Four fire tenders were rushed to the spot, located near the Tikri Kalan Metro station. The station was cordoned off. The fuel station employees who died were identified as Manish, Brahmajet and Sunny.



The CNG station where the truck cylinder exploded at Tikri Kalan area in New Delhi on Wednesday.

The driver of the vehicle, a Tata truck, is among those injured. Apart from the truck, a scooter and a Eeco car also suffered damage.

Families mourn

Manish, 25, was a resident of Baba Haridas Colony in West Delhi. "He was the one refuelling the truck," said a senior police officer. When Manish's friend Ashish and uncle Vijay Prasad got a call about him getting injured, they rushed from their homes in Baba Haridas Nagar, assuming that he would be in the hospital by the time

they reached. "For half an hour, he was lying there at the station. He had severe burn injuries... We had to take him to the hospital," said Ashish. Manish, father of a five-month-old, got married last year. He had taken up the job just eight months ago and fed a family of five, including his elderly parents, according to the relatives. Ashish also claimed that Manish had been talking about leaks at the station for some days.

"He and the others were even given leave as repair work was going on," he added. Brahmajet's nephew,

Aditya, said that he got a call at about 4:30 pm that he had been critically injured. "I went to the station but an ambulance had not arrived even then. I took him to the Jeevan Jyoti Hospital in Bahadurgarh. I don't know what to tell his wife and kids," he said.

The third deceased, Sunny, 30, who lived in Nizampur area, had been working at the station for three years, and lived with his parents, widowed sister-in-law and her children. "He was the sole breadwinner. Finally he had some savings, and we were thinking of getting him married," said Balraj, Sunny's uncle.

On run for 8 months, man caught after 2-km on-foot chase by police

Accused of holding scrap dealer captive and demanding Rs 2 crore ransom

Express News Service
New Delhi, August 19

HE THOUGHT he could give police the slip. But when Mohammed Wamiq took off in New Ashok Nagar on Tuesday after noticing a team of officers waiting for him, a nearly 2-km on-foot chase followed—ending his eight-month run from the law. Wamiq, the alleged mastermind of a January 2 abduction in which a 44-year-old scrap dealer was held captive and his family was asked to pay Rs 2 crore, was arrested on Tuesday, police said.

The chase began after an NDR Crime Branch team, acting on technical surveillance and local intelligence, tracked Wamiq to Southeast Delhi.

He was allegedly heading to New Ashok Nagar to meet his girlfriend when he noticed the police team and tried to flee. "The officers chased him on foot for nearly 2 km before apprehending him," said DCP Chandan Kumar Singh said.

Wamiq, who had been on the run since January, was declared a proclaimed offender by a court in March. Police said Nizamuddin, the scrap dealer, was abducted while he was travelling from his Delhi home to his factory in Ghaziabad. Five men allegedly stopped

his vehicle near Okhla Metro station and forced him into a white Tata Punch.

"The accused allegedly made him inhale an unidentified substance, leaving him semi-conscious," said the DCP. Wamiq then called Nizamuddin's house and demanded a ransom of Rs 2 crore and threatened to kill him if it was not paid.

However, police said, Nizamuddin managed to escape when the vehicle stopped at a petrol pump. He jumped out, raised an alarm and fled before reaching his factory. He then approached the Shaheen Bagh police station, where an FIR was registered.

Police said Wamiq knew Nizamuddin and was aware that he could arrange a substantial ransom. He allegedly contacted his associates and arranged the Tata Punch used in the crime.

While three other accused—Rizwan, Taiyab and Ayaz Khan alias Bhura—were arrested in January, Wamiq and another accused, Noman, absconded and were declared proclaimed absconders. A reward of Rs 20,000 each was announced for information leading to their arrest. During questioning, Wamiq allegedly told police that he and Noman fled Delhi for Kotdwar after the incident. While Noman later travelled to Bengaluru, Wamiq remained in Kotdwar before returning to Delhi on August 18. Police said Wamiq had previously been involved in four criminal cases related to theft, robbery, cheating and Arms Act offences in Uttar Pradesh. He also ran a salon in Faridabad, which he shut last December after suffering losses.

Delhi SIR schedule revised third time, final rolls to be released on November 4

Devansh Mittal
New Delhi, August 19

THE TIMELINE for the Special Intensive Revision (SIR) in Delhi was revised for the third time on Wednesday after the exercise was launched with door-to-door distribution of enumeration forms among voters on June 30. This is the second time within this month that the Capital saw a revision in the SIR schedule.

The deadlines for the publication of the draft and final electoral rolls have been pushed by a week.

While the rationalisation and rearrangement of polling stations was originally scheduled to be completed by August 17, the deadline has been pushed to August 24.

The draft electoral roll will now be published on August 31, instead of August 24. The final rolls will be published on November 4, instead of October 27, as per the revised timeline.

Officials said the revision in the schedule is aimed at giving

Revised deadlines

Activity	Revised Deadline
Rationalisation of polling stations	August 24
Release of draft rolls	August 31
Filing claims, objections	August 31 to September 30
Notice phase for disposal of claims, objections	August 31 to October 29
Release of final rolls	November 4

authorities more time for the rationalisation of polling stations.

The SIR enumeration phase got over on Monday. During the close to one-and-a-half month long process, forms of 97.51 lakh electors—about 67% of the 1.45 crore electors recorded initially when the SIR exercise began in Delhi—had been collected and uploaded to the official portal, as per the data from the office of the Chief Electoral Officer (CEO).

The remaining 47.58 lakh electors, constituting about 33% of the electorate—who were absent, may have moved or died; are covered under duplicate entries, or "Other" reasons—were

marked "uncollectible" and will have their names struck off.

This indicates that the names of roughly one out of every three electors in the Capital are expected to be deleted from the draft roll.

The revised schedule shifts the window for filing claims and objections from August 24-September 23 to August 31-September 30.

The notice phase for the disposal of claims and objections has also been extended from August 24 to October 29.

This revision comes after the Election Commission had or-

dered two previous extensions to the SIR due to the slow progress on digitisation of enumeration forms.

However, Delhi's estimated 33% deletions at the draft stage is less than the other major metro cities. Bengaluru is set to see around 45% deletions, Hyderabad 44% deletions and Mumbai is set to see roughly 35% deletions.

The final number of exclusions from the electoral roll will be known only on November 4 when the final electoral rolls will be published.

Electors who may have submitted forms with incomplete details will get notices over the next two months asking for proof of their eligibility to remain on the electoral rolls. Some of them might be added back to the rolls.

The ECI has also said that genuine electors who may have been deleted in the draft rolls can be added to the final roll in the one-month claims-and-objection period as fresh electors.

Can't use all construction rights? Delhi Master Plan 2047 lets you sell them

Devansh Mittal
New Delhi, August 19

IF YOU cannot use all the construction rights available on your plot, Delhi's new Master Plan will allow you to sell unused rights to another developer who can use them for a different plot. This is the idea behind Transferable Development Rights (TDR), a new provision in the Master Plan for Delhi (MPD)-2047, which was approved by the Delhi Development Authority (DDA) last week.

The MPD is awaiting final approval and notification from the Ministry of Housing and Urban Affairs (MoHUA).

TDR has been used extensively in Mumbai, particularly to accelerate slum rehabilitation and urban redevelopment. According to research by think tank Observer Research Foundation (ORF), more than 8 crore sq ft of slum TDR were used by developers to build towers and redevelopment housing societies in suburban Mumbai over a period of two decades until 2021.

In Delhi, the DDA aims to use this market-based mechanism that is designed to incentivise private property owners and to encourage them to participate in heritage preservation and slum rehabilitation efforts.

How is TDR expected to work in Delhi?

Under the public-private partnership (PPP) model for slum rehabilitation, developers build homes for slum residents

Under the new TDR mechanism, these unused development rights can be used on another plot, or sold to another developer

The potential for unused rights is very significant because the new MPD provides a Floor Area Ratio (FAR) of 500 for slum rehabilitation, which allows for the building of high-rises.

FAR determines how much total floor space can be built on a plot. Consider a land parcel of 2,000 sq m. If the builder builds his building covering just 50% of the land and has a FAR of 500, then he will be able to build 10 floors, each with an area of 1,000 sq m. With the same FAR, if the builder uses just 25% of the land for building, he will be able to build 20 floors of 500 sq m each.

The additional building rights (TDR) are likely to be used in Transit-Oriented Development (TOD) zones, which already have a FAR of 500.

In which cases will TDR be available?

TDR will be awarded in three specific cases:

- Conservation or preservation of heritage buildings
- Regeneration of buildings in the Walled City (Old Delhi)
- In-situ slum rehabilitation schemes.

TDR will be awarded in the form of a TDR Certificate issued by the DDA against the payment of requisite charges. The certificate will provide development rights only within the National Capital Territory of Delhi, and

will be transferable among properties.

However, these rights can be used only in designated "Receiving Areas" which will be identified by the DDA from time to time. These are expected to include areas notified for transit-oriented development, including areas on both sides of Metro corridors. This geographical limitation is expected to ensure that development remains controlled and aligned with the city's planning objectives.

A dedicated portal to trade TDRs

DDA will create a dedicated single-window portal to facilitate the trading of TDRs. This portal, a key feature of the new mechanism, is expected to streamline the process of buying, selling, and utilising development rights across the city.

A joint government-industry task force set up by the previous Lieutenant Governor V K Saxena in 2024 too had recommended a provision in the new slum policy along these lines.

"Private developers are incentivised to participate in slum redevelopment by granting them additional Floor Space Index (FSI). This additional FSI can be used for commercial purposes or sold in the open market, making the projects financially viable for developers," the task force had said.



Several parts of Delhi were washed by rain on Wednesday. TASHI TORIKAL

Skywatch



Forecast: August 20, 2026
Generally cloudy sky. Light to moderate rain.

MAX: 32-34
0.2°C above normal

MIN: 26-28
0.5°C below normal

• Sunrise: 5:54 AM (August 21)

• Sunset: 6:56 PM (August 20)

• Moonrise: 2:07 PM (August 21)

• Moonset: 11:29 PM (August 20)

AQI Tracker



Bawana
Poor
AQI: 223

Mundka
Satisfactory
AQI: 98

Aya Nagar
Satisfactory
AQI: 81

Najafgarh
Satisfactory
AQI: 74

■ Good (0-50)

■ Satisfactory (51-100)

■ Moderate (101-200)

■ Poor (201-300)

■ Very Poor (301-400)

■ Severe (401-500)

Aeronautical Development Agency
(Ministry of Defence, Govt. of India)
PB No. 1718, Vimanapura Post, Bangalore-560017

ADA-ADV-138:2026

Date: 17-08-2026

CANCELLATION

SUB: ENGAGEMENT OF PROJECT ASSISTANTS ON TENURE BASIS

Advertisement No. ADA-ADV-138:2026 dated 03.08.2026 for Engagement of Project Assistants on tenure basis at ADA stands cancelled due to administrative reasons.

Director (Admin & HR), ADA

अखिल भारतीय आयुर्विज्ञान संस्थान, पटना
All India Institute of Medical Sciences, Patna
Phulwarisharif, Patna- 801507

No.: FTS-15070(XV)/Deputation/2026 Date: 11.08.2026

VACANCY NOTICE ON DEPUTATION

Applications are invited in prescribed pro-forma from eligible Officers of Central/State Government/U.T./Autonomous Bodies/Universities/Public Sector Undertaking/ Ministries /R&D Organization/Police Departments of Central/State/U.T./Armed Forces including Para Military Forces as applicable for filling up the following Group 'A' Posts on Deputation Basis at All India Institute of Medical Sciences, Patna. The essential qualification, experience etc. required for applying for these posts are as under:-

Sl. No.	Name of Post	Pay Matrix & Level	No. of post(s)
01.	Superintending Engineer	Level-13 (₹ 1,23,100 - ₹ 2,15,900)	1
02.	Chief Librarian	Level-13 (₹ 1,23,100 - ₹ 2,15,900)	1
03.	Senior Analyst (System Analyst)	Level-12 (₹ 78,800 - ₹ 2,09,200)	1
04.	Deputy Chief Security Officer	Level-11 (₹ 67,700 - ₹ 2,08,700)	1
05.	Hospital Architect	Level-11 (₹ 67,700 - ₹ 2,08,700)	1
06.	Senior Procurement-cum-Stores Officer	Level-11 (₹ 67,700 - ₹ 2,08,700)	1
07.	Executive Engineer (AC & R)	Level-11 (₹ 67,700 - ₹ 2,08,700)	1
08.	Executive Engineer (Electrical)	Level-11 (₹ 67,700 - ₹ 2,08,700)	1
09.	Chief Medical Social Service Officer	Level-11 (₹ 67,700 - ₹ 2,08,700)	1
10.	CSSD Officer	Level-11 (₹ 67,700 - ₹ 2,08,700)	1
11.	Senior Dietician (Assistant Food Manager)	Level-10 (₹ 56,100 - ₹ 1,77,500)	2
12.	Accounts Officer	Level-10 (₹ 56,100 - ₹ 1,77,500)	3*
13.	Security Officer	Level-10 (₹ 56,100 - ₹ 1,77,500)	1
14.	Chief Medical Record Officer	Level-10 (₹ 56,100 - ₹ 1,77,500)	1
15.	Supervising Medical Social Service Officer	Level-10 (₹ 56,100 - ₹ 1,77,500)	1

*Two (02) posts are tentative, in anticipation of non-continuation of currently working two Accounts Officers.

The last date for posting the completed application in the prescribed pro-forma along with required documents through proper channel is up to **30 days from the publication of the advertisement on the official website of AIIMS Patna** i.e. www.aiimspatna.edu.in. The format of application and details regarding age, qualifications, experience and other information to the posts are available on the official website of AIIMS Patna i.e. www.aiimspatna.edu.in. All further addendum, corrigendum and notifications, if any, will be available on the Institute's website www.aiimspatna.edu.in.

Sd/-
Executive Director
AIIMS, Patna

EXPRESS

Careers

CHRISTIAN MEDICAL COLLEGE & HOSPITAL, LUDHIANA

Project : National Centre for Advanced Stroke Trials, Technology and Practice (CAR)

Advanced Stroke Centre, Christian Medical College, Ludhiana

Principal Investigator : Prof. Jeyaraj Pandian

JOB POSITION	QUALIFICATION/EXPERIENCE	VACANCY
Project Scientist III (Medical)	Post Graduate Degree in Medical Sciences, including integrated PG Degrees.	(1)
Project Scientist I (Non-Medical)	Post Graduate Degree in Non-Medical Sciences, including integrated PG Degrees.	(1)
Project Technical Support-II	Three Years' graduate in Science/ Commerce/IT with three relevant years' experience in relevant field OR Post Graduate Degree in Science/ Commerce/IT ; Good knowledge of Computer including proficiency in MS Excel, MS Word & MS Power Point	(2)

Last date for Submission of Application : 28th August 2026.

Please submit your CV to the undersigned: CARNeuro2025@gmail.com and jeyaraj.pandian@cmcludhiana.in

41st Annual Convocation

Inauguration of
Centre for Advanced Research in Bacteriophage and Infectious Diseases (CARBID)
(Sponsored by ICMR, Govt. of India, New Delhi & VIT)

22nd AUGUST 2026 - SATURDAY | Time : 9.30 A.M.

CHIEF GUEST

Smt. Rekha Gupta
Hon'ble Chief Minister, Delhi

GUEST OF HONOUR

Mr. Babu Unnikrishnan
Vice President & CTO - BFSI, Tata Consultancy Services

PRESIDED BY

Dr. G. Viswanathan
Founder & Chancellor

VIT UNIVERSITY

www.vit.ac.in

MULTI-CRORE SEWAGE TREATMENT PLANT TENDER FRAUD

Defence flags 27-month delay in arrest as court sends Jain to judicial custody

Nirbhay Thakur
New Delhi, August 19

THE 27-MONTH delay between the registration of the FIR and the arrest of former Delhi minister and AAP leader Satyendar Jain and four others came under sharp focus in court on Wednesday, with the defence arguing that the accused had joined the investigation whenever called. The court, however, said their earlier cooperation did not prevent the investigating officer (IO) from arresting them later, and that the investigating agency's decision to arrest could not be "lightly brushed aside".

The court, however, rejected Jain's plea challenging his arrest and sent him and the other accused to two weeks of judicial custody a day after they were arrested by the Anti-Corruption Branch (ACB) in a multi-crore sewage treatment plant (STP) tender fraud. It also granted the ACB two-day police custody of former Delhi Jal Board (DJB) contractual consultant Ankur Shrivastava.

"Even though the accused persons may have joined investigation at earlier instances whenever called by the investigating agency, but merely on that ground today it cannot be claimed that the IO could not have arrested the accused when they lastly appeared before him. The subjective satisfaction of the investigating

Other cases against Satyendar Jain

MONEY LAUNDERING CASE:

Accused of laundering money through four firms linked to him when he was a minister in the Delhi government, Jain was arrested by the Enforcement Directorate on May 30, 2022. The case was based on a CBI FIR lodged against the accused in 2017 under the Prevention of Corruption Act.

● After spending over 18 months, he walked out of Tihar jail in October 2024 when a Delhi court granted him bail and stated that the trial in the case was unlikely to commence soon.

● In the CBI case against him, Jain had already been granted regular bail by a trial court on September 6, 2019.

CCTV PROJECT CASE:

In March 2025, the Anti-Corruption Branch booked Jain over alleged corruption in a Rs

571-crore CCTV project. Officials said he allegedly accepted a bribe of Rs 7 crore to waive off the liquidated damages (LD) penalty of Rs 16 crore imposed on Bharat Electronics Limited (BEL), which was installing CCTV cameras in the Capital.

PWD HIRING CASE:

Jain was also booked in a case relating to alleged irregularities in hiring in the Public Works Department (PWD). This was one of the first major corruption cases filed against any senior leader of the AAP. After almost four years of investigation, the CBI reached the conclusion that there were no irregularities in recruitment, and no one had made any pecuniary gains. A Delhi court in August 2025 accepted a closure report filed by the CBI against Jain in the case.

NIRBHAY THAKUR

agency as to the arrest of an accused cannot be lightly brushed aside," Special Judge Dig Vinay Singh of the Rouse Avenue Court said.

Dismissing Jain's application that his arrest was illegal, the court said, "Suffice it to note here that having gone through the police file, the contentions raised by both the sides, it cannot be claimed at this stage, prima facie, that the arrest is illegal or unjustified."

The others sent to judicial custody are Nagendra Yadav, proprietor of AN Enterprises; Raj Kumar Kurra, owner of Euroteck Environment Private Limited (EEPL) and Pankaj Verma, proprietor of Sriharan.

The court issued notice on the bail applications filed by Jain and the others and listed the matter for hearing on August 25.

During the hearing, the defence flagged the delay in ar-

rest. "May 10, 2024, is the FIR date. The arrest has happened 27 months later. In the entire period, I have been called just once for questioning, this arrest was not justified and it is completely illegal," senior advocate N Hariharan said on behalf of Jain.

Senior advocate Maninder Singh, representing Yadav, added, "A premier investigating agency like ACB decides to arrest someone who is not arrested by the ED when a chargesheet was filed by them. This is a mockery. You assume people you're doing investigation and then you arrest them by evening. Grounds of arrest are a sham. I joined investigation when called via notices. They haven't mentioned the reason in the entire grounds of arrest. Law can't work on whims and fancies."

Advocate Rajat Bharadwaj, appearing for Shrivastava, argued that the accused had complied with notices issued under Section 41A of the CrPc, but the grounds of arrest did not disclose this.

"...There's a clear cut case of suppression and intentional concealment. In grounds of arrest, it is not disclosed that a 41A notice was issued. The grounds should say, 'after August 5, this is why we've arrested the accused'," he said.

The ACB, represented by Public Prosecutor Manish Rawat, alleged that Jain had in-

chestrated a multi-crore scam by manipulating tender conditions for the upgradation of five STPs in 2022.

According to ACB's remand papers submitted before the court on Wednesday, Jain, in collusion with former DJB CEO Udit Prakash Rai, allegedly entered restrictive technical specifications — including unpiloted Integrated Fixed-Film Activated Sludge (IFAS) technology and strict oxygen transfer efficiency requirements — while deliberately omitting mandatory environmental safeguards prescribed by the CPCB.

On the agency seeking police custody of Shrivastava, the court said, "His police custody is indeed necessary for fair investigation, for recovery of his mobile phone which would be a crucial piece of evidence; his custodial interrogation is also necessary to unearth the other aspects of the conspiracy..."

A defence counsel, meanwhile, pointed out that an STP using similar technology had been installed in Surat and had become a model for the rest of the country. "IFAS technology was introduced pursuant to directions of the Supreme Court and the National Company Law Tribunal," the counsel added.

"Their case is that because you restricted to this technology... therefore the cartelisation and therefore the corruption," Bharadwaj said.

Tender changed to increase cost, benefit Euroteck: ACB

Alok Singh & Nirbhay Thakur
New Delhi, August 19

THE ANTI-CORRUPTION Branch (ACB) probe into the alleged multi-crore sewage treatment plant (STP) tender scam involving former Delhi minister and AAP leader Satyendar Jain has found that tender conditions and the scope of work were changed to increase cost and benefit the company that won the contract, while money was routed through intermediaries allegedly linked to Jain and former Delhi Jal Board (DJB) CEO Udit Prakash Rai.

The agency claimed that initially, a relaxation of oxygen transfer efficiency requirements was proposed to encourage "wider competition" during the tendering process. This proposal was allegedly rejected after discussions between Jain and Rai. Instead, a condition requiring bidders with a minimum oxygen transfer efficiency of 4 Kg/Kwh was enforced. "This decision significantly reduced competition and allegedly favoured a particular technology provider, namely EEPL," the ACB alleged.

Further, the agency claimed that a pilot study was not conducted and a restrictive technology condition imposed to "restrict the competition". The ACB alleged that meetings were held on December 21 and 23, 2021, involving Jain and senior DJB officials, during which the terms of reference

companies have been linked to alleged manipulation of tenders. Rai has been accused of taking bribes worth Rs 1.5 crore.

Tender conditions

According to the ACB's remand papers submitted before the court on Wednesday, the tendering process was allegedly manipulated to restrict competition and favour Euroteck Environment (EEPL), which was eventually awarded the contract to upgrade and augment five STP each in Niloti, Najafgarh, Narela and Kirti Nagar in 2022.

The agency claimed that initially, a relaxation of oxygen transfer efficiency requirements was proposed to encourage "wider competition" during the tendering process. This proposal was allegedly rejected after discussions between Jain and Rai. Instead, a condition requiring bidders with a minimum oxygen transfer efficiency of 4 Kg/Kwh was enforced. "This decision significantly reduced competition and allegedly favoured a particular technology provider, namely EEPL," the ACB alleged.

Further, the agency claimed that a pilot study was not conducted and a restrictive technology condition imposed to "restrict the competition". The ACB alleged that meetings were held on December 21 and 23, 2021, involving Jain and senior DJB officials, during which the terms of reference



ACB personnel produce Satyendar Jain before the Rouse Avenue Court in New Delhi on Wednesday. ANI

were prepared and it was decided that only fixed-media IFAS (Fixed-Film Activated Sludge) technology — an advanced wastewater treatment process used in STPs — would be considered for upgradation. "Restrictive conditions of IFAS technology with only fixed media was imposed... which restricted the competition among the technology providers," the ACB said, adding that no pilot study or trial run of IFAS technology was ever conducted before adopting it for large-scale implementation.

Scope of work and cost

The ACB probe also centres on the inclusion of augmentation costs in a project that was meant to involve only upgradation at some STPs.

"During the probe, it was found that the cost of augmen-

tation was included for the STPs where only upgradation was to be carried out. This directly benefited the company providing the technology," a source said.

Upgradation improves the quality of treatment, while augmentation increases an STP's capacity to process larger volumes of wastewater. Both involve the use of technology, manpower and equipment.

The ACB alleged that the technical proposal for augmentation of Rohini STP from 15 MGD to 25 MGD was altered by Jain "who approved enhancement to 30 MGD without any technical recommendation or feasibility study".

"Similarly, Rohini and Narela STPs were included in the project while Okhla Phase V STP was excluded, resulting in an estimated escalation of ap-

proximately Rs 123 crore," it added. The agency called the decision of Jain "arbitrary" and "taken without adequate technical justification".

Link to Euroteck

According to sources in the ACB, Jain first met Kurra at his home in August 2021 regarding the deal. This was followed by a process in which Kurra allegedly secured the tender with the help of the other accused.

Further, the agency alleged that on December 22, 2021, a day after one of the meetings involving Jain and senior DJB officials, Euroteck entered into an agreement with Sriharan Enterprises, a proprietorship concern of Verma, appointing it as an "authorised marketing agent entitled to receive commission at the rate of 3% of payments received by Euroteck from DJB tender works".

Verma is the nephew of Vinod Chaturhan, who is a neighbour of Jain, the agency alleged.

Money trail

The ACB has so far traced around Rs 16 crore through cash transactions and bank transfers involving companies owned by Yadav and Verma, sources said. These transactions allegedly involved intermediaries known to Jain and Rai.

The agency has said that Rai had received bribes worth Rs 1.52 crore in his own and his relatives' bank accounts through banking channels linked to a company owned by Yadav.

From congestion to roadside parking, Delhi traffic police to target 'problem areas'

Sakshi Chand
New Delhi, August 19

DELHI POLICE Commissioner Anurag Kumar has asked the traffic wing to draw up an action plan to tackle congestion, accident-prone stretches and chronic traffic choke points with each traffic circle being tasked with identifying at least one "problem area". These could be stretches affected by encroachment, roadside parking or heavy traffic movement.

The Indian Express has learnt. The directions, issued a few days ago, call to combine enforcement with engineering measures as well as public awareness and participation. "The plan is expected to focus on reducing congestion, improving traffic flow and strengthening road discipline," a senior officer said.

Traffic officials have been asked to identify roads and stretches requiring priority attention.

"The traffic unit has also been directed to undertake zero-tolerance drives against common violations such as triple riding, riding without helmets and driving on the wrong carriageway," the officer said.

The directions seek to combine enforcement with engineering measures as well as public awareness and participation

Kumar stressed that visible and sustained enforcement is essential to ensure traffic discipline, the officer added.

The emphasis is on making traffic policing more visible on the ground. Officials have been asked to increase their presence, make greater use of communication sets and use social media more actively for traffic alerts and traffic-management messaging.

Awareness programmes in schools and colleges are also being planned. "Sector-specific engagement plans should be prepared for groups such as taxi operators, e-rickshaw drivers and truck operators to seek voluntary compliance and sensitise them about the impact of rash driving and unauthorised parking," the officer added.

One proposal that could im-

prove enforcement on Delhi's roads is a review of the authority to issue traffic challans. At present, local police personnel seeking to issue a traffic challan have to inform traffic police officers to issue challans.

The matter is being examined by the Traffic Management Division.

"The notification needs to come from the government and it is under process. If approved, even local police will be able to issue such challans," the official said.

Further, Kumar has directed the traffic police to deploy personnel from the CP Reserve for integrated checking.

The directions come after last week, while on general gash (night patrolling) before the Independence Day, Kumar had reached the KTR Flyover at around 12.30 am and found several vehicles parked on the loop connecting the flyover to the airport.

Angered by the parking on the flyover, he had suspended Delhi Cantonment Traffic Inspector Sushil Kumar, his JDO (joint duty officer), and the sub-divisional in-charge at Vasant Vihar police station and sent them to the Police Lines.



Delhi LG Tarunjit Singh Sandhu and Chief Minister Rekha Gupta launch 200 new electric buses and 56 Ladies Special services in New Delhi on Wednesday. PRAVEEN KHANNA

LG, CM flag off 200 electric buses, launch 56 Ladies Special services

Express News Service
New Delhi, August 19

DELHI'S ELECTRIC bus fleet crossed the 5,000 mark on Wednesday with the induction of 200 new buses, as Lieutenant Governor (LG) Tarunjit Singh Sandhu and Chief Minister Rekha Gupta flagged off the buses at the Delhi University Sports Complex, officials said.

With the latest induction, Delhi's total bus fleet has reached around 6,800. The government on Wednesday also launched 56 women-only e-bus services, including services connecting DU colleges.

Gupta said the expansion of electric buses and women-only services was aimed at making public transport cleaner, safer and more convenient. "These initiatives would strengthen clean, green and sustainable public transport in the capital while also helping reduce vehicular pollution," Sandhu said.

The 200 new e-buses comprise 88 12-metre electric buses and 112 nine-metre Delhi EV Connector (DEV) buses, an official said. The government has set a target of expanding the fleet to around 14,000 buses by 2028-29, while converting all Delhi Transport Corporation (DTC) buses to electric vehicles.

The new buses were launched alongside a new Delhi-Karnal interstate electric bus service, dedicated Ladies Special services and a public EV charging station at DTC's Rajghat Depot L.

Officials said that 30 Ladies Special trips will operate on 15 high-demand routes, while 26 University Ladies Special (U-SPL) trips will run on 13 routes. The services will operate during peak hours in the morning and evening and will connect key employment, educational hubs, officials said.

The Ladies Special buses will have women police personnel and Home Guard marshals deployed on board and will be operated by women staff, an official said. Panic buttons installed in the buses have also been integrated with the Delhi Police's emergency response system, an official said.

public transport cleaner, safer and more convenient. "These initiatives would strengthen clean, green and sustainable public transport in the capital while also helping reduce vehicular pollution," Sandhu said.

The 200 new e-buses comprise 88 12-metre electric buses and 112 nine-metre Delhi EV Connector (DEV) buses, an official said. The government has set a target of expanding the fleet to around 14,000 buses by 2028-29, while converting all Delhi Transport Corporation (DTC) buses to electric vehicles.

The new buses were launched alongside a new Delhi-Karnal interstate electric bus service, dedicated Ladies Special services and a public EV charging station at DTC's Rajghat Depot L.

Officials said that 30 Ladies Special trips will operate on 15 high-demand routes, while 26 University Ladies Special (U-SPL) trips will run on 13 routes. The services will operate during peak hours in the morning and evening and will connect key employment, educational hubs, officials said.

The Ladies Special buses will have women police personnel and Home Guard marshals deployed on board and will be operated by women staff, an official said. Panic buttons installed in the buses have also been integrated with the Delhi Police's emergency response system, an official said.

FOUR INCOMPATIBLE DONOR-RECIPIENT PAIRS FROM NAGALAND, KASHMIR, PUNJAB AND BIHAR BECAME PART OF A MEDICAL CHAIN IN WHICH EACH DONOR GAVE A KIDNEY TO ANOTHER FAMILY'S LOVED ONE

8 strangers, 4 kidneys, 1 lifeline: How a four-way kidney swap overcame a legal hurdle

Tabshir Shams
New Delhi, August 19

THIS ONE sounds like a film script: Four families from four corners of India, who had never met, brought together by the same desperate hope — if they could not save their own, perhaps they could save each other's.

There was a family from Nagaland. Another from Kashmir. Yet another from Punjab. And the last from Bihar. Beyond different communities and faiths, they had a loved one, who needed a kidney transplant and was running out of time.

Each of the four patients also had a common trait: to donate one of their own kidneys to their loved one. But there was a problem.

The kidneys belonged to the wrong people. In each family, the willing donor was a near relative of the patient — the category of donor contemplated

under India's transplant law — but the two were biologically incompatible.

In several of the patients, the problem was not simply blood-group compatibility. Three of the four recipients were highly sensitised and had positive cross-match results, meaning their blood contained antibodies capable of attacking the cells of a particular donor.

The families had found a possible answer: Don't give the kidney to the person you love. Give it to someone else's loved one instead. Donor A would give to Recipient B. Donor B would give to Recipient C. Donor C would give to Recipient D. And Donor D would give to Recipient A. This was a cycle of strangers, each saving a family they had never met, in the hope that another stranger would do the same for theirs.

Kidney-swap transplantation is not new in India. The basic idea is relatively simple: when a willing donor cannot donate to their intended recipient because of biological incompatibility, another donor-recipient pair can enter the exchange. The two donors effectively swap kidneys.

The difficulty grows rapidly as more pairs are added. A transplant team has to establish not merely that each donor is compatible with somebody, but that the entire chain works. A kidney has to move in such a way that the chain closes.

Immunological testing is central to that process. Previous pregnancies, blood transfusions and transplants can all contribute to sensitisation. In a four-way exchange, there are many more possible combinations — and every link matters. "We have tried three-way swaps manually, but matching donors with unrelated recipients is very tedious

THE LEGAL JOURNEY How the court battle played out

1. AUTHORISATION COMMITTEE

Rejected the proposal. THOTA Act, Section 9(3A) — explicitly allows only a two-way (two-pair) swap.

2. APPELLATE AUTHORITY

Upheld the rejection.

3. DIRECTORATE GENERAL OF HEALTH SERVICES (DGHS)

Did not approve the proposal.

4. COMBINED SUPREME COURT

The four families filed a combined suit in the Delhi High Court.

5. DELHI HIGH COURT

Permitted the four-way kidney swap in this case. Waived the requirement for permission from the respective State Governments.

THE APPELLATE AUTHORITY

upheld that decision, taking the view that Section 9(3A) of the THOTA Act only contemplated an exchange between two incompatible donor-recipient pairs. A larger chain, the authorities held, would require an amendment to the law.

On May 26, 2026, the Delhi High Court set aside the orders

of the Authorisation Committee and the Appellate Authority and held that Section 9(3A) should not be read as restricting swap transplantation to two donor-recipient pairs. The references in the provision to a "first donor" and "second donor", it held, were illustrative of the mechanism rather than a statutory ceiling on the number of pairs.

There was, in other words, a gap between what the technology and medicine could make possible and what officials believed the wording of the law allowed.

On July 13, 2026, eight people — four donors and four recipients — got admitted at Max Super Speciality Hospital, Saket.

Eight operations were done in a choreographed chain: four donor nephrectomies, in which kidneys were removed from the living donors, and four

transplant operations. They were conducted simultaneously across five operating theatres, beginning at around 7 am and continuing until 7 pm.

The eight patients were kept sedated in rooms close to one another. As a kidney was removed from one donor, it was placed in an ice bowl and rushed to the adjoining operating room, where the compatible recipient was already waiting.

The next donor-recipient link was being prepared even as the previous transplant was taking place. There was no room for a break in the chain.

"Like in an army, responsibilities are divided man to man, post to post," Dr Kumar said. The High Court's order had waived the requirement for separate approvals from each patient's respective state government — a mandatory step under the usual process. "So,

we only had a day for the operation to be done," Dr Kumar said.

The risks were many. A donor could have withdrawn. A recipient could have developed a medical problem.

A delay in one operating theatre could have disrupted the sequence. And after the transplant, the chain would still not be over. Every recipient's immune system had to accept the new organ.

"If the kidney is rejected, then there could be issues — including a return to dialysis, or in the worst cases, loss of the transplanted organ altogether. Imagine Donor C develops an unexpected problem and cannot undergo nephrectomy. It potentially leaves the corresponding recipient without a kidney and breaks the chain involving the other families. But here all synced together," Dr Kumar added.

'Har Ghar Jal'

UP Government
Bringing Water to
Every Home

UTTAR PRADESH

LEADS THE NATION WITH HAR GHAR JAL

Under the Jal Jeevan Mission, the 'Har Ghar Jal' initiative has emerged as a transformative force for rural Uttar Pradesh. Under the visionary leadership of Chief Minister Yogi Adityanath, the state has made remarkable strides in expanding access to safe and reliable tap water, turning water security into a powerful catalyst for rural development and improved quality of life. Before 2019, only 1.97% of rural households in Uttar Pradesh had access to tap water. Today, coverage has risen dramatically to 91.99%, bringing the benefits of household tap connections to millions of families. More than 14.74 crore rural residents are now benefiting from the initiative. This remarkable transformation goes beyond infrastructure-it is reshaping everyday life by improving health, convenience, dignity and opportunities for rural communities.

Water for All, Prosperity for Every Village

Under the Leadership of Yogi Government, Jal Jeevan Mission Emerges as a Model of Rural Transformation



- 2.45 crore+ rural households with tap connections: Bringing functional household tap water closer to every family across Uttar Pradesh.
- 14.74 crore+ rural residents benefiting: Expanding access to safe, reliable drinking water.
- 27,650+ villages certified 'Har Ghar Jal': Ensuring verified tap connections and functional water supply.
- Less dependence on handpumps, wells & distant sources: Saving time, reducing effort and making rural life more convenient.

From Water to Health: Transforming Rural Lives

- Safe Water, Healthier Communities:** Reducing exposure to water-borne diseases and strengthening rural health.
- Water at the Doorstep, Opportunities for Women & Girls:** Saving time and opening doors to education, jobs, entrepreneurship and self-development.
- Better Water, Better Childhoods:** Improved facilities in schools and Anganwadi centres supporting hygiene, sanitation and healthier environments.
- Water with Dignity:** Reliable household water supply bringing greater convenience, dignity and social well-being to rural families.



Solar Power Driving a Greener Water Revolution

- 33,000+ water projects powered by solar energy: Bringing clean, sustainable power to rural water supply.
- Nearly 80% of drinking water projects solar-powered: Building a greener and more reliable water infrastructure.
- 900 MW of solar capacity: Accelerating the integration of renewable energy with essential public infrastructure.
- Solar-powered pumping: Reducing dependence on conventional electricity and improving operational efficiency.
- Water Security + Clean Energy + Environment: Building a greener, more resilient and sustainable rural water ecosystem.

Women as 'Jal Praharis' Guardians of Water Quality

- 4.80 lakh+ women trained in water testing: Creating a powerful, community-led network for safer drinking water.
- Women's groups in 97,000+ villages engaged: Using Field Testing Kits (FTKs) to strengthen grassroots water quality monitoring.
- 65,000+ water samples tested-Helping detect potential water: Quality concerns and enabling timely action.
- ₹20 per test, up to ₹400 honorarium: Turning water stewardship into an opportunity for income, skills and women's empowerment.

Water Brings Skills, Skills Bring Opportunities



- 8 lakh+ youth trained in technical skills: Building a skilled workforce for rural water infrastructure.
- Plumbing, electrical work, pump operation, fitting, masonry & motor mechanics: Equipping youth with job-ready, livelihood-oriented skills.
- 1.75 lakh+ masons | 1.66 lakh+ electricians | 1.16 lakh+ plumbers trained: Strengthening the skilled workforce at the grassroots.
- Local skills, local jobs, stronger villages: Trained manpower supporting operation, maintenance and repairs while giving a boost to the rural economy.

A New Milestone in
Uttar Pradesh's Water Revolution

5.20 lakh+

km of water pipelines-Building a vast rural water network and strengthening last-mile connectivity.



2.45 crore+

rural households with tap water-Bringing safe, reliable drinking water to families across villages.



5 lakh+

women trained in water testing
Empowering women as active partners in
community-led water management.

33,000+

water projects powered by solar energy
Driving green, sustainable water supply with nearly
900 MW of solar-powered capacity.

- A New Era of Har Ghar Jal in Vindhya-Bundelkhand Region:** Functional household tap connections have reached over 20.69 lakh families across 9 districts, ensuring access to safe and clean drinking water.
- Uttar Pradesh Secures 2nd Place in the 5th National Water Awards:** The state has been honoured with the Second Prize for its outstanding performance and effective implementation of the Jal Jeevan Mission.
- Safe Water, Healthy Communities-Under Stop Diarrhoea Campaign-2026:** Uttar Pradesh is strengthening awareness, water quality testing, sanitation and hygiene practices, while the Jal Jeevan Mission has ensured piped drinking water in 1,16,340 schools and 1,55,136 Anganwadi centres.
- Uttar Pradesh Shines at Jal Mahotsav 2026 -** Outstanding performers from 14 districts under the Jal Jeevan Mission were honoured at the national Mega Event; Rachna Devi of Chitrakoot was felicitated by the Hon'ble President, while Shri Devaswaroop Kunjbihari, VWSC Chairman, was honoured by the Hon'ble Union Minister of Jal Shakti for "Exemplary Financial Sustainability through User Charge Collection." New Delhi

Channi skips key Cong meeting for another MA exam

Man Aman Singh Chhina
Chandigarh, August 19

AT A time when the senior Congress leadership is busy dousing the organisational firestorms lit by Jalandhar MP Charanjit Singh Channi and his supporters in Punjab, the former Chief Minister is burning the midnight oil for an MA exam and skipped the CWC meet in New Delhi on Wednesday.

Channi is pursuing a masters degree in Public Administration from Punjab University, Chandigarh. One of the papers for the course is scheduled for Thursday, Channi, who had once declared himself a "lifelong student", did not go to the exam. He has two postgraduate degrees, one in business administration and another in political science, as well as a PhD in political science under his belt.

While he pursues another academic qualification, his absence at the meeting, attended by party chief Mallikarjun Kharge and LoP Rahul Gandhi, did not go unnoticed. This is the second time in recent weeks that he has skipped an event where Gandhi was to be present.



Meatless Row

A DAY after visuals of BJP national president Nitin Nabin enjoying traditional Andhra cuisine with the party's state leadership in Vizag snowballed into a controversy, with many accusing him of consuming non-vegetarian food in the holy month of Sawan, the party pulled out all the stops to take on the "fake narrative" on social media. The Chhattisgarh BJP's official handle put out a post insisting that the food item shown in the footage was actually a traditional raw jackfruit curry, a purely vegetarian dish.

Metro to Rescue

INDIAN YOUTH Congress (IYC) president Uday Bhunu Chib had a touch-and-go moment as he boarded a flight for Pune on Wednesday evening. Chib, who was to be present during the Congress Working Committee (CWC) meeting at Indira Bhawan, left for the airport around 4.30 pm for his 5.40 pm flight. He was headed to Pune to oversee preparations for Rahul Gandhi's Chhatron Ki Goonj protest in Gurgaon on August 22. After getting stuck in crawling traffic, Chib decided to take the metro to the airport and reached just minutes before boarding for the flight was closed.

Kharge: Hurt that not many in CWC condemned 'purification' ritual

Manoj CG
New Delhi, August 19

AT THE meeting of the Congress Working Committee (CWC) on Wednesday, party president Mallikarjun Kharge vented out a personal anguish. And he has done that rarely. He told those present that he was "hurt" that many of the CWC members did not openly come out in support of him on the 'purification' issue by condemning it.

Kharge was referring to a 'purification' ritual organised in Uttarakhand's Haldwani after his visit some days ago. The Congress had alleged that those who organised the 'shuddhikaran havan' were linked to the BJP and said it reflected a casteist mindset. The BJP, on the other hand, had distanced itself from the event. Kharge had raised the issue in Rajya Sabha as well. He said he had never asked anyone to protect him because he is a Dalit, but his 'purification' event made him feel humiliated.

At the CWC meeting,



AICC chief Mallikarjun Kharge with Congress leaders Sonia Gandhi, Rahul Gandhi, Priyanka Gandhi Vadra, K C Venugopal, Ambika Soni, Jairam Ramesh and others at the CWC meet on Wednesday. ANI

Kharge broached the topic. He said he felt "hurt" that all the CWC members and especially those "good-looking people" who get space in the media did not speak about it. AICC general secretary K C Venugopal said the party did raise the issue and condemned it, but Kharge's body language suggested, those present at the meeting said, he was far from convinced.

Kharge did not take any

names, and Congress leaders could only speculate who all he was referring to. In fact, the Congress president — again without taking names — pointed out that some leaders are prone to making comments and writing articles not in consonance with the party line. Briefing the media later on the deliberations in the CWC, Venugopal spoke about the 'purification' row, arguing that the

incident was "unacceptable" and "condemnable" and alleged that it reflected the mindset of the BJP.

The meeting also saw Kanhaiya Kumar, who is the AICC in-charge of the NSUI, talking about the Cockerroach Janta Party (CJP) and telling the leadership that the party should not cede political space to such groups. Sources said many in the party share Kumar's view. The party has so far maintained distance from the CJP even while supporting the student protests and linking it to the larger issue of jobs.

Without naming CJP, the resolution passed by the CWC noted that "sustained pressure from student groups and the united Opposition — both inside and outside Parliament — compelled the Education Minister to resign".

The meeting also saw Lok Sabha MP Shashi Tharoor pointing out that the word "bullying" used in the draft resolution in the context of US pressure on India should be substituted with some other

word. While Kharge and others are said to have argued the word bullying was not unparliamentary, the final resolution merely said, "The Congress Working Committee is deeply concerned that the Modi government is sacrificing India's agricultural and energy security, as well as its strategic sovereignty, in the face of American pressure."

Sources said Rahul Gandhi, in the context of the student and youth protests and his 'Chhatron Ki Goonj' campaign, reiterated that Prime Minister Narendra Modi was now India's past. Sources said he, however, did not agree with senior leader Manish Tewari's assessment that the last serious student movement was the anti-Mandal agitation in the 1990s, which led to 62 people immobilising themselves and more than 100 killed in police firing. Rahul said the 'Chhatron Ki Goonj' campaign was a very successful student movement.

The CWC resolution later said the 'Chhatron Ki Goonj' campaign was receiving an overwhelmingly positive response.

'Party above nation for Cong': BJP slams CWC's Vande Mataram stand

Express News Service
New Delhi, August 19

THE BJP on Wednesday condemned the Congress's resolution to sing only two stanzas of Vande Mataram, saying the "party was above the nation" for Congress members.

BJP national spokesperson Sudhanshu Trivedi accused the Congress of becoming the "new Muslim League" by insisting on the same demand that the Muslim League had made regarding the national song. He said that the Congress' decision also raised questions on its 'patriotism and loyalty' to the country. Trivedi stressed that the resolution passed in the Congress meeting on Wednesday was "extremely reprehensible".

"The Congress Working Committee's resolution seems more important to it than the powers granted by the Constitution and the laws made by Parliament. The Congress has also proven that it considers itself above the Constitution, above the country, and its party resolution above constitutional law."

Terming the Congress' decision "extremely condemnable", Trivedi said, "This decision has completely shattered its (the Congress') claim of being the self-proclaimed sole copyright holder of the freedom struggle." Trivedi said Congress had put an end to "speculation that it has become today's new Muslim League". "Because the same obstinacy that the Muslim League had in 1937 regarding Vande Mataram is the same obstinacy that the Congress is showing in 2026 regarding Vande Mataram," he posted on X.

"Instead of forgetting such a shameful chapter or rectifying the situation, the Congress has embraced it. It reveals the party's current state. There is no longer any doubt that its loyalty to the nation completely comes under suspicion," he said.

The Congress on Wednesday resolved that only the first two stanzas of Vande Mataram will be sung at all party events in future. The decisions were taken at a four-hour-long meeting of the Congress Working Committee (CWC).

Central Vista revamp: Future home of Budget Press likely at Kartavya Bhawan 9

Secure printing facility gained significance after a leak in 1956

Damini Nath
New Delhi, August 19

AS PART of the Central Vista redevelopment, the government is planning to set up the Budget Press, which is the secure printing facility where the annual Union Budget is printed, at the under-construction Kartavya Bhawan 9 building, where the Finance Ministry could shift upon completion, said officials. The Delhi Urban Art Commission in its meeting on July 16 approved a revised plan for the Kartavya Bhawan 8 and 9 project that includes a "Budget press added in the ground floor of Kartavya Bhawan 9", as per the minutes of the meeting. As part of the redevelopment project, 10 secretariat buildings named Kartavya Bhawan are being constructed along the Central Vista. KB 8 and 9 are under construction on the site of the old Vice-President's House and Vigyan Bhawan Annex, which have been demolished, on Maulana Azad Road.

The location of the press, which also signs the Economic Survey, gained significance after the Union Budget of 1956-1957 leaked from the printing press located at Rashtrapati Bhavan. It was then that the Finance Ministry decided that the Budget Press should be located within its own premises at North Block. Last year, when the Finance Ministry moved out of North Block into Kartavya Bhawan 1, the existing machinery could not be shifted due to space and weight con-

EXPRESS special



Officials said the Budget Press at North Block has been dismantled as the building is being renovated into a museum. FILE PHOTO

What happened in 1956

THE BUDGET Press was shifted to the basement of North Block after a leak of the Union Budget 1956-1957 from the press at Rashtrapati Bhavan. A case under the Official Secrets Act was lodged. The court proceedings show that the general foreman of the Rashtrapati Bhavan press, F X Jacobs, had leaked information about the taxation proposals in the Budget to a Delhi resident, D P Chadha, who further sold it to some Mumbai-based businessmen.

straints. On September 2, 2025, the Finance Ministry floated a tender for new, lighter printing machines to be fit into the space available at KB 1.

In the file notings, along with the tender document, the Ministry said: "Additionally, the load-bearing capacity of the floors, particularly on the ground level, was found to be inadequate for heavy-duty press machines such as paper-cutters and trimmers. These technical limitations necessitated a re-evaluation of the machinery options originally proposed."

The new press was still under trial at the time for the Union Budget 2026-2027 in February, leading to the Budget being printed in North Block, according to government sources.

The printing of the Budget is carried out under security cover,

with the officers concerned being "locked in" at the premises from the time the printing starts till the Finance Ministry presents the Budget in Parliament.

The Housing and Urban Affairs and Finance Ministries did not respond to emails requesting comment. However, officials in the ministries said the Budget Press at North Block has been dismantled as the building is being renovated into a museum, and the press at KB 1 has been installed. The officials said though the allotment of the space would be done when the building is complete, the Finance Ministry could move into KB 9, which is under construction at Maulana Azad Road. Keeping that in mind, the Central Public Works Department has designed the building to house the Budget Press, they said.

Cabinet clears major rail projects to decongest Howrah-Chennai line

Dheeraj Mishra
New Delhi, August 19

THE UNION Cabinet on Wednesday approved four railways multi-tracking, and one four lane high speed project worth Rs 13,041 crore.

The multi-tracking railway projects have been approved to decongest the high-density Howrah-Chennai route.

These include the 173-km Kharagpur-Bhadrak (Ranital) 4th Line in West Bengal and Odisha, the 75-km Bhadrak-Haridaspur 4th Line in Odisha, the 90-km Gummidipundi-Gudur 3rd and 4th Line in Andhra Pradesh and Tamil Nadu, and the 72-km Cuttack-Paradeep (Badabandha) 3rd and 4th line in Odisha.

These four projects together will cost around Rs 9,450 crore. Kharagpur-Ranital railway line is one of the main corridors connecting eastern and southern India. It carries long distance passengers and freight

traffic. Officials said the section is projected to remain saturated even after the commissioning of the third line, which has necessitated the construction of the fourth line as well.

The project links to the steel hubs at Jakhapura, Tatanagar and Durgapur with Paradip and Dhamra Ports for efficient movement of raw materials and finished goods.

Similarly, the existing Bhadrak-Haridaspur stretch in Odisha, presently at 91 per cent capacity, is expected to be near saturation from projected port and steel demand.

The Gummidipundi-Gudur section is an existing double line forming part of both the Delhi-Chennai and Howrah-Chennai High Density Network (HDN) routes. The section falls under the Vizag-Chennai Industrial Corridor and forms a key part of the planned East Coast Economic Corridor, India's first coastal corridor. The line capacity utilization is ex-

pected to reach 131%.

The fourth project, Cuttack-Badabandha, is a strategic corridor and part of the Jharuguda-Cuttack-Paradeep Highly Utilised Network (HUN).

It connects Paradeep Port to key hinterland areas of major steel clusters, iron ore mines and coal fields.

Officials said the existing section is saturated at up to 101% utilisation, and is projected to rise further to 177%.

The multi-tracking works will increase the existing network of Indian Railways by about 410 km and result in additional freight traffic by 76 million tonnes per annum (MTPA), said the Railways.

On Wednesday, the Cabinet also approved development of 4-lane broad gauge Muzaffarpur-Satnamahi-Sonbarsa Corridor (NH-22) in Bihar worth Rs 3,591 crore. This is expected to reduce the current travel time between Muzaffarpur to Sonbarsa from two hours to one.

Ministers get social media fame check, asked to engage more with Gen Z

Liz Mathew
New Delhi, August 19

UNION MINISTERS attending the Cabinet meeting on Wednesday were given an account of their social media engagements in the past two and a half months, sources said.

The analysis, which also included a comparison of their digital outreach and engagement on four social media platforms, advised the ministers to step up their activities on these platforms to reach out to a larger audience.

Sources said each minister was handed an envelope after the Cabinet meeting. The envelope contained details of their activities from May 1 to August 15, assessing their performances across X, Instagram, Facebook

and LinkedIn. The metrics used were the average daily posts, engagement per post, total likes, follower country and the overall traction each post had created, sources said. The level of traction created by the social media posts of political leaders, including those from the Opposition, was also compared.

Senior ministers Nirmala Sitharaman, S Jaishankar and Piyush Goyal were not present in Wednesday's Cabinet meeting. Sitharaman is leading a ministerial delegation with Jaishankar, Goyal and Minister of State Jitin Prasada to Singapore for high-level talks aimed at deepening economic ties with that country.

A source said the ministers get such performance analysis of their social media posts from

time to time. The source said the assessment is "meant to urge the ministers to scale up their digital outreach". The latest analysis assumes significance in the wake of Prime Minister Narendra Modi emphasising engagement with Gen Z on social media.

The ministers and other BJP leaders have been advised to increase their social media activity and focus more on engaging with the youth. Modi has urged BJP leaders, including the ministers and chief ministers, to utilise social media for reaching out to citizens directly and for promoting the Central government's welfare schemes. At the BJP-NDA chief ministers' conclave, an account of their activities on social media platforms is always a part of their performance analysis, sources said.

'HATE SPEECH' Arrest warrant against Mahua for skipping court summons



TMC MP Mahua Moitra

Ravik Bhattacharya
Kolkata, August 19

THE KRISHNANAGAR court on Wednesday ordered the immediate issuance of an arrest warrant against TMC MP Mahua Moitra for non-compliance with summonses in an alleged hate speech case. Meanwhile, Moitra said she would challenge the order in a higher court.

Noting that she had failed to appear despite repeated summonses, the 3rd Judicial Magistrate Court held in its order that the Krishnanagar MP showed "no respect for the court of law". The series of disobedience of the order of this court... goes to show the lackadaisical approach of the accused to comply with the court order and accordingly this court is left with no other option but to issue a warrant of arrest against her," the court said.

The Lok Sabha MP did not appear on at least four hearing dates — August 4, 12, 18 and 19. Moitra, however, has maintained that she wanted to be represented by her lawyer in court.

On June 17, a case was filed against Moitra at the Court of Chief Judicial Magistrate, Krishnanagar, on the complaint of Chaitra Nandi, also a resident of Krishnanagar. The complainant alleged that the Lok Sabha MP had made remarks against the Union Home Minister, Army personnel, and "certain religious beliefs and symbols revered by" the Hindu community.

'Make UP your second industrial home': Yogi to Japanese firms at investment meet

Express News Service
Lucknow, August 19

SIX MONTHS after he travelled to Japan with a high-level delegation to promote the state as a big ticket investment destination, Uttar Pradesh Chief Minister Yogi Adityanath on Wednesday exhorted Japanese business leaders to make the state their "second industrial home", calling for investments not only in manufacturing but also in research and development, green hydrogen, human resource development, tourism and governance as areas where Yamanashi and UP could collaborate.

Addressing the participating delegates during the inaugural session of the five-day UP-Japan Investment Meet 2026 in New Delhi, the CM said that robotics, precision engineering

and green manufacturing coupled with Japanese practices such as Kaizen and SS could help build an industry-ready workforce in UP.

Japan's strengths in precision, quality, technology and manufacturing could complement UP's young workforce, infrastructure and large market, he added.

Kotaro Nagasaki, Governor of Yamanashi Prefecture in Japan, who is leading the Japanese delegation, highlighted green hydrogen, human resource development, tourism and governance as areas where Yamanashi and UP could collaborate.

Adityanath said, "Japan is the land of the rising sun, while Uttar Pradesh is the land of Su-

ryavansh. India-Japan ties are a partnership of shared growth, technology and prosperity."

At the CEO-level discussions, Union ministers Ashwini Vaishnaw and Shivraj Singh Chauhan also urged Japanese companies to make large investments in the state. Describing Japan as a long-term development partner, Chauhan urged Japanese companies to combine their technology with UP's workforce, scale and market.

Kubota and Minda Corporation held a virtual ground-breaking ceremony for projects worth Rs 3,191 crore at the Yamuna Expressway Industrial Development Authority (YEIDA), which are likely to generate



Union Minister Ashwini Vaishnaw and Uttar Pradesh CM Yogi Adityanath with Yamanashi Prefecture governor Kotaro Nagasaki at the UP-Japan Investment Meet 2026 in Delhi on Wednesday. ANI

more than 10,000 jobs.

Officials said these projects could help create a larger Japan-

nese manufacturing and automotive supply chain in the state, bringing suppliers, ancil-

lary units, technology providers and skilled workers into the ecosystem.

Vaishnaw highlighted opportunities in infrastructure, manufacturing, electronics, semiconductors, railways, defence and agriculture, inviting Japanese companies to invest in India, particularly in UP.

As part of the state's long-term Japan strategy, the UP government proposed to build a 500-acre Japan City at YEIDA near Noida International Airport in Gautam Buddha Nagar district's Jewar to "create an integrated ecosystem" for Japanese companies, suppliers and ancillary industries.

"A Japan City will also be developed with all amenities just 3 kilometres from the Noida Inter-

national Airport where semiconductor and electronics manufacturing clusters as well as data centres are located nearby," CM Adityanath said, inviting Japanese firms to "build a long-term industrial ecosystem in UP, spanning manufacturing, semiconductors, clean energy, technology and skilling".

The state government also projected a "wider infrastructure network" as another advantage, including "17 operational airports, two dedicated freight corridors, metro connectivity in seven cities and more than 75,000 acres of industrial land bank".

Meanwhile, seeking to leverage the state's shared Buddhist heritage with Japan, the government has prepared a four-

day itinerary for the Japanese delegates to showcase cultural landscape and push for investments in tourism and wellness.

The delegation will start their UP tour on Thursday and will visit Agra, Lucknow, Varanasi and Buddhist heritage sites in Saranath. In Agra, they will be given a Brahmin welcome and visit the Taj Mahal before travelling to Lucknow, it is learnt.

Besides Saranath, UP is home to major Buddhist destinations like Kushinagar, Shravasti, Kapilvastu, Kaushambi and Sankisa. The recent announcement of Saranath's UNESCO World Heritage recognition has added fresh momentum to the state's effort to position its Buddhist circuit for international travellers, particularly from Japan.

New Delhi

Collectors in 6 border states, J&K, Ladakh get power to grant citizenship

Press Trust of India
New Delhi, August 19

THE UNION Home Ministry on Wednesday authorised District Collectors in Gujarat, Rajasthan, Punjab, West Bengal, Assam and Tripura (except tribal areas), and Union Territories of J&K and Ladakh to grant naturalised citizenship to "registered and proper" applicants ordinarily residing in these regions.

The government notified the Citizenship (Third Amendment) Rules 2026 on Wednesday, granting Collectors in these states and UTs the authority to process citizenship-seeking applications for "registered and proper" applicants ordinarily residing in these regions.

"The collector, on being satisfied with the suitability of the applicant, that he is a fit and proper person to be registered or naturalised, as the case may be, shall grant him the citizenship of India," the notified rules said. "The Collectors in these states will replace the 'Empowered Committees' and 'Designated Officers' that previously held these powers."

In the gazette notification, the Ministry of Home Affairs authorised the Collectors in these areas to "receive, scrutinise, and dispose of" such applications in accordance with the laid-down parameters.

The new rules apply to citizenship-seeking applicants residing in Gujarat, Rajasthan, Punjab, West Bengal, Assam, and Tripura, as well as the Union Territories of J&K and Ladakh. In Assam and Tripura, the rules specifically exclude tribal areas. The government has directed that all pending applications with these committees in the specified regions be immediately transferred to the relevant Collector.

STATE ORDERS FIRE-SAFETY AUDIT OF HOTELS & GUEST HOUSES; S.I.T. FORMED TO PROBE INCIDENT

5 Bangladeshis, one child among nine killed in Kolkata hotel fire

Ravik Bhattacharya
& Tanusree Bose
Kolkata, August 19

A FIRE AT a hotel in Central Kolkata in the early hours of Wednesday has claimed at least nine lives, including at least five Bangladeshis nationals. Most of the guests were asleep when smoke engulfed the hotel, suffocating nine persons including a child, the police said.

The fire broke out around 2 am on Wednesday at the Shikha Inn hotel located in a five-storey building on Free School Street in Central Kolkata. Officially known as Mirza Ghalib Street, the Free School Street area has several hotels catering especially to Bangladeshi nationals who often visit the city for medical treatment.

The incident comes close on the heels of a massive fire at a four-storey hotel in Tarapith in West Bengal's Birbhum district early on Monday, in which nine people died.

The state government has ordered a statewide fire-safety audit of hotels and guesthouses, while an SIT has also been formed to probe the incident.

Exit gates locked, no fire alarms

The police said that Wednesday morning's fire, believed to be caused by a short circuit, spread fast, making it difficult for the guests to escape. Police sources said the building also lacked proper firefighting systems.

Atiyar Rahman, a guest from Sakthira in Bangladesh, told *The Indian Express*, "There was no firefighting mechanism in the hotel. We woke up struggling to breathe in the smoke. We somehow managed to escape."

As the news of the fire



Rescue and police personnel arrive at the hotel in Kolkata on Wednesday. PARTHA PAUL

spread, five firefighting engines and the Disaster Management Department rushed to the spot.

Most of the guests had rushed to the hotel terrace for safety. There was an emergency exit but the gates were locked, and there were no fire alarms at the hotel, police sources said.

A fire services team used ladders to scale the building, get inside through the windows, and rescue people from the building. Over 60 people were rescued from the fire.

The fire personnel who rushed to the spot claimed dense black smoke in the building led to difficulty in visibility and breathing.

After prolonged and strenuous rescue efforts, the fire brigade and police personnel successfully rescued around 60 persons from the hotel and brought them to safety," said a senior officer of

Kolkata Police. "The fire-fighting and rescue operations continued for over 2 hours and were completed by 4.30 am. A police team remained deployed throughout the operation to ensure safe and effective coordination and crowd control," the officer said.

Nine people were rushed to Calcutta Medical College and Hospital, where they were declared dead. The police said the deceased included six men, two women, and a child.

Five of the deceased have been identified as Bangladeshi citizens — Akram Ali, Debashish Dutta, Afshana Shirmin and Swarnashish Dutta, all from the same family, apart from 37-year-old Babu Ahmed. Two others have been identified as Indian nationals — 19-year-old Sandip Paswan from Bihar, and Yog Narayan Aggarwal, 68, from Siliguri. The

identities of two other deceased are yet to be ascertained.

The cramped-up entrance of the Shikha Inn hotel is covered with boards with names of other hotels and lodges. Locals say that each floor of the five-storey building had around 5-6 hotels, with each hotel housing 4-5 tiny rooms.

Hardly any windows were visible in the hotel building, which is lined by iron staircases located at its backside.

The locals alleged that the owners had linked two buildings together, flouting all rules and regulations. The iron staircases also got heated up from the fire, making it difficult for the guests to escape.

proper permissions. Minister of State for Fire and Emergency Services, Koushik Chowdhury told mediapersons, "There are several hotels inside this building. I am shocked to see what was going on here..."

Chowdhury said the preliminary information pointed to a short circuit behind the fire, and that more details would be available after the forensic examination is conducted.

Municipal Affairs and Urban Development Minister, Agni-mitra Paul, also questioned the alleged flouting of rules by the building owners. Visiting the spot on Wednesday, Paul questioned how several air conditioners were operating and whether the electrical load caused the short circuit leading to the fire. She added that the Calcutta Electric Supply Corporation (CESC) should also take responsibility.

Meanwhile, a five-member Special Investigation Team (SIT) has been formed and it will be headed by Bhagrat Ghosh, Assistant Commissioner of Police (Adm), Detective Department, Kolkata. The police have filed a suo motu FIR in the case, under sections of the BNS relating to culpable homicide not amounting to murder, rash or negligent act that endangers human life or the personal safety of others, negligent or rash conduct involving fire or combustible matter, and certain sections under the Fire Service Act.

While the owner of the hotel, Bishwajit Mitra is absconding, his wife, Lipa Mitra told mediapersons, "My husband was there in the hotel till 10.30 pm last night. How this incident happened, we do not know. It has to be investigated. We have all the required licences and permits."



Relatives of people taken ill after drinking spurious liquor at Sir Takhtasinhji General Hospital in Gujarat's Bhavnagar. EXPRESS

4 dead, 8 critical after consuming spurious liquor in Gujarat

Brendan Dabhi
Ahmedabad, August 19

FOUR PERSONS have died and 18 others were hospitalised, eight of them in critical condition, in Gujarat's Bhavnagar district after consuming spurious liquor that had been illegally brought from Madhya Pradesh, police said.

Four bootleggers have been detained in this connection, they said, adding that the victims had consumed duplicate liquor of a popular Indian-Made Foreign Liquor (IMFL) brand. Gujarat is a 'dry' state where manufacturing, sale and consumption of alcohol are banned.

The first death was reported on Tuesday evening, another one in the night of the same day and two others died on Wednesday, police said.

Bhavnagar District Collector Manish Kumar Bansal on Wednesday said the spurious liquor affected at least 22 people.

While deaths of three persons — Kartik Makwana (40), Upendra Gohil (25), and Ghanashyam Jadhav (50) — have been confirmed due to consumption of spurious liquor,

the postmortem and toxicology reports of the fourth victim, identified as Narendra Yadav, are awaited, Bansal said. All the deceased are from Bhavnagar district.

Of the 18 people currently admitted to five hospitals including Sir Takhtasinhji General Hospital and four private hospitals, two remained in critical condition, four are in the Intensive Care Unit (ICU), two are on ventilator support and 10 others are in stable condition, the collector said.

In a video statement, Bansal said the district administration received information around 6 pm on Tuesday about a group of four persons falling ill after consuming illicit liquor during a party held at Kharkadi village in Ghogha taluka of the district on August 16. The collector said that one person from Surat was currently undergoing treatment there, while the person from Jamnagar is asymptomatic.

The same batch of spurious liquor was allegedly sold to several people across at least two talukas — Ghogha and Bhavnagar.

Bansal said that senior government doctors had been deputed at the private hospitals for supervision.

Railway police begins probe into 'custodial' death of Nigerian man

Express News Service
Surat, August 19

GOVERNMENT RAILWAY Police (GRP) on Wednesday initiated an inquiry into the alleged custodial death of a foreign national who died under suspicious circumstances after questioning by RPF officials at the Surat Railway Station.

While the man has been identified as a Nigerian national, the officials didn't disclose his name. He was travelling from Mumbai to Delhi on the Golden Temple Express before his detention at the Surat railway station.

He was detained and questioned after an alleged brawl with co-passengers when the train was near Vapi in Valsad, they added.

According to Surat GRP, a passenger complained to the railway helpline '139' on August 17 that a Nigerian national and another co-passenger were fighting over standing near one of the gates of the train.

The Nigerian national allegedly pushed a fire extinguisher on co-passengers during the scuffle, police sources said.

He was subsequently detained at Surat and taken for questioning at the RPF office, where he collapsed. He was rushed to SUMMER Hospital, where doctors declared him dead on arrival.

While the postmortem was held on August 18, its report was still awaited till Wednesday evening, the officials said.

Meanwhile, Surat GRP has registered a case of accidental death and started the probe. Western Railway Superintendent of Police Abhay Soni told *The Indian Express*, "After primary investigations, it is believed that the deceased was a Nigerian national. When Surat RPF caught him, he didn't have any of his identity cards with him. He lived in Valsad (Mumbai) and was arrested twice by Malvani and Malad police in Mumbai for drug (cocaine) trafficking cases in 2018."

2 months lost: NET retest disrupts aspirants' plans

Nirbhay Thakur
New Delhi, August 19

WHEN 26-YEAR-OLD Muneer Ahmad Kumar saw the name of prominent sociologist Govind Sadashiv Ghuray misspelt as "Ghurney" in his UGC-NET sociology question paper in June, he sensed something was wrong.

Vithika Sharma, 25, noticed similar errors in the same paper: Sociologist A.R. Desai's name was misspelled as "A.R. Desai", American philosopher Martha Nussbaum became 'Martha Nussaph'.

These were among several glaring errors which led the National Testing Agency (NTA) to announce on Sunday that it will re-conduct the UGC-NET examination for English, Commerce, and Sociology in September. The test determines eligibility for Junior Research Fellowships and assistant professor positions and is also used for admission to PhD programmes.

The agency had cited a slew of typographical errors and questions repeated from previous tests, stating that the papers did not meet the standards of a "fair and error-free



Clockwise from top left: UGC-NET aspirants Muneer Ahmad from J&K, Vithika and Rajni Panda from Rajasthan

examination". Several candidates affected by these developments whom *The Indian Express* spoke to said this has resulted in derailed plans and a short, anxiety-ridden window to prepare for the retest.

Muneer, who is from Jamnalu & Kashmir, said that his timeline is likely to be thrown into disarray and narrow his academic choices. "Had things gone as scheduled, I could have explored more options. A lot of PhD ad-

mission forms are going to be re-issued soon, and I'm afraid that I won't be able to apply to many places now. They are away two months of our time. Regathering ourselves to study again is not easy at all," he said, referring to this as a "traumatic experience". Utkarsh Kalra, 29, from Una in Himachal Pradesh, sees the retest not just as a delay, but as the potential loss of a major career opportunity. "After dedicating six years to preparing for

UPSC exams, I decided to build an academic career in Sociology," he said. He said he was aiming for an assistant professor's position in Himachal University.

"The application window for assistant professor vacancies in Himachal Pradesh, which was opened after four years, closes on the 25th. Because of the exam cancellation, I have essentially lost this major career opportunity. Even though I will appear for the re-exam, preparing everything from scratch in just 20 days is extremely difficult, especially when 70% of the paper demands pure rote learning," he said.

Aspirants also said that logistical issues have cropped up because of the lapse of two months since the now-scrapped exam. "Our circumstances have changed since the June examination," said Rajni Panda, 24. "I was in my hometown Jaipur during the exam, but I'm now working in another district, so travelling back to the earlier examination city will be difficult and expensive. Many students are facing similar situations due to jobs, studies and other commitments." She said she hoped

that the NTA would introduce an option to change examination centre cities to accommodate these challenges.

The NTA's decision to conduct the retest followed widespread complaints from candidates after the examination was conducted from June 22 to 30. A committee's findings confirmed that the three papers contained many factual, typographical, and translation errors.

Many students questioned why the NTA took so long to announce retest. Vithika, who is from Rajasthan's Kota, said, "Anyone who had studied Sociology could have identified the errors in one go." "There were a lot of spelling mistakes. 'Social' was written as 'Oval', 'Martha Nussbaum' became 'Martha Nussaph', she said. "No one even cared to proofread," she added.

A student from Punjab who will be re-appearing in the English UGC-NET, said: "It is frustrating, but what other option do we have? We were relieved after the exam, but now the entire cycle starts again."

FULL REPORT ON
WWW.INDIANEXPRESS.COM

CBI arrests I&B Ministry officer for accepting Rs 10 lakh bribe

Express News Service
New Delhi, August 19

THE CBI HAS arrested a Deputy Controller of Accounts, posted with the Union Ministry of Information and Broadcasting, in a Rs 10 lakh bribery case, a spokesperson from the central agency said on Wednesday.

The spokesperson said that the CBI registered a case on August 18 against Sandeep, based on a written complaint from one Rameek Sharma, who is the associate vice president of Avian Media Pvt Ltd.

He told the CBI that he contacted Choudhary on August 14 regarding the renewal of a contract, when Choudhary allegedly demanded Rs 15 lakh. Following negotiations, he allegedly agreed to accept Rs 10 lakh to expedite the processing of the renewal file.

"The CBI laid a trap on Tuesday and caught Choudhary accepting the bribe amount through his wife," the spokesperson said.

● MAHARASHTRA DOUBLES REHABILITATION GRANT TO RS 50,000, EXTENDS SCHEME TO THOSE ACQUITTED AFTER SPENDING AT LEAST A YEAR IN CUSTODY

After jail, a laptop or poultry farm: For freed prisoners, a chance to start again

Sadaf Modak
Mumbai, August 19

WHEN THE 44-year-old walked out of Kolhapur Central Jail in 2022 after nearly two decades in prison, he had a BA in History, a master's in History and Sociology and a plan to study law. He did not have a laptop.

A Maharashtra government grant meant for released prisoners gave him Rs 25,000. He borrowed another Rs 5,000 and bought a secondhand one. Today he works as a legal assistant at a private firm in Mumbai. The man, who was convicted in a murder case, did not want to be identified.

From August 18, the grant that helped him take that first step was twice as much.

A Government Resolution is

sued by the Maharashtra Women and Child Development (WCD) department on August 18 has raised the grant-in-aid for released prisoners from Rs 25,000 to Rs 50,000. The scheme will also, for the first time, cover people acquitted after spending at least a year in custody in addition to convicts and probationers under the Maharashtra Probation of Offenders Act, 1958. The increased grant applies to those released on or after August 18. The state Cabinet had cleared the proposal on July 14, and the GR states that the scheme will be reviewed every three years at the level of the Commissioner, WCD Pune.

What the money buys is small and specified. A sewing machine, carpentry tools, the set-up for a poultry farm, a secondhand laptop.

A 45-year-old farmer from

Palghar, released in 2025 after nearly a decade in prison, received Rs 25,000 in June and put it into hens. He too did not want to be identified. "I purchased coops and some feed for the hen and a small flock of about 40 hens. I am currently earning but with the set up now complete, I will seek a loan from elsewhere and buy a larger flock," he said.

A woman who spent more than five years in prison used the money to start a clothes business. Another beneficiary set up a paan shop.

Mumbai had been planning for the grant since well before his release. He was in the second year of his BA when he was arrested in 2005 in a murder case, convicted a year later and sentenced to life imprisonment. "I



The 44-year-old from Mumbai had been planning for the grant since well before his release. He was in the second year of his BA when he was arrested in 2005 in a murder case. AMIT CHAKRABARTY

did not want to spend the rest of my life defined by one mistake," he said.

In 2007, he enrolled for a degree through Yashwantrao Chavan Maharashtra Open University and topped the course with

a distinction. A master's followed, then law. Inside prison he worked first in the hospital and later in the superintendent's office, where officials noticed his handwriting and began asking him to fill in forms for

other prisoners. That was where he heard about the government's grant. "Many spoke of seeking the aid for setting up a small grocery shop, or start work as a carpenter, or tailor. I had decided then that I will apply for it on my release," he said.

After his release, the Mumbai suburban district probation officer and Chandrakant Shinde, a social worker with Prayas, a field action project of the Tata Institute of Social Sciences, helped him apply. The NGO also helped him enrol in a law course at a city college.

In 2017, the Bombay High Court directed the state to raise the allocation to at least Rs 2 crore. The budget went up to Rs 1 crore in 2020, with another crore available if required. Officials said actual spending has been around Rs 1.20 crore, benefiting up to about 480 people a year. Beneficiaries said the earlier Rs 25,000 was a start, and that any increase was welcome for more sustainable funding. Dr Vijay Raghavan, project director of Prayas, said Maharashtra was among the few states with a scheme for released prisoners. "Such a scheme recognises the state's responsibility towards reintegration into society and rehabilitation of a population, who face stigma and challenges in getting employment," he said.

The Justice Radhakrishnan Committee on Prison Reforms, set up by the state on High Court orders, recommended in 2018 that the grant be allowed to cover a wider range of rehabilitation needs, including housing, household goods, education, training and skill development.

In 2017, the Bombay High Court directed the state to raise the allocation to at least Rs 2 crore. The budget went up to Rs 1 crore in 2020, with another crore available if required. Officials said actual spending has been around Rs 1.20 crore, benefiting up to about 480 people a year. Beneficiaries said the earlier Rs 25,000 was a start, and that any increase was welcome for more sustainable funding. Dr Vijay Raghavan, project director of Prayas, said Maharashtra was among the few states with a scheme for released prisoners. "Such a scheme recognises the state's responsibility towards reintegration into society and rehabilitation of a population, who face stigma and challenges in getting employment," he said.

The Justice Radhakrishnan Committee on Prison Reforms, set up by the state on High Court orders, recommended in 2018 that the grant be allowed to cover a wider range of rehabilitation needs, including housing, household goods, education, training and skill development.



GenH

युवा उद्यमी चौपाल

Dream Beyond Boundaries

Chief Guest

Sh. Nayab Singh Saini

Chief Minister, Haryana

August 21, 2026 **10:00 AM**

Gurugram University

Encouragement to Haryana's Youth under Vision - 2047

Target to increase per capita income from 3 Lakh 96 Thousand per year (currently) to 40 Lakh per year

Aim to provide employment to 50 Lakh youth

Target to provide skill training to 2 Lakh youth, and AI skill training to 50 Thousand youth

In Haryana, 11,900 start-ups have been launched by youth with 50% women participation

Today, achievements have reached new heights and Tomorrow's goals are boundless



“Today, India is among the world's leading StartUp destinations and many of these success stories are being scripted by our Yuva Shakti.”

- Narendra Modi



Scan the QR code to register

On this occasion

Yuva Udyamita Yatra will be launched

21 August – 11 December, 2026

Giving wings to Haryana's Youth



Information, Public Relations & Languages Department, Haryana

www.prharyana.gov.in | Follow us on @diprharyana

@ieExplained

#ExpressExplained

If there are questions of current or contemporary relevance that you would like explained, please write to explained@indianexpress.com

TECH

Chatbots & teen safety: The limits of ChatGPT's new guardrails

Soumyendra Barik
New Delhi, August 19

OPENAI is rolling out a separate version of ChatGPT for teenagers, with tighter restrictions on conversations around self-harm, suicide, eating disorders and sexual content as concerns grow over the impact AI chatbots can have on younger users. The move comes amid mounting scrutiny of AI companies over cases where teenagers who died by suicide had extensively interacted with chatbots before their deaths.

AI chatbots and teens

A number of cases have opened the debate around AI chatbots because they work differently from conventional social media platforms. AI chatbots are programmed to be agreeable companions to validate users' feelings. But this unchecked validation can intensify suicidal behaviors and self-mutilation among vulnerable children confiding their deepest fears.

One of the most closely watched cases involves 16-year-old Adam Raine, whose parents sued OpenAI last year. They alleged that ChatGPT had validated his suicidal thoughts and discussed methods of self-harm before his death in April 2025. OpenAI acknowledged that some of its safety protections could become less reliable over the course of long conversations.

This year, Character.AI and Google agreed to settle a lawsuit filed by the mother of 14-year-old, who died by suicide in 2024 after extensively interacting with a Character.AI chatbot.

His mother alleged that he had developed an intense emotional attachment to the bot. Experts warn that children's developing brains make them particularly vulnerable to AI systems that create dopamine responses.

ChatGPT for teens

OpenAI plans to place users it identifies as being under 18 into a more restricted ChatGPT experience. The company says the teen version will avoid romantic or sexual conversations, place stronger limits around self-harm-related content and discourage the chatbot from presenting itself as conscious or emotionally attached to the user. Parents will also be able to link their accounts, set usage restrictions and receive alerts in certain situations. OpenAI will use a *curator* to estimate whether a user could be under 18. These include how an account is used, the subjects discussed and how long the account has existed. ChatGPT can automatically place the account under the teen safeguards even if a different age was entered while signing up. But age-detection systems are not foolproof, and several parental controls depend on families opting in. The teen version is therefore an attempt to reduce some of the risks emerging around AI companionship, rather than a complete fix for them. Last year, OpenAI introduced parental controls, though critics quickly demonstrated these could be easily bypassed.

Drishti IAS

IAS GS Foundation Course (Offline & Live Online Batches)

Centre	English Medium	English Medium
9 New Delhi	20 Aug 11:30 AM	26 Aug 11:30 AM
9 New Delhi	17 Aug 11:30 AM	24 Aug 11:30 AM
9 Indore	24 Aug 11:30 AM	18 Aug 11:30 AM
9 Lucknow	20 Aug 11:30 AM	20 Aug 11:30 AM
9 Prayagraj	18 Aug 11:30 AM	24 Aug 11:30 AM
9 Ranchi	12 Aug 11:30 AM	20 Aug 11:30 AM
9 Patna	17 Aug 11:30 AM	4 Sept 8:00 AM
9 Jaipur	21 Aug 11:30 AM	11 Aug 5:00 PM
9 Bhopal	21 Aug 11:30 AM	21 Aug 11:30 AM

Drishhti IAS

Call Us: 87501 87501

LEGAL

Dignity in death: Debate over 'humane' execution



AMAAAL SHEIKH & ARAV SHAH

CAN a method of execution devised in colonial India still satisfy the Constitution's promise of dignity? The Supreme Court on Tuesday said it can, at least on the material currently before it. The bench dismissed a PIL that argued the method is scientifically unreliable and violates the right to a dignified death under Article 21 of the Constitution.

The court held that the challenge ran into two hurdles — the 1983 precedent of *Deena vs. Union of India* in which a three-judge bench upheld hanging as a Constitutional mode of execution, and Parliament's decision to retain hanging while enacting the Bharatiya Nagarik Suraksha Sanhita (BNSS).

The method

In India, hanging is the prescribed method of executing death sentences and is a part of British Common Law. Historically, hanging was carried out through the "short drop" method. As the name suggests, it's a short drop that causes asphyxiation.

Today, modern executions rely on the long-drop method. The longer drop is meant to immediately snap the second and third cervical vertebrae (C2 and C3) and, thus, the spinal cord. This is meant to instantly render the individual unconscious. But the length of the drop must be calibrated to the individual's weight and height. A drop that is too short can fail to break the neck and result in prolonged strangulation. Conversely, a drop that is too long can risk decapitating the person.

Standard prison protocols dictate that the body be left hanging for 30 minutes after the trap door opens.

The challenge

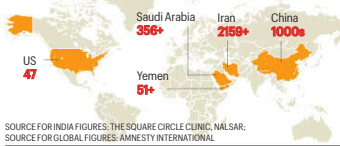
The petition sought a declaration that the provision prescribing hanging was unconstitutional and argued that Article 21 includes a right to die through a dignified procedure. They said the method is "accompanied by intense physical torture and

CAPITAL PUNISHMENT IN INDIA....



...AND THE WORLD

The following are the countries that recorded the most executions in 2025



SOURCE FOR INDIA FIGURES: THE SQUARE CIRCLE CLINIC, NALSAR; SOURCE FOR GLOBAL FIGURES: AMNESTY INTERNATIONAL

pain," and inherently unpredictable.

They cited a 1992 study that remains of 34 people hanged in England between 1882 and 1945. Fractures at C2-C3 were common, but the "hangman's fracture" — assumed to cause near-instant death — showed up in only three of the 34 cases; six died of asphyxiation instead. They said this made hanging neither quick nor controllable.

Anup Surendranath, Executive Director of The Square Circle Clinic at NALSAR University of Law — formerly Project 39A, which intervened in the proceedings — told *The Indian Express* that the studies placed before the court raised broader concerns about the assumptions underlying hanging as a mode of execution. Surendranath said researchers who examined the remains of executed prisoners found that "people had not died by this instant breaking of the neck. Instead there were a whole host of other very painful, long-drawn suffering reasons that had caused their death".

The jurisprudence

Section 393(5) of the BNSS provides that where a person is sentenced to death, "the sentence shall direct that he be hanged by

the neck till he is dead". The clause, which has barely changed since it was introduced in the CrPc in 1861, has survived multiple amendments and now appears in the BNSS.

The right to die with dignity flows from the right to life guaranteed under Article 21 of the Constitution. The Supreme Court in *Glan Kaur v State of Punjab* (1996) held that the right to life includes the right to live and consequently to die with dignity.

The Supreme Court in *Deena vs. Union of India* (1983), upheld the constitutional validity of hanging after examining medical evidence, expert opinion, and comparative execution methods. The court held that hanging, when properly administered, is a quick and certain method of execution and does not violate Article 21. It said that the process causes no greater pain than any other known method and avoids "barbarity, torture and degradation".

Why top court upheld hanging

The Union government maintains that hanging remains the "safest and quickest" method of execution. It said that no botched execution has ever been recorded in India, while lethal injection in the US carries a well-documented history of failures.

The bench found no reason to revisit *Deena*. It noted that the petitioners had placed scientific material before the court but held that the material did not displace the basis on which *Deena* had been decided. Nor did it establish that lethal injection, electrocution, lethal gas or shooting offered an advantage over hanging.

It referred to the reasoning in *Deena*, where hanging through the long-drop method was described as a process intended to bring about immediate unconsciousness through cervical fracture. The court said the existing method continues to satisfy the State's obligation to carry out a death sentence with "decency and decorum" and without "degradation or brutality".

While dismissing the petition, the bench stopped short of treating the issue as closed forever. It observed that Constitutional law evolves and that future challenges could arise if new scientific, medical or empirical material fundamentally alters the assumptions on which *Deena* was decided. It also left it open to the Union government to examine alternative methods

SC has upheld validity of execution by hanging. What does the law say about the right to die with dignity, and how do other countries carry out executions?

of execution, should it choose to do so.

Modern execution methods

More than two-thirds of the world's nations — around 113 — have ended the death penalty in law or practice, according to Amnesty International. Yet, a 2025 report by the non-profit showed a 12% increase in executions compared to the previous year.

The search for a humane method of execution has led to varied practices, each carrying its own scientific and ethical controversies. Hanging remains one of the more widely authorised methods of execution, particularly in countries influenced by British Common Law, including India, Singapore and Japan. A 2012 Cornell Law School database identified 60 countries that authorised hanging as a method of execution. Other prevalent methods are

Lethal injection: This is the primary method in several US states where the death penalty is allowed and heavily utilised in China. In this method, a sequence of drugs is administered to a convict — an anesthetic, a paralytic and finally potassium chloride. The procedures can often get botched owing to compromised venous access.

Shooting: This is used in North Korea, Somalia and parts of West Asia. A 2012 Cornell Law School database identified 60 countries that authorised hanging as a method of execution. Other prevalent methods are

Beheading: Saudi Arabia carries out executions by beheading with a sword. It is reliant on the executioner's precision.

Nitrogen hypoxia: A recently introduced method in the US involving the inhalation of pure nitrogen gas. It is designed to cause asphyxiation without triggering the hypercapnic alarm response — that panicked feeling of suffocation. Critics argue it has not been sufficiently vetted and amounts to human experimentation.

The legal debate over methods of execution is largely between how state power and human rights intersect. Reformists argue hanging can take too much time if there are any errors, constituting cruel and inhuman treatment. But while capital punishment remains in use, finding an execution method that balances the finality of state action with the dignity of the individual will remain a difficult question.

POLITY

How India plans to count caste now, what went wrong earlier

Vikas Pathak
New Delhi, August 19

WITH THE Registrar General of India deciding to use an "open-ended question on caste" for the ongoing census to enumerate castes, the lack of a predetermined list of castes means it will be up to the respondent to mention his or her caste to the enumerator.

"If you identify your caste by your surname, the census official will be duty-bound to include it as your caste. If the misspells your surname, that too will become an entry in the caste column," a senior IAS officer told *The Indian Express* on condition of anonymity.

It is likely to throw a plethora of entries pertaining to what may be a single caste. For instance, Rajput, Thakur, Singh, and Kshatriya may be used interchangeably by a respondent. However, Rajput in Bundelkhand region cutting through Uttar Pradesh and Madhya Pradesh may also mean the Other Backward Class Lodhi community, and Singh is a surname cutting across castes and categories.

Until the 1931 Census, when the data of the last census that enumerated castes were released, the colonial state had also used the same method. The 1931 Census report shows the problems faced in enumerating caste, as

it became an extremely subjective category.

The 1931 Census

In the 1931 Census report, there were instances of caste groups clubbing themselves as one caste, or sometimes even imagining a new category to define themselves.

Sections of the leather working caste among Dalits in Punjab decided to assume a new religious identity of Aad Dharmis, meaning people who belonged to the "original", "pre-Aryan" religion of India. As many as 418,789, roughly the same number as Christians in Punjab at that time, enumerated themselves as Aad Dharmis, a category that did not exist in 1921. The same trend was noticed in other regions too, with names like Adi Dravida, Adi Andhras, and Adi Karnatakas coming up.

The 1931 Census also offered examples of multiple castes consolidating into a single caste for bolstering their numbers or claiming a new social status. "The best instance of such a tendency to consolidate a number of castes into one group is to be found in the grazier castes which aim at combining under the term 'Yadava' the Ahirs, Goals, Gopis, Idaiyans and perhaps some other castes of milkmen, a movement already effective in 1921," the report said.

What the numbers say

- The Ministry of Social Justice and Empowerment lists 1,208 Scheduled Castes, with different castes being in the category in different states.
- A Press Information Bureau year-end press release of 2022 lists exactly 730 Scheduled Tribes.

What happened after

In the 1941 Census, though caste details were collected, caste was dropped from the final tabulation. In the 1951 Census, in a newly independent India shaped by the ideals of equality and secularism, the government led by Jawaharlal Nehru decided there would be no caste enumeration.

The 2011 exercise of the UPA government failed to produce usable caste data because of the problem of open-ended enumeration. The final dataset contained nearly 46.7 lakh distinct caste names, compared with the 4,147 castes recorded in the last comprehensive caste census in 1931. The Union government eventually withheld the raw caste data.

In 2023, then Bihar Chief Minister Nitish Kumar ordered a statewide caste survey. An IAS officer aware of the exercise told *The Indian Express* that the state officials had compiled a list of castes for the purpose, as not having a list would create an administrative nightmare. After the survey data came out, questions were raised regarding the way the lists were prepared and methodology.

The solution

Former Indian Council of Social Science Research chairman S K Thorat, who was a

member of the expert committee to write a report on the caste data in Telangana, told *The Indian Express* that a predetermined list was necessary.

"There are already SC, ST and OBC lists recognised by the government. All we need is a similar list of castes in the general category, and we will then have an exhaustive list," he said. "It may still have a small margin of error, maybe 2-3%, but that will actually minimise the error, rather than going for open-ended caste enumeration."

He added that there can also be columns for "no caste" and "no religion" for people not identifying with these.

Thorat also suggested that separate questionnaires be prepared for effective data focusing on the separate exclusions faced by the Scheduled Castes (untouchability related) and Scheduled Tribes (physical and geographical isolation). He underlined that such a questionnaire for the OBCs was not required, as social and educational backwardness would anyway be captured by the census exercise.

"There should also be questions on the hierarchies and exclusions within the SCs and STs, as some castes are more deprived than others," said O P Shukla, a Valmiki activist who has been raising his voice for sub-categorisation of the SCs.

GLOBAL

From scientific research to geopolitics: Why India needs a clear 'Arctic narrative'



EXPERT EXPLAINS

CAPT. ANURAG BISEN (RETD)

VETERAN SUBMARINER AND SENIOR FELLOW, VIVEKANANDA INTERNATIONAL FOUNDATION

INDIA HAS long viewed its engagement with the Arctic through the lens of scientific research. But the Arctic is evolving into a hub where climate change and geopolitics converge. Now, a report by the Parliamentary Standing Committee on External Affairs, titled "India's Role and Presence in the Arctic and Antarctic Regions", asks: What is India's narrative on the Arctic?

Few realise that India, as part of the British Dominion, was among the original 14 signatories of the 1920 Svalbard Treaty, which entitles an Indian to visit Svalbard — an

archipelago located between mainland Norway and the North Pole — without a visa and to engage in commercial ventures.

Today, India remains one of only two developing countries with a permanent scientific presence in the region, through the Himadri research station in Ny-Ålesund, Svalbard. The report, however, highlights a concerning gap between India's ambitions and its capabilities.

The Indian narrative

The first pillar of such a narrative must be climate security. India's dependence on the monsoon remains profound. Agriculture still accounts for roughly 18% of its gross domestic product and supports more than half of its population. Nearly 70% of India's annual rainfall comes from the southwest monsoon.

Scientific studies increasingly point to an Arctic-Indian monsoon teleconnection. Rapid Arctic warming and declining sea ice alter atmospheric circulation patterns that influence monsoon behaviour across South Asia, affecting rainfall patterns, agricultural productivity, food security and



The Svalbard archipelago, where India's Himadri research station is located.

WIKIMEDIA COMMONS

economic growth in India.

Second, the Arctic is a major contributor to global sea-level rise. If current trends continue, entire low-lying island states — such as the Maldives — face existential threats. Large parts of Bangladesh and significant stretches of India's coastline could

experience recurrent flooding and displacement. By some estimates, more than 250 million people living in vulnerable coastal regions of South Asia could be affected by mid-century.

For India, this is not merely an environmental issue. Large-scale climate-induced migration from neighbouring regions could create unprecedented humanitarian, social and security challenges.

Geopolitical importance

Two of India's closest strategic partners, the US and Russia, are Arctic nations. China, India's principal long-term adversary, has invested heavily in Arctic infrastructure, research and shipping despite being an extra-regional state.

The Arctic is increasingly emerging as a battleground for major powers, with maritime access, energy security, and critical mineral supply chains intersecting. India also maintains friendly relations with other Arctic nations, as was evident in the recent India-Nordic Summit. The question is whether India is prepared to engage at a scale commensurate with its interests.

In terms of engagement, India's present challenge is structural: responsibility for Arctic affairs is fragmented across multiple divisions within the Ministry of External Affairs. The Arctic states and Arctic Council-related matters are handled by four different territorial and functional divisions, making a coherent whole-of-government Arctic engagement difficult.

India, despite having an Arctic Policy since 2022, still lacks a dedicated senior official responsible for Arctic affairs.

Polar Research Vessel

Without an ice-class research vessel, India's scientific footprint in the Arctic remains largely confined to Svalbard. Access to the wider Arctic Ocean depends on the collaboration with foreign partners and on the availability of icebreakers.

The committee notes that India needs a dedicated Polar Research Vessel (PRV) to undertake meaningful pan-Arctic research. An indigenous PRV, despite being sanctioned in 2014, is expected to be delivered only towards the end of this decade. Meanwhile, China offers an example it

acquired a second-hand icebreaker from Ukraine and developed indigenous capability. Today, it operates several polar-capable vessels and is the second country after Russia to be building a nuclear icebreaker.

Shortfall in funding

The report's most striking revelation concerns funding. India spent just Rs 17.53 crore on Arctic activities in 2024-25: less than one-tenth of its expenditure on Antarctica and less than the cost of building a kilometre of a flyover. For a region that affects sea-level rise along India's 11,098-km coastline and is a climate and geopolitical hotspot, the figure appears apologetic.

On the mismatch between interests and investments, the Committee effectively asks: If the Arctic is important enough to warrant a national policy, why not a parliamentary study, and repeated diplomatic engagement with Arctic states, why does India's budgetary commitment suggest otherwise?

India needs a coherent Arctic narrative. The Arctic Policy provided the framework. The Parliamentary panel identified gaps. Now, policy must translate into capability.

'My house helps' experience, and a question: How can reservation go when caste hasn't? — By Kumar Kartikya
Log on to www.indianexpress.com



The Editorial Page

THURSDAY, AUGUST 20, 2026

Disobedience is the true foundation of liberty. The obedient must be slaves.
— Henry David Thoreau

The Indian EXPRESS
— FOUNDED BY —
RAMNATH GOENKA
— IN 1932 —

BECAUSE THE TRUTH INVOLVES US ALL

Cancel with caution, livelihoods are at stake

THE PROTESTS against compromised public examinations in Jharkhand, on since late July, brought the Hemant Soren government to the negotiating table almost immediately. Nearly all their demands have been met. To be sure, Jharkhand, like many other states, needs to do much more to ensure the integrity of its public examination system. In fact, governments across the country must confront the crises of education and employment that have given these tests outsized importance. But the blanket cancellation of appointments, while it helps the government under pressure to appear responsive, can also be a slippery slope. It skirts vital distinctions and short-circuits due process. It can end up doing injustice to those who competed in good faith and cleared the exam fairly. Overnight, the 2,000 individuals appointed after clearing the Jharkhand Staff Selection Commission-Combined Graduate Level (JSSC-CGL) examination found themselves without employment.

Those who cleared the exam had already suffered from the unconscionable delays. Recruitment for JSSC-CGL posts began with a notification in 2016-16. In 2024, the Jharkhand High Court ordered that status quo be maintained amid allegations of a paper leak. In December 2025, the court lifted the stay and asked the government to appoint successful candidates. Now, those candidates are in limbo, facing uncertainty, a growing group of protesters. Outside Jharkhand Mandla, Vikas Kumar Sharma told this newspaper, "Never in our wildest dreams did we imagine that the office where we worked in the morning would have us standing outside its gates by evening... as protesters."

Even before the protests, the state's public service commission had cancelled the state Public Service Commission exam, ordered a CID probe and arrested a director of TSR Data Processing Private Limited (TDPL) — all exams conducted by TDPL stand cancelled. The cancellation of exams that have undergone judicial scrutiny is arguably a blunt instrument that scores political points without addressing the deeper issues that have to do with dysfunctional systems and dwindling employment. It is the government's responsibility to ensure that those who got jobs after stringent tests, through a process that was upheld by the court, are not discriminated against. Due process and the credibility of the testing system are at stake. For the protesters, too, the current moment calls for a pause. From Jantar Mantar in Delhi to Jaipal Singh Mundia Stadium in Ranchi, it has been an arduous journey, in the course of which the young and those left behind have demanded accountability and reform. They have pushed the powerful to listen. This momentum must lead to meaningful reform. It would be tragic if it is frittered away.

ChatGPT for Teens is step forward. It's not enough

FOR A generation of digital natives growing up on smartphones and social media, Artificial Intelligence (AI) is not what lies in the future. It is becoming a part of the texture of the everyday. A sounding board for curiosity, a companion that shapes how they learn, communicate and seek reassurance. Which is why OpenAI's ChatGPT for teens, which introduces tighter safeguards around self-harm, violence, eating disorders and content, along with parental controls, safety alerts and other regulatory features, is a welcome, if overdue, intervention. The new launch acknowledges what Big Tech has consistently, and often willfully, chosen to glide over — that young users are a distinct category in need of specialised and empathetic attention. For them, the dangers of AI are formidable. It is highly responsive, anthropomorphic, and adept at mimicking empathy. For adolescents still developing judgement and a sense of self, that combination often proves to be pernicious.

ChatGPT for teens comes amid lawsuits in the US alleging that the chatbot contributed to suicides of teenagers, and a US Federal Trade Commission investigation into seven AI companies, including OpenAI, over the effects of their products on children. Meta is currently facing a trial in the US on the ground of deliberately designing Facebook and Instagram to exploit young users' vulnerabilities and making its platforms addictive. Across the world, there is a pushback against the unchecked rollout of AI services to children. China has moved to restrict AI systems that encourage emotional dependence; India relies on a patchwork of laws, regulations and platform-led interventions.

There is no putting AI back in the box. The challenge is to ensure that as its use becomes inevitable, it does not come at the expense of young people's well-being. The safeguards announced by OpenAI are not foolproof. Age prediction is still an estimate, children can misrepresent their age, and content restrictions are only as effective as their enforcement. What is needed is independent testing, greater transparency and independent scrutiny alongside better digital literacy and sensitisation. The fact that these protections have been implemented in the first place is a reminder that children's online safety cannot be left to Big Tech alone. ChatGPT for Teens is a beginning. More work lies ahead.

Because parents, too, like to play

PARENTING is one of the most rewarding jobs in the world, the popular truisms goes. It is also one of the hardest — which may be why fewer people are willing to take it on. Governments anxious about falling birth rates reach for the familiar arsenal of cash bonuses, tax breaks and longer parental leave. Could there be something for them to glean from the recent New York City initiative that asked what parents might need — besides money and infrastructure? NYC's Parents' Night Out initiative offered four hours of free supervised childcare for children aged 13, giving parents the rare chance to go out on a date, catch up on chores or simply inhale, for a few hours, the unfamiliar luxury of having nowhere they needed to be. There is something radical about the idea of leisure as parental right, not privilege. Public policy needs to see parents through the duties they perform: Feeding, clothing, educating, protecting. But parents are also people who once had hobbies, friendships, interests and stretches of time that belonged entirely to them.

There is a larger idea here about how public policy — usually designed around what citizens must do, like work, commute, pay taxes, etc. — can pay more attention to the question of what citizens might need simply to enjoy. Leisure, companionship, play, culture and unhurried time are easily dismissed as private luxuries, rather than recognised as ingredients of a happy society. NYC shows that public policy need not only make life more affordable or more efficient. It can also make room for pleasure.

Count caste by all means. But abandon belief that counting settles anything

YOGENDRA YADAV argued in these pages ("Caste census is dead. Don't expect a formal announcement or funeral", IE, August 12) that the caste census exercise has been quietly killed by a technical choice — an open-ended question inviting every Indian to name his own caste, which in 2011 produced 4.7 million caste names and a convenient burial. His diagnosis of the politics is sort of persuasive. But in proposing a drop-down menu instead, he adds that this "poses no difficulty for the enumerator, as long as there is no confusion about caste names".

That is precisely the problem, and it is not about names. It is about incentives. Basic NSS-PLFS statistics provide an explanation. In 1999-2000, 35.7 per cent of Indians said they were OBC. Five years later, 40.9 per cent did. India's population grew 1.8 per cent a year. So the OBC population went from 357 million to 447 million in five years — a growth rate of 4.6 per cent a year. The General category (non OBC, SC or ST) population went from 359 million to 342 million: They shrank, at 0.95 per cent a year.

What would it take for the OBC population to grow that fast? The benchmark demographers use for the outer limit of human fertility is the Hutterites, an Anabaptist community of the North American plains who married early, used no contraception, and enjoyed good nutrition and medical care. Their total fertility rate — 10.9 children per woman — is the standard against which all other fertility is indexed. Between 1880 and 1950, their population grew from 443 to 8,542. That works out to 4.32 per cent a year.

India's OBCs, on the survey evidence, out-reproduced the Hutterites. Nor was this

a five-year aberration. Between 1999 and 2025, the OBC population nearly doubled, from 357 million to 674 million. Since India added 456 million people in total over those 26 years, a group that was 36 per cent of the country in 1999 accounted for 70 per cent of every person it has added since. The General category, meanwhile, shrank: 359 million to 350 million.

Demography is unusually good at catching this sort of thing, because fertility leaves a fingerprint in the age structure. A group growing because it is having more children must be over-represented among children.

A population growing at 4.6 per cent a year should be overwhelmingly young — its child-to-adult gap should dwarf that of the rest of the population. It does not. In 2004, the OBC share among children under 15 exceeded the OBC share among adults by just 2.0 percentage points, and by 2025, that gap had narrowed to 1.2, even as the OBC share climbed a further five points. Had the growth been real, the gap would be of an altogether different order. At Hutterite fertility, OBCs would account for three-quarters of all births and be over-represented among children by more than 30 percentage points. Even a total fertility rate of six would require 20. By way of contrast, Muslims, who genuinely do have higher fertility, are over-represented among children by 3.2 points in 2004, widening to 4.3 by 2025. That is what a fertility differential looks like. The OBC numbers look like nothing of the sort.

The OBC share is rising almost as fast among adults as among children. Adults are not born. They were incentivised to reclassify. A decade ago ("Census, Christians and Conversions", IE, August 29, 2015), I used the same test for the Christian population. They have the highest female education in India and among the lowest fertility — 2.4 children per woman against 2.8 for Hindus and 3.6 for Muslims (NFHS, 1998-99). Only Sikhs were lower, at 2.3. Yet between 1991 and 2011 Sikhs grew at 1.2 per cent a year, exactly as their fertility predicts, while Christians — with virtually the same fertility — grew at 1.9 per cent, faster than the Hindus and matching the national average. Doing that demographically needs a fertility rate near 3.3, not the revealed 2.4.



SURJIT S BHALLA

Why? Incentives. One reason: A Christian of backward-caste origin can sit on state and central OBC lists and claim reservation, while simultaneously holding notified minority status with the institutional protections of Article 30 — minority institutions set their own admissions and are exempt from quota obligations. What he cannot claim is Scheduled Caste status. Two sets of benefits, from two classifications, at once. Whether that is anomaly or justice is a separate argument. That it creates an incentive is not arguable.

None of this is a claim about the honesty of Indians. It is a claim about human beings, and it is the least controversial proposition in economics. People respond to incentives. They always have, everywhere, and the response is usually invisible to the people making the rules. Readers will forgive me — or not — for observing that I have been making the same argument about

investment. Indian promoters sent a record \$33.3 billion abroad last year while domestic private investment stagnated. Net foreign direct investment has fallen to 0.18 per cent of GDP. Commentators cite all this as a failure of animal spirits, and ministers appeal to industrialists to invest at home. But nobody is behaving badly. A firm choosing between a factory here and one abroad faces a bilateral investment treaty requiring 60 months in Indian courts before arbitration, 765 Quality Control Orders where there were 14 in 2014, and no trade agreement with the market (USA) that absorbs \$42 billion of Indian exports. It responds exactly as the incentives instruct. So do the households that discovered they were OBC in 2004.

The same explanation explains the caste count, the conversion numbers and the investment collapse; no proof required.

So should India have a caste census to count correctly? Yes. Caste counts — India allocates education and employment on caste. But abandon the belief that counting settles anything. Ask for caste, sub-caste and surname, never for category, so the respondent is not invited to choose her own entitlement, and let the statistical office (and professional sociologists, not the armchair types) map it afterwards. Publish the microdata. And check every count against fertility — because a group whose growth requires Hutterite fertility has not grown. It has responded to incentives. Yadav is right that the Census is being killed by design. He is too generous in supposing that, absent the sabotage, it would have told us the truth.

Bhalla is chairperson of the Technical Expert Group for the first official Household Income Survey of India. Views are personal

Ask for caste, sub-caste and surname, never for category, so the respondent is not invited to choose her own entitlement, and let the statistical office map it afterwards

For deep-tech fund, members' connections are valuable assets



PAYAL MALIK



KRISHNAPRIY A VS

DEAR EDITOR I disagree

A fortnightly column in which we invite readers to tell us why, when they differ with the editorial positions or news coverage of 'The Indian Express'

Expert judgement requires proximity that enables a combined knowledge of technological maturity and commercial viability

that affect bureaucratic decision-making. The 50 per cent RDIF limit to project financing ensures project proponents and private investors have shared accountability.

As RDIF's institutional design is fundamentally different from conventional public expenditure schemes, judging it through the lens of procedural propriety governing conventional bureaucratic decision-making may not be prudent. Instead, it should be assessed based on outcomes and the effectiveness of its governance architecture in tackling conflict of interest. The proof of the pudding is in its eating. Out of the 15 start-ups publicly mentioned, at least 10 have clear institutional or founder linkages to publicly funded premier technological institutions like IITs, and most have received prior external funding, signalling their technical merit.

A decade into Startup India, start-up registrations have burgeoned and India's entrepreneurial ecosystem has come a long way. Nevertheless, India is yet to produce many high-impact global scale-ups, particularly in technology-intensive sectors. The RDIF is targeted to address this gap in frontier sectors. The government's sectoral commitments function as a catalyst for private investment in technology sectors where the government has specific mission-mode initiatives.

TDB's Investment Committee is a recommending body with the final accountability resting with the TDB. The chairperson and members of the investment committee are industry experts with impeccable credentials. Foreseeing the eventuality of unavoidable connections between industry experts and potential applicants, pre-investment guidelines to tackle conflict of interest, including mandatory recusal and "supermajority" rules for choice of investee companies, are in place.

RDIF signifies a shift from the traditional public-funded R&D grant model to one where the government shapes the strategic direction of technological progress and mobilises industry expertise and private capital. Given its importance to India's technological sovereignty and strategic autonomy, it must not be undermined by political controversy.

The writers are with the ICRIER-Prusac Centre



AVIRAL PANDEY

THE BJP's new national team under Nitin Nabin is significant less for the scale of the reshuffle than for what its composition reveals about the road ahead. Of the 65 national office-bearers, 51 are new. Yet the party has also brought back experienced leaders such as Ram Madhav and Smriti Irani, retained B L Santhosh, and made room for younger faces and wider regional representation. With the 2027 UP election, the Presidential election and the 2029 Lok Sabha polls ahead, the BJP is preparing for the next phase before electoral pressure peaks.

Nitin Nabin is the face of the change, but calling it simply "his team" would miss the larger picture. The new team composition suggests a broader organisational exercise. It is less a break with the past than a selective reconfiguration: Retaining an organisational architecture that has worked, bringing back experience while it is considered valuable, and making space for newer faces.

The geographical spread points to a longer-term calculation. The BJP is firmly established across much of the Hindi heartland and western India; its room for growth lies in regions where its electoral presence is limited. Representation from Karnataka, Tamil Nadu, Kerala and Andhra Pradesh, along with the Northeast, suggests an effort to make the organisation more genuinely national. D Purandeswar's elevation is relevant to this southern push, while K Surendran and Anil Antony bring experience from states where the BJP still has considerable room to grow.

This should not be read as a shift of the BJP's centre of gravity to the south. Rather, it reflects an acknowledgement that future expansion cannot come only from regions where the party is already strong. The strategy is straightforward: Consolidate the base, repair weak spots and create new political space. The social composition carries a similar message. Women, OBCs, Dalits, tribal leaders and members of minority communities have been given greater organisational visibility. This is more than symbolism. As the BJP's electoral base has broadened, its organisation must increasingly reflect that social diversity.

The changes in the digital and youth organisations suggest another adjustment. Amit Malviya has been replaced as IT cell chief, while Tejasi Surya has been replaced as president of the youth wing. This should not be read as a retreat from digital politics. The BJP was among the earliest parties to build an extensive social-media machinery. A more plausible reading is that the party is adapting that machinery to a digital environment that has become faster, more fragmented and less predictable. That matters because younger voters can now generate political narratives outside established party structures. Recent youth-led protests over examinations and employment are instructive — not because they demonstrate an anti-BJP wave, but because they show how quickly a specific grievance can enter the national political conversation. The reset, then, may not be about changing what the BJP stands for, but ensuring that its organisation can understand — and respond to — a changing India before that change is reflected at the ballot box.

The writer teaches at Patna University

Nitin Nabin is the face of the change, but calling it simply 'his team' would miss the larger picture

40 YEARS AGO

August 20, 1986



Violence spreads in Pakistan

ANTI-GOVERNMENT demonstrators in Pakistan clashed with the police even as the army was called out in Sindh province to crush the current agitation against the Zia-ul-Haq government, in which at least 26 people have died so far. According to reports, the agitation has spread to fresh areas, including Lahore, following the announcement by the Movement for the Restoration of Democracy (MRD) to launch protests to oust Gen Zia and force the government to hold elections. Violent incidents continued in Sindh province, a stronghold of the Opposition, with demonstrators damaging railway tracks and buildings in some places.

Security belt dilemma

THE GOVERNMENT is still in two minds about whether or not it should go ahead with the proposed bill to create a security belt along the entire India-Pakistan border in this session of Parliament.

Student killed by schoolmates

A 17-YEAR-OLD schoolboy, Rajinder Singh, was stabbed to death and his younger brother, Gurdeep Singh, received stab wounds when they were attacked by their schoolmates in Babarpur, a trans-Jamuna colony. The assailants, Ashok Kumar and Vishnu Dutt Sharma alias Raju, have been caught by the Shahdara police.

Rajinder and Gurdeep, residents of Kabool Nagar, were from a family of masons and both had recently completed Class VIII at a school near their home. Since the school was only up to middle classes, they were admitted to the Government Boys' Senior Secondary School, Babarpur, merely a week ago.

Car bomb kills 20 in Iran

A CAR bomb ripped through a main square in Tehran, killing 20 people and wounding several others, the Islamic Republic News Agency reported. The blast at 8.20 a.m. local time (10.20 IST) took place during the rush hour, in one of the most crowded areas of the capital.

The Ideas Page

THURSDAY, AUGUST 20, 2026

An institution in freefall: Parliament is all dressed up with nowhere to go



THAROORTHINK
BY SHASHI THAROOR

THE RECENTLY concluded Parliament session has confirmed yet again that urgent action is needed to restore the "temple of our democracy" to something better than utter dysfunctionality. Our collective failure to strike a balance between partisan politics and mature statesmanship remains the most glaring weakness of our parliamentary democracy. The Opposition remains adamant that certain issues must be discussed. But faces a government that considers compromise a sign of weakness. The Opposition persistently chooses disruption if it won't be heard; the government refuses to reach out and accommodate even some of its demands. Time, taxpayers' money and meaningful debate are all lost. So also are opportunities for MPs to question ministers, to raise constituency issues in Zero Hour or of national importance under Rule 37, and to place on record their views on the bills that the government cheerfully passes amid the din.

The relationship between the government and the Opposition has devolved into an unprecedented bitterness. It was not always so. A foundational civility once governed our public life: Atal Bihari Vajpayee took delight in receiving the Jewisharal Nehru treated him with immense courtesy as a young Opposition backbencher, how Rajiv Gandhi ensured he received medical care in the US, and how Narasimha Rao dispatched him to Geneva to represent India at a critical UN summit on Kashmir. Such bipartisan grace is today unimaginable.

Instead, Indian politics has descended into a crusade of mutual denigration. Each side claims the mantle of absolute virtue while writing off the other as irredeemable. To the ruling party, dissent is branded as "anti-national"; the Opposition, in turn, casts itself as an outnumbered band of Pandavas

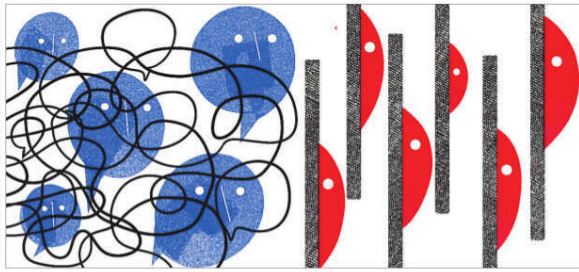


ILLUSTRATION: C. R. SAKSHAM

battling a ruthless, resource-rich Kaurava establishment. But democracy cannot survive without abasic presumption of mutual good faith: the belief that even our fiercest rivals care about the nation's welfare, even if we disagree profoundly on how to serve it. When we treat political adversaries as existential enemies, the common ground required for governance vanishes.

This breakdown of democratic trust is a collective failure. The ruling party was just as uncompromising when it was out of power. The very leaders who once championed parliamentary obstruction as a vital tool for enforcing executive accountability discovered, upon taking office, that where you stand depends on where you sit. Suddenly, disruption became an unpardonable sin. Unsurprisingly, the Opposition, having suffered under those tactics for years, rejects the sermon. If the traditional Golden Rule urged us, "Do unto others as you would have them do unto you," the new code of Indian politics is far simpler and far more destructive: Do unto them what they did unto you.

There is also a glaring disconnect between parliamentary performance and electoral success. Representatives are elected (and re-elected) for reasons that have almost nothing to do with their ability to skewer a minister during Question Hour or dissect a flawed

The Opposition persistently chooses disruption if it won't be heard: the government refuses to reach out and accommodate even some of its demands. Time, taxpayers' money and meaningful debate are all lost

bill with forensic precision. Instead, voters judge their MPs by the constituent services they render and the raw, local political muscle they command. The talent that ought to be showcased on the floor of the House has migrated to television studios. In turn, when party whips corral MPs into the well of the House to disrupt proceedings with organised shouting rather than reasoned debate, party leaders signal that they value partisan aggression far above parliamentary excellence.

At one time, political parties valued different skills in their leaders: The mass mobilisation of the "politics of the street" and the debating prowess of the "politics of Parliament". When the "politics of the street" has invaded Parliament, the "politics of Parliament" has no place to go, impoverishing our democratic discourse and rendering the possibility of national consensus on progress untenable. Some good work continues in parliamentary committees, mostly away from the media glare, and in the absence of the cameras that place a premium on disruptive grandstanding. But what the public sees is disruption, the absence of dialogue and a complete breakdown in communication. Disillusionment with the functioning of Parliament is rife across the country.

This generational freefall in legislative standards has only

been exacerbated by the ruling dispensation. The current government displays a barely concealed contempt for the legislature, preferring to rule through the Opposition rather than engage it. Unlike Jawaharlal Nehru, who attended Parliament daily and treated it as the beating heart of Indian democracy, Prime Minister Narendra Modi rarely deigns to grace the House with his presence. Over recent years, the government has reduced Parliament from a consultative chamber in a deliberative democracy to a mere noticeboard for announcing executive decisions and a rubber stamp for legalising them.

This systematic diminishing of Parliament strikes at the very core of our democratic order. Tragically, its own custodians are allowing the institution to be hollowed out, bringing us dangerously close to a point where the public will no longer even miss it when it is effectively rendered meaningless. But if Parliament is allowed to lose all purpose, what will remain of our democracy?

Democracy requires a rare, delicate balance. It demands that politicians maintain fierce ideological convictions during an election, yet actively cooperate for the collective progress of the nation once the ballots are cast. This principle is essential to build a healthy political culture, drawing on timeless lessons from democratic history, global precedents, and the evolving nature of public service. When both sides concur that national interests should be prioritised over partisan rivalries, governance can shift from zero-sum obstructionism to constructive collaboration. This approach does not mean giving up party ideology or abandoning one's principles. Instead, it recognises that while political parties offer distinct paths toward progress, the ultimate destination remains the welfare, safety, and prosperity of the nation.

An obvious solution, successfully used elsewhere, is to grant the Opposition one day a week or two hours a day to raise any issue it deems essential, while allowing the work of Parliament to proceed undisturbed the rest of the time. Does no one in the government have the imagination or the vision to effect such a compromise?

The writer is a fourth-term Congress MP from Thiruvananthapuram

BRICS is working for a future that puts the planet first



BHUPENDER YADAV

AS INDIA hosted the 12th BRICS Environment Ministers' Meeting on August 18 in New Delhi under its chairship, it did so with a deep sense of responsibility and optimism. BRICS countries account for 49.5 per cent of the world's population, approximately 40 per cent of global GDP and 26 per cent of international trade, underscoring their growing influence on the global economy, development agenda and the future direction of international co-operation. As the world faces interconnected environmental challenges, BRICS demonstrates that sustainable development, climate action and inclusive growth can advance together through dialogue, partnership and shared responsibility.

Under the leadership of PM Narendra Modi, initiatives such as Mission LiFE (Lifestyle for Environment) and Ek Ped Maa Ke Naam (A Tree in the Name of Mother) have demonstrated the value of combining ecological restoration, public participation and community ownership. These initiatives illustrate how climate action, biodiversity conservation, resilience-building and livelihood enhancement can reinforce one another when pursued through integrated approaches.

It was in this context that India's BRICS chairship was guided by the vision articulated by PM Modi: "Just as we brought inclusivity to our G-20 presidency and placed the concerns of the Global South at the forefront of the agenda, similarly, during our presidency of BRICS, we will advance this forum with a people-centric approach and the spirit of 'Humanity First'."

Under India's chairship, the BRICS Environment Working Group focused on four interconnected priorities. The priority on Promoting Sustainable Lifestyles builds on the principles of Mission LiFE and encourages responsible and sustainable consumption and production, behavioural change, awareness among citizens and communities and knowledge-sharing. This was complemented by the priority on Afforestation, Forest Fire Management and Disaster Resilience, which addresses the growing pressures on forests, land and natural ecosystems through integrated landscape restoration, combating land degradation, wildfire preparedness and response, early-warning systems and ecosystem resilience. By strengthening cooperation, sharing best practices and leveraging scientific advances such as remote sensing and artificial intelligence, BRICS aims to build more resilient landscapes and communities. The Circular Economy priority reflects a growing recognition that the traditional "take-make-dispose" model is no longer sustainable. BRICS member countries view the circular economy as a key enabler of sustainable development and inclusive economic growth, and seek to reduce environmental pressures while creating economic opportunities and green employment through stronger international cooperation in research, innovation, technology transfer and capacity building. As climate impacts intensify, adaptation has become an urgent necessity, particularly for developing countries facing disproportionate vulnerabilities. A defining feature of the BRICS approach is the recognition that traditional knowledge, indigenous knowledge and local knowledge systems offer valuable insights for building resilience. The BRICS Principles for Advancing Climate Resilience through People-Centric and Community-Based Adaptation emphasise integrating such knowledge with modern science and technology to create context-specific, evidence-based and culturally appropriate solutions.

Together, these priorities reflected a simple yet powerful conviction: Environmental action must be people-centric, implementation-oriented and responsive to the realities of developing countries. The principles of equity and Common but Differentiated Responsibilities and Respective Capabilities (CBDR-RC) resonated across and remain fundamental to an effective and balanced global environmental response to climate change.

The outcomes achieved under India's BRICS chairship extend beyond declarations. They include the development of practical principles on sustainable lifestyles, integrated landscape management, forest fire preparedness and community-based adaptation, as well as technical reports, platforms, dialogues and knowledge-sharing networks. These outcomes reflect months of collaboration, negotiation and consensus-building among member countries and demonstrate the value of multilateral cooperation in addressing common environmental challenges.

India's efforts to reduce emissions intensity while expanding non-fossil energy capacity reinforce the belief that development and environmental responsibility can advance together. India has reduced the emissions intensity of its economy by 37.38 per cent between 2005 and 2022, while non-fossil sources accounted for 54.18 per cent of installed electricity capacity (as of 30 June 2026). India's new Nationally Determined Contribution for 2031-2035 further reflects the commitment to advancing climate action while supporting inclusive development and energy security. BRICS is seeking to contribute meaningfully to global environmental governance while delivering tangible benefits for communities on the ground. The success of these efforts will ultimately be measured not by the adoption of principles alone, but by their ability to strengthen ecosystems, support livelihoods and build a more sustainable and resilient future for all.

The writer is Union Minister for Environment, Forest and Climate Change

LETTERS TO THE EDITOR

Party reshuffle

THE EDITORIAL goes on to hit the nail on the head by stating that the BJP's latest rejig, involving the to-and-fro of certain key individuals, will be assessed more by their respective ability to contribute towards making it future-ready ('Rejig in party must be reset for governance', IE, August 19). The BJP reset could be a first step in the right direction, but the long-awaited reshuffling of PM Modi's Cabinet also remains quintessential for 'resetting the governance' in the given critical scenario across the nation.

SK Gupta, via email

Deepen ties

STRENGTHENING INDIA-JAPAN relations offers substantial mutual benefits across strategic, economic and technological domains, while advancing their shared vision of a free, open, peaceful and rules-based Indo-Pacific (A changing Asia demands more from Delhi and Tokyo, together', IE, August 19). Defence cooperation through joint exercises, training and reciprocal logistics arrangements can enhance maritime security and regional preparedness. Initiatives such as the Supply Chain Resilience Initiative can reduce dependence on China while diversifying critical supply chains and strengthening economic security. Vaibhav Goyal, Chandigarh

Darwin upset

BANGLADESH'S PERFORMANCE in Darwin is a reminder that cricket's landscape is widening ('At Darwin, Bangladesh upends the cricketing order', IE, August 19). Established teams can no longer assume that rankings or past records guarantee easy victories. The sport will benefit if emerging sides receive sustained opportunities, quality coaching and regular international fixtures. For Bangladesh, the challenge is to build on this resounding victory. Stronger domestic structures and bilateral cricket can turn an encouraging performance into lasting progress. Prakash Paramasivan, Neelambar



VIKRAM SINGH

AS THE Central Reserve Police Force (CRPF) marked its Raising Day on July 27, the celebrations carried an added significance this year. The CRPF, which has been at the forefront of India's internal security operations for decades, has also been central to one of the most consequential security campaigns of the Modi government: The dismantling of Left Wing Extremism (LWE). PM Narendra Modi, in his message on the occasion, highlighted the CRPF's courage and commitment, while the force's role in the campaign against Naxalism has been particularly visible in the forests of Chhattisgarh, Jharkhand and other parts of the former Red Corridor. The Centre declared the country free from Naxalism on March 31, 2026.

For a region that for decades was associated with ambushes, armed cadres and Maoist control, this is a turning point. It also raises a question larger than the military defeat of an insurgency: What replaces the Red Corridor? The answer will determine how durable the government's achievement is.

Home Minister Amit Shah's approach to LWE brought together intelligence-led operations, greater coordination between central and state forces, disruption of Maoist financing, rehabilitation and a sustained expansion of the security grid. The CRPF's specialised CoBRA units, alongside state police forces, were deployed in operations including Black Forest, Octopus, Double Bull and ChakraBandha, helping dismantle strongholds that had re-

What replaces the Red Corridor? The answer will determine how durable the government's achievement is

mained difficult to penetrate for years. Once security forces could establish a more permanent presence in areas where the state had struggled to maintain one, roads and communications could be extended, institutions could be opened and development programmes could reach communities that had remained isolated.

The numbers offer a sense of that change. Since 2014, the government says 408 new security camps and 597 fortified police stations have been established in LWE-affected areas. More than 12,000 km of roads have been constructed, while 1,804 bank branches, 1,321 ATMs and 6,025 post offices have been added. Mobile connectivity has expanded across most villages in the affected regions, alongside Eklavya Model Residential Schools, ITIs and skill development centres. For people living in these areas, these are not merely development statistics. A road changes access to a market or a hospital. A bank branch connects households to formal finance. A telecom tower brings a remote village closer to the rest of the country. A school or skill centre expands the choices available to young people.

The objective now is to ensure that the state's presence in these regions is defined by institutions and opportunity rather than by the security challenge that once dominated the landscape. This also explains the emphasis on rehabilitation. The government's surrender policy has sought to bring former cadres back into civilian life through financial assis-

tance, training and support for reintegration, while agencies have targeted the financial networks that sustained the insurgency. The strategy has been to reduce the movement's ability to operate, finance itself and replenish its ranks.

Amit Shah's repeated engagement with the LWE-affected regions has been another feature of the campaign. His visits to Bastar and security review meetings on the ground have kept the Centre closely involved with an operational challenge that demands coordination between Delhi, state governments and personnel deployed deep inside difficult terrain. The government's ability to combine political direction with an expanded security and development architecture has been central to the shift. The next phase will be less dramatic than the operations that made the headlines, but it could be more important in determining the legacy of the campaign. The former Red Corridor will truly become a development corridor when the infrastructure now reaching these regions begins to generate sustained economic activity, better education and greater integration with the rest of India.

The guns going silent is an important milestone. The harder task is ensuring the space they leave behind is filled with roads, schools, businesses, livelihoods and functioning institutions. That is the opportunity the end of Naxalism has created, and that is where the government's larger test begins.

The writer is former DGP, Uttar Pradesh, and chancellor of Noida International University

After Naxalism, a development corridor

when India's larger destiny was at stake.

Students taking part in the Swadeshi Movement, the Non-Cooperation Movement, the Civil Disobedience Movement and the Quit India Movement boycotted colonial educational institutions, faced imprisonment, and carried the message of resistance into towns and villages. Bhagat Singh was not merely a young revolutionary who made the supreme sacrifice. He was a political thinker who understood that courage without political understanding could not transform society. In his 1931 document 'To Young Political Workers', written only weeks before his execution, he emphasised the need for study circles, political education, propaganda and organised work among workers and peasants. His martyrdom was not simply an act of extraordinary personal cour-

age. It was an appeal to young Indians to think, organise and fight for a better future.

The decades after Independence have repeatedly confirmed this political character. Students have risen not only over fees, examinations or hostel facilities, but over democracy, federalism, language, social justice, civil liberties and the direction of the country itself. The anti-Hindi agitations in Tamil Nadu drew enormous student participation. The Assam Movement saw students play a central organisational role. The student-led mobilisation against the Emergency became

His martyrdom was an appeal to young Indians to think, organise and fight for a better future

an important part of the democratic resistance of the 1970s. Left student organisations, too, have a long record of asking questions far beyond campus boundaries.

India today is passing through a crisis on many fronts. Public education faces growing pressures. Examination systems have been shaken by allegations and instances of paper leaks and irregularities. Young people confront an acute crisis of employment and secure livelihoods. Communal polarisation threatens the social fabric of the Republic. Democratic dissent is too often treated as a problem to be managed rather than a constitutional right to be respected. Accountability has become difficult to extract from those in power. And yet, at a moment when cynicism could easily have overwhelmed hope, students have again stepped forward.

The struggle is no longer against a foreign colonial power. It is against the forces that seek to hollow out the democratic and constitutional foundations of the Republic; against communal division, inequality, unemployment, and the erosion of institutional accountability. The present student movement must be carried forward. Students must reach beyond their campuses, build solidarity with workers and farmers, stand with Dalits, tribals and women facing discrimination, defend public institutions and become an active force for constitutional democracy. This is where the legacy of Bhagat Singh remains particularly relevant. His message was not simply to be angry. It was to study, understand, organise and act.

The writer is general secretary, CPI

Students are upholding Bhagat Singh's legacy



D RAJA

THERE IS something inspiring and enlightening about the sight of students standing together in protest. Their placards may carry new demands, their slogans may belong to a new generation, and the technologies they use to organise may be radically different from those of the past. From the struggle against British colonial rule to the battles for democracy, social justice and the rights of young people in independent India, students have repeatedly emerged at the forefront of mass mobilisation. They have never confined themselves to the narrow boundaries of classrooms and campuses

 TAMIL NADU TRANSMISSION CORPORATION LTD Notice Inviting Tenders (E-Tendering Process)		
Specification No.	Tender Inviting Authority	Name of the Work
T-2383 03/05/26-27	SE/Transmission-II CETP&SO/Madurai	Supply and Erection of Transformers 110 KV Line Works
	CETP&SO/Chennai	SSE Works

 **TELANGANA CO-OPERATIVE MARKETING FEDERATION LTD.**
 Email: cpmfr.telangana@gmail.com / Tel: 086-2402 1708

Re.No.685/PMB/ Disposal of Jawar Hybrid Yasanagi/2025-26 Date: 19.08.2026

**TENDER NOTIFICATION FOR ONLINE E-AUCTION FOR
 THE SALE OF JAWAR HYBRID YASANAGI (RABI) 2025-26**

PROCURED BY TO MARKFED.

Tender notification for online e-Auctions on disposal of Jawar Yasanagi (Rabi)

2025-26 procured by TO MARKFED auctions for the quantity and lots as mentioned in the e-auction portal through: <https://auction.telangana.gov.in> & <https://telangana-e-procurementportal.com> (in e-procurement portal will be available from 11:30 AM on 20.08.2026).

1. E-auction bidding will commence on 20.7.2026 from 10:00 AM to 05:00 PM
 2. Last date for submission of EM: 25.08.2026 upto 05:00 PM
 For online registration and further technical support please contact Service Providers Mobile No: 7337445545 / 6309139656 / 7337455556 / 9912756216
 For further details please contact. Ph: 7288878878, and 7288878872

Sd/- MANAGING DIRECTOR



PUNJAB STATE POWER CORPORATION LTD.

(Regd. Office: PSEB Head Office, The Mall, Patiala)
 Corporate Identity Number : U40402018HG308313
 Website : www.psecltd.com (Contact Number 96461-0715)

Tender inquiry no. 691/GHTP/PEMCSSM-18/IV-14 **Date: 18/08/2026**

By: Chief Engineer/ Electrical Maintenance Circle, Gurug Harbajod Thermal Plant, Lohra Mohabait, invites e-corporate for Hotline (online) washing of 22 KV & 66 KV insulator strings, porcelain portion of switchyard equipment i.e. CTS, FTS, Breakers, Isolators etc. installed at 220 KV Substation, GHTP, Lohra Mohabait as per detailed Scope of work mentioned in the technical specifications.

For detailed NIT & tender specification please refer to: <https://eproc.punjab.gov.in>
 from 18/08/2026 12:00 PM to 11:00 AM onwards.

Note: Corrigendum and addendum, if any will be published online at <https://eproc.punjab.gov.in>

No. 14417/PB
GRTP-65/26

 **MAHARASHTRA ENERGY
DEVELOPMENT AGENCY (MEDA)**
(A Government of Maharashtra Undertaking)
Aunth Road, Opposite Spicer College, Near Commissionerate
of Animal Husbandry, Aundh, Pune
E-mail id: kusun@meda.gov.in Phone No. : 91-20-25690623

NOTICE FOR E-TENDER

Request for Proposal (RFP) for SELECTION OF AGENCY FOR OPERATION
AND MAINTENANCE OF MEDA'S PM KUSUM PORTAL WITH RRS
INTEGRATION.

For detailed Tender Document, interested bidders should visit website
www.matenders.gov.in. The online bid submission period is from
20-08-2026 and the last date for bid submission is 04-09-2026 @ 17:00 hrs.

The Director General MEDA reserves the right to accept or reject anyone or
all the Tender without giving reasons there of.

General Manager, MEDA

[illegible]

राज्याच्या सरकारी
कॉलेज शिक्षा विभाग, जयपूर

प्रमाण: PZ/31/2024/1000, 1001, 1002, 1003, 1004, 1005, 1006, 1007, 1008, 1009, 1010, 1011, 1012, 1013, 1014, 1015, 1016, 1017, 1018, 1019, 1020, 1021, 1022, 1023, 1024, 1025, 1026, 1027, 1028, 1029, 1030, 1031, 1032, 1033, 1034, 1035, 1036, 1037, 1038, 1039, 1040, 1041, 1042, 1043, 1044, 1045, 1046, 1047, 1048, 1049, 1050, 1051, 1052, 1053, 1054, 1055, 1056, 1057, 1058, 1059, 1060, 1061, 1062, 1063, 1064, 1065, 1066, 1067, 1068, 1069, 1070, 1071, 1072, 1073, 1074, 1075, 1076, 1077, 1078, 1079, 1080, 1081, 1082, 1083, 1084, 1085, 1086, 1087, 1088, 1089, 1090, 1091, 1092, 1093, 1094, 1095, 1096, 1097, 1098, 1099, 1100, 1101, 1102, 1103, 1104, 1105, 1106, 1107, 1108, 1109, 1110, 1111, 1112, 1113, 1114, 1115, 1116, 1117, 1118, 1119, 1120, 1121, 1122, 1123, 1124, 1125, 1126, 1127, 1128, 1129, 1130, 1131, 1132, 1133, 1134, 1135, 1136, 1137, 1138, 1139, 1140, 1141, 1142, 1143, 1144, 1145, 1146, 1147, 1148, 1149, 1150, 1151, 1152, 1153, 1154, 1155, 1156, 1157, 1158, 1159, 1160, 1161, 1162, 1163, 1164, 1165, 1166, 1167, 1168, 1169, 1170, 1171, 1172, 1173, 1174, 1175, 1176, 1177, 1178, 1179, 1180, 1181, 1182, 1183, 1184, 1185, 1186, 1187, 1188, 1189, 1190, 1191, 1192, 1193, 1194, 1195, 1196, 1197, 1198, 1199, 1200, 1201, 1202, 1203, 1204, 1205, 1206, 1207, 1208, 1209, 1210, 1211, 1212, 1213, 1214, 1215, 1216, 1217, 1218, 1219, 1220, 1221, 1222, 1223, 1224, 1225, 1226, 1227, 1228, 1229, 1230, 1231, 1232, 1233, 1234, 1235, 1236, 1237, 1238, 1239, 1240, 1241, 1242, 1243, 1244, 1245, 1246, 1247, 1248, 1249, 1250, 1251, 1252, 1253, 1254, 1255, 1256, 1257, 1258, 1259, 1260, 1261, 1262, 1263, 1264, 1265, 1266, 1267, 1268, 1269, 1270, 1271, 1272, 1273, 1274, 1275, 1276, 1277, 1278, 1279, 1280, 1281, 1282, 1283, 1284, 1285, 1286, 1287, 1288, 1289, 1290, 1291, 1292, 1293, 1294, 1295, 1296, 1297, 1298, 1299, 1300, 1301, 1302, 1303, 1304, 1305, 1306, 1307, 1308, 1309, 1310, 1311, 1312, 1313, 1314, 1315, 1316, 1317, 1318, 1319, 1320, 1321, 1322, 1323, 1324, 1325, 1326, 1327, 1328, 1329, 1330, 1331, 1332, 1333, 1334, 1335, 1336, 1337, 1338, 1339, 1340, 1341, 1342, 1343, 1344, 1345, 1346, 1347, 1348, 1349, 1350, 1351, 1352, 1353, 1354, 1355, 1356, 1357, 1358, 1359, 1360, 1361, 1362, 1363, 1364, 1365, 1366, 1367, 1368, 1369, 1370, 1371, 1372, 1373, 1374, 1375, 1376, 1377, 1378, 1379, 1380, 1381, 1382, 1383, 1384, 1385, 1386, 1387, 1388, 1389, 1390, 1391, 1392, 1393, 1394, 1395, 1396, 1397, 1398, 1399, 1400, 1401, 1402, 1403, 1404, 1405, 1406, 1407, 1408, 1409, 1410, 1411, 1412, 1413, 1414, 1415, 1416, 1417, 1418, 1419, 1420, 1421, 1422, 1423, 1424, 1425, 1426, 1427, 1428, 1429, 1430, 1431, 1432, 1433, 1434, 1435, 1436, 1437, 1438, 1439, 1440, 1441, 1442, 1443, 1444, 1445, 1446, 1447, 1448, 1449, 1450, 1451, 1452, 1453, 1454, 1455, 1456, 1457, 1458, 1459, 1460, 1461, 1462, 1463, 1464, 1465, 1466, 1467, 1468, 1469, 1470, 1471, 1472, 1473, 1474, 1475, 1476, 1477, 1478, 1479, 1480, 1481, 1482, 1483, 1484, 1485, 1486, 1487, 1488, 1489, 1490, 1491, 1492, 1493, 1494, 1495, 1496, 1497, 1498, 1499, 1500, 1501, 1502, 1503, 1504, 1505, 1506, 1507, 1508, 1509, 1510, 1511, 1512, 1513, 1514, 1515, 1516, 1517, 1518, 1519, 1520, 1521, 1522, 1523, 1524, 1525, 1526, 1527, 1528, 1529, 1530, 1531, 1532, 1533, 1534, 1535, 1536, 1537, 1538, 1539, 1540, 1541, 1542, 1543, 1544, 1545, 1546, 1547, 1548, 1549, 1550, 1551, 1552, 1553, 1554, 1555, 1556, 1557, 1558, 1559, 1560, 1561, 1562, 1563, 1564, 1565, 1566, 1567, 1568, 1569, 1570, 1571, 1572, 1573, 1574, 1575, 1576, 1577, 1578, 1579, 1580, 1581, 1582, 1583, 1584, 1585, 1586, 1587, 1588, 1589, 1590, 1591, 1592, 1593, 1594, 1595, 1596, 1597, 1598, 1599, 1600, 1601, 1602, 1603, 1604, 1605, 1606, 1607, 1608, 1609, 1610, 1611, 1612, 1613, 1614, 1615, 1616, 1617, 1618, 1619, 1620, 1621, 1622, 1623, 1624, 1625, 1626, 1627, 1628, 1629, 1630, 1631, 1632, 1633, 1634, 1635, 1636, 1637, 1638, 1639, 1640, 1641, 1642, 1643, 1644, 1645, 1646, 1647, 1648, 1649, 1650, 1651, 1652, 1653, 1654, 1655, 1656, 1657, 1658, 1659, 1660, 1661, 1662, 1663, 1664, 1665, 1666, 1667, 1668, 1669, 1670, 1671, 1

 **BENGALURU CENTRAL CITY CORPORATION**
OFFICE OF THE SENIOR ASSISTANT DIRECTOR
OF HORTICULTURE, ZONE-1

No: SADH-1/HORT/TENDER/14/0026-27 Dated: 19/08/2026

INVITATION FOR TENDER (IFT)
(TWO COVER SYSTEM - THROUGH KARNATAKA PUBLIC PROCUREMENT PORTAL)

The Senior Assistant Director of Horticulture, Zone-1, Bengaluru, Karnataka, Bengaluru Central City Corporation, invites online tenders through the Karnataka Public Procurement Portal (KPPP) from eligible and experienced contractors/firms/agencies for the following work, in accordance with the Karnataka Transparency in Public Procurements Act, 1999 and the Karnataka Transparency in Public Procurements Rules, 2002, as amended from time to time.

Name of Work: Beautification, Landscape development, Water facilities and other civil works including borewell drilling and electrification of parks and upgradation of tender sure roads in Shanthinagar Assembly Constituency

Estimated Cost of Work : ₹2.00,00,000/-

EMD : ₹3.00,000/-

Tender Processing Fee : As applicable in KPPP Portal

Tender System : Two Cover System

Mode of Tender : Online through KPPP only

Completion Period : As specified in the approved Tender Document

Bid Validity : As specified in the Tender Document

Standard Tender Document : KW-4, as applicable

Calendar of Events :

1) Date of publication of Tender Notification on KPPP : 19/08/2026 (2) Date of commencement of downloading Tender Documents : 19/08/2026 (3) Pre-Bid Meeting : 24/08/2026 at 12.30PM (4) Last Date and Time for submission of Tender : 19/08/2026 upto 5.00 PM (5) Date and Time of opening of tenders : 04/09/2026 at 11.30 AM (6) Opening of Financial Bid : Will be initiated separately through KPPP to technically qualified bidders.

Sd/- Senior Assistant Director of Horticulture
Zone-1, Horticulture Division Bengaluru Central City Corporation

**PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE
APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON**

See Section 82 CrPC

Whereas complaint has been made before me that said accused **Raju S/o Jagu Ram R/o B-13/26, B-Block, Shahbad Raju, Delhi** has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in case registered vide FIR No. 39/2024/US 32/34 IPC, PS Shahbad Raju, Delhi and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest there upon issued that the said accused **Raju** can not be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said **Raju** has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant),

Proclamation is hereby made that the said accused **Raju** of FIR No. 39/2024/US 32/34 IPC, PS Shahbad Raju, Delhi is required to appear before this court (or before me) to answer the complaint on or before the day of 28.09.2025.

By Order,
Ms. Shanti Bhandari
 District Magistrate First Class (Jr), North
 Room No. 114, 1st Floor
 Rohini Courts, Delhi

DP/11481/ON/2024(Court Matter)

राज्यस्वास्थ्य सचिवालय
कार्यालय अधीक्षक, मयूरदास माधुव चिकित्सालय जोधपुर

E-TENDER NOTICE (09/09/2026-27)

Online Bids are invited from eligible bidders i.e. Manufacturer/Authorized Distributors/Dealers to provide various items at Services at **Mathura Das Mother Hospital** Jodhpur attached to D.S. No. 1 Medical College Jodhpur as per tender terms and conditions. Tenders are to be submitted daily upto 12 noon in electronic form only on website <http://www.eppn.nepal.gov.np>. The tender document may be downloaded from above mentioned website. The tender document may also be seen on <http://www.eppn.nepal.gov.np>. The details of the bid are as follows:-

[E-Tender No. 09/2026-27]
General Supply Items
UBN/SCN/26272/LRC/00137
Amount-100 Lac.

Sd/-
Superintendent
Mathura Das Mother Hospital
Jodhpur

DIPRI/15/509/2026

Office of the Additional Chief Engineer (Project) PHED Bhatnagar E-mail: aceproj.bha.phed@rajasthan.gov.in			
No.	Notice Inviting Bid No. 01/2026-27		Date:
On behalf of the Governor of Rajasthan, online tender are hereby invited from eligible bidders for the following works of water supply projects on per criteria mentioned below. Detailed NIT / Tender documents are available on website: http://eprc.rajasthan.gov.in / http://rajasthan.gov.in. Tender to be submitted online in electronic format on website http://eprc.rajasthan.gov.in / http://rajasthan.gov.in till 17/09/2026 upto last date of receipt.			
NIT No.	Name of Project	Est. Estimated Cost	SPFF NRB No.
01/26-27	Work of Pkg-3 of Chambal Disbhar (Bhatnagar) Project (Retendering) for providing (FTHS) in villages and Gram Panch of Roophas, Uchbain, Bhatnagar (Sewar) and Kumbhar Moch of District Bhatnagar under JRM	Rs. 232.30 Crores	PHS/25/01/080429
NIB Code: PHS/26/27/3225		(Sardar Sharma) Additional Chief Engineer (P) PHED Bhatnagar	
DIPR/C/15267/0206			

राज्यपाला कार्यालय			
कायान्वय अधिकाारी अधिवाना सार्वजनिक निर्माण विभाग खण्ड कोटयुक्ती			
(कायान्वय डायरेक्ट कोटयुक्ती)			
ईमेल ektpwdd@gmail.com			
क्रमांक	1173-81	तारिख	13.08.2026
Short Term NIT No 08/2026-27			
Construction of Various Art Project Under PwD Division Kotgall District Kotgall Jhelore Chilling lake is invited from eligible and interested bidder from the above-mentioned works. The bidding process will commence from 17.08.2026 12:00 pm upto 27.08.2026 12:00 PM. And shall remain open up to 28.08.2026 at 02.00 PM Detailed bidding documents and other particulars of may be downloaded from the State Procurement Portal (http://eproc.rajasthan.gov.in and http://ppp.naii.in) of the state and (http://pwr.rajasthan.gov.in in departmental website. The approximate value of the procurement is Rs.86,34,00-Lakhs.			
URN No.	URN No.	S. No.	URN No.
1	PWDS27PWSORH003	2	PWDS27PWSORH007
4	PWDS27PWSORH010	5	PWDS27PWSORH013

**PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE
APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON**

See Section 344 BNSS

Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused **Yogesh S/o Rajbir S/A-168, Shabbad Dairy, Delhi** **Rakesh s/o Pawa S/o Jagdamba R/B-1020, PS Shabbad Dairy, Delhi** has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in case registered vide **FIR No. 51/2021/PS 392/344/1 IPC, PS Shabbad Dairy, Delhi** and it has been returned to me warrant of arrest and now issued that the said accused **Yogesh & Rakesh s/o Pawa** can not be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said **Yogesh & Rakesh s/o Pawa** absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant).

Proclamation is hereby made that the said accused **Yogesh & Rakesh s/o Pawa** of **FIR No. 51/2021/PS 392/344/1 IPC, PS Shabbad Dairy, Delhi** are required to appear before this court (or before me) to answer the complaint on or before the day of **29.09.2026**.

By Order,
Ms. Shanti Bindal
Judicial Magistrate First Class-BS (North)
Room No. 114, 1st Floor
Rohini Courts, Delhi

DP/1147/ON/2026/Court Material

[illegible]

"IMPORTANT"

Whilst care is taken prior to acceptance of advertising copy, it is not possible to verify its contents. The Indian Express (P) Limited cannot be held responsible for such contents, nor for any loss or damage incurred as a result of transactions with companies, associations or individuals advertising in its newspapers or Publications. We therefore recommend that readers make necessary inquiries before sending any monies or making any other payments to any advertiser, or acting on any agreements with advertisers or otherwise acting on an advertisement in any manner whatsoever.

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF A PERSON ACCUSED

See Section 82 Cr. P.C. / 84 BNSS

Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused person **Kapil Kumar S/o Jogender R/o B-40, Jagatpur Extension, Gali No. 12, Delhi** has Committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in case FIR No. **611/2015 U.S. 279/337/338 P.S., P.S. GTB Enclave, Delhi** and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest thereupon; that the said accused **Kapil Kumar** cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said accused **Kapil Kumar** has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant);

Proclamation is hereby made that the said accused **Kapil Kumar** of case FIR No. **611/2015 U.S. 279/337/338 P.S., P.S. GTB Enclave, Delhi** is required to appear before this Court to answer the said complaint on or before **12.10.2026**.

By Order
 Ms. Sangmitra
 Judicial Magistrate First Class
 Room No. 54, Second Floor, Shahdara District
 Karkardooma Courts, Delhi

DP/8835/SHD/2024 (Court Matter).

कावांवल, अधीक्षण अभियंता पदेन परियोजना प्रबंधक, वाटरशेड तेल
कम डाटा सेंटर जिला-कोटपुतली-बदोई
E-mail- sewdsoc.kot.behrur@rajasthan.gov.in
Sr. No. 388 Date: 17-8-2026

REVISED
NOTICE INVITING BID
NIT NO-18 YEAR 2026-27

Bids for Watershed Development Works are invited from interested bidders up to
23.08.2026 at 6:00 PM as per following details. Other particulars of bid may be
visited on the procurement portal <https://sppp.rajasthan.gov.in> of the state
departmental website.

			(Ru in Lacs)	
1	Kotputli Mjya 2.2	18/06/2027	57.84	WSC267 A0001
2	Vatnagar Mjya 2.2		143.45	WSC267WS0801666
3	Necanmama Mjya 2.2		153.43	WSC267WS0801667
4	Banwar Mjya 2.2		58.31	WSC267WS0801668
5	Banwar Mjya 2.2		102.11	WSC267WS0801681
6	Purta Mjya 2.2		114.35	WSC267WS0801682
7	Vatnagar Mjya 2.2		75.82	WSC267WS0801683
8	Necanmama Mjya 2.0		58.95	WSC267WS0801684
9	Vatnagar puskey 2.0		2.06	WSC267WS0801686

Sd/-
(RAJESH KUMAR GUPTA)
Superintending Engineer
WCDC Kotputli-behrou

DIPRC/15293/2026



जयप्रकाश नारायण सेवा संस्था
जयपुर **अतिरिक्त निदेशिका, गांधी मार्ग, जयपुर**
 ई-मेल : secr@jayprakash.org | फोन : 0146-2222220

क्रमांक :- अनुसूच. के-2/2024-27/नविन-राजस्थान
दिनांक :- 19.08.2023

निविदा सूचना

राजस्थान के राजधानी जयपुर में ओर में "Package IV (work under City D.) (South) Jaipur" work of Strengthening and Improvement in the water supply distribution network under the jurisdiction of Jaipur Nagar Nigam Heritage under AMRUT 2.0" कार्य हेतु निम्न सूचना अधिनियमित कर के राजस्थान (अथवा भारत के अधिकतर संसदीय/केन्द्रीय क्षेत्र निवासियों में निम्न प्रकार द्वारा निविदा निर्देश / पत्रों/ दिशानिर्देशों के अधीन में संश्लेषित संवेदीयों को निविदा पत्र में ई-अनुसूचक द्वारा निविदा/ निविदा अर्पण को ई. निविदा निविदा पत्र में निविदा पत्र www.sppp.rajasthan.gov.in में www.eproc.rajasthan.gov.in पर उपलब्ध है।

क्रम संख्या	एन.आई.ओ. नं.	थी.पी. एन. कोड	निविदा पत्र
1	PH6267/TA2319	PH/2627/V/LOB04637	18/06/26-27

(राजस्थान निविदा)
अतिरिक्त निदेशिका
जयपुर अतिरिक्त निदेशिका
जयपुर अतिरिक्त निदेशिका

DIR/CR/636826.27

**PROCLAMATION REQUIREING THE
APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON**

See Section 82 CrPC

Whereas proclamation has been made before me that accused **Rahul v. Gagan Prasad S/o Rajesh Prasad R/o H. No. 111/7A, Railway Colony, Kishan Gagan, Delhi** has committed or is suspected to have committed the offence in case registered vide FIR No. 11/2020 U/S 25/54/59 Arms Act, PS Karol Bagh, New Delhi and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest their upon issued that the said accused **Rahul v. Gagan Prasad** cannot be found and whereas I have been shown to my satisfaction that the said **Rahul v. Gagan Prasad** has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant).

Proclamation is hereby made that the said accused **Rahul v. Gagan Prasad** of FIR No. 11/2020 U/S 25/54/59 Arms Act, PS Karol Bagh, New Delhi is required to appear before this court (or before me) to answer the complaint on or before the date of **29.09.2026**.

By Order,
Sh. Nishat Gagan
Judicial Magistrate First Class-01, Delhi

DP/11/2020/Cr/2026 (Court Matter) Tiz Hazrat, Delhi

MOTILAL NEHRU SCHOOL OF SPORTS

RAI-131029, DISTT. SONPAT (HARYANA)
ADVT-003/2026

Applications are invited from the eligible and interested candidates working regular basis on the analogous post in Central/State Govt. Departments for appointment of various teaching and non-teaching posts on DEPUTATION BASIS as per standard terms & conditions of deputation prescribed in Haryana Civil Service Rules, 2016 as amended from time to time will be applied. The applications should reach on or before 01/09/2026 at 04.00 P.M. at the address "The Principal & Director, MNSS, RAI-131029 (Haryana)". Applications received after the last date due to postal delay or any other reasons will not be considered. The **POST OF MASTER (SR JWG) IS AT PAR WITH PGCT AND THE POST OF MASTER (JR JWG) IS AT PAR WITH TGT**.

Candidates are advised to go through the instructions while applying for the posts of Master (Teaching & non-teaching posts) to be filled on deputation basis (visit the school website www.mnsrai.org)

Sl. No.	Name of Post	No. of Post	FPL*	Mode of appointment
1	History - Master (Sr Wg)	01	FPL-08	Deputation basis for a period of one year
2	Hindi - Master (Sr Wg)	01	FPL-08	or till vacancy is filled on regular basis, whichever is earlier.
3	Maths - Master (Sr Wg)	02	FPL-08	The period may be extended beyond one year based on performance.
4	Music - Master (Sr Wg)	01	FPL-08	
5	Economics - Master (Sr Wg)	01	FPL-08	
6	Physical Education (Sr Wg)	01	FPL-08	
* Profound knowledge of Sanskrit.				
7	Hindi - Master (Jr Wg)	01	FPL-07	
8	Maths Master (Jr Wg)	01	FPL-07	
9	Coach Cricket -	01	FPL-06	
10	Coach Football	01	FPL-06	
11	Coach - Hockey	01	FPL-06	

*** Indicative of FPL at the time of fresh joining Note :-**

- (a) Pay entitlement shall be admissible to employees joining MNSS on deputation basis as per corresponding scale applicable to the corresponding staff post in MNSS. Rai will be applicable to the persons joining MNSS, Rai on deputation.
- (b) Number of posts may increase or decrease.
- (c) The applicant is required to submit a No Objection Certificate (NOC) from employer, where he/she is working presently.
- (d) If joining is MNSS, Rai - From Class 10 to 12th
- (e) If joining is Kamla Nehru School - For Class 5th & 6th

Those applicants who are serving at distant locations, and to avoid any postal delay may submit the duly filled application form along with scanned copies of all required documents through email at mnsrai@gmail.com. The applicant must clearly mention the post applied for in the subject line of the email.

SD/-

PRINCIPAL & DIRECTOR

MNSS, RAI

NO.43836/SHRY

OFFICE OF THE CHIEF ENGINEER WATER RESOURCES ZONE, BANSWARA	
Mahli Colony, Near New Court Campus, Banswara, E-mail-csewrho@gmail.com	
No. FJ/CJWR/BSW/ACCTT/2026-27/6223	Date: 13-08-2026
Short Term e-NIB No. 05/2026-27	
On behalf of the Governor of Rajasthan, bids are invited from eligible bidders for the work of "Survey, Planning, Designing for Rejuvenation of Mores River, Construction of Ghats on both side of the River, Large Kund and Riverfront Development at Khadgauda Village - Durgampur (Phase-I) including O&M for Period of 05 years on Engineering Procurement Construction (EPC) Single Responsibility turnkey basis" (Estimated Value of Work - Rs 8055.66 Lakh inclusive GST) Last date of submission of Bid is 05.09.2026 Detailed Bid & Brochure can be seen on & downloaded from official website (http://procure.rajasthan.gov.in), (http://sppd.raj.nic.in)	
NIB Code No.-WRD2627/0287 UBN No.- WRD2627WLOB00609	
DIPRC /15021/2026	Sd/- Chief Engineer

राज्यपाला कार्यालय	
कार्यालय अधिष्ठाया अनिवार्यता सार्वजनिक निर्माण विभाग खण्ड बान्सुर (राहती कार्यालय के बीच बान्सुर)	
दस्तावेज नंबर 01641-294290, ईमेल cpwdbansur@gmail.com	
क्रमांक 635	दिनांक 14.08.2026
Short Term NIT No 09/2026-27	
Construction of Various Atal Path Road Under Pwd Division Bansur District Koptulpi-Bhehor Online Bids are invited from eligible and interested bidder from the above-mentioned works. The bidding process will commence from 17.08.2026 12:00 pm upto 27.08.2026 03:00 PM. And shall remain open till 27.08.2026 at 12:00 PM Detailed bidding documents and other particulars of may be downloaded from the State Procurement Portal (http://eproc.rajasthan.gov.in and http://sprj.nic.in of the state and http://pwd.rajasthan.gov.in in departmental website. The approximate value of the procurement is Rs.341.44/- Lakhs.	
UBN No- PWD2627WSOB10514, PWD2627WSOB10518 Sd/- Executive Engineer PWD Div Bansur	
DIPR/C/15243/2026	



ग्रेटर नोएडा औद्योगिक विकास प्राधिकरण

प्लॉट सं. ४१, ग्राहक पार्क-४, ग्रेटर नोएडा, नोएडा-२०१३०१, उद्योग इलाका-२०१३०३४८
 ४१, ग्राहक पार्क-४, ग्रेटर नोएडा, नोएडा-२०१३०१, उद्योग इलाका-२०१३०३४८
 ४१, ग्राहक पार्क-४, ग्रेटर नोएडा, नोएडा-२०१३०१, उद्योग इलाका-२०१३०३४८

पत्रांक- अर्बन सर्विसेज/ २०२०/ ६३०दिनांक १९/०८/२०२०

ई-निविदा आमंत्रण सूचना

मुख्य कार्यकर्ता अधिकारी, ग्रेटर नोएडा औद्योगिक विकास प्राधिकरण के ओर से ई-निविदा आमंत्रण सूचना संख्या: अर्बन सर्विसेज/ २०२०/ ६२९ दिनांक १९/०८/२०२० के माध्यम से उल्लेखित कार्य की ई-निविदा आमंत्रित की जाती है। ई-निविदा की विषयगत जानकारी ग्रेटर नोएडा प्राधिकरण की वेबसाइट www.greaternoidaauthority.in पर ई-निविदा लिंक पर ई-पोर्टल <http://etender.upnic.in> पर उपलब्ध है। किसी परिवर्तन, संशोधन व अतिरिक्त सूचनाओं के लिए उक्त वेबसाइट देखते रहें।

क्र.सं.	कार्य का नाम	अनुमानित लागत
1	Supply of JCB Dumper/Tipper Tractor Trolley for Enchantment/Removal Drive work in Urban Service. GNIDA.	₹ 160 लाख

उक्त कार्य का निविदा दिनांक २१/०८/२०२० को सांघ ०५०० से दोपहर ०२:०० बजे तक अलार्ग किया जा सकता है। किसी भी प्रश्न हेतु Email - sudhirbhatia@gnidn.in पर संपर्क किया जा सकता है। निविदा के अंतर्गत की प्री-क्वालिफिकेशन दिनांक ०९/०९/२०२० को तक ११:०० बजे खोली जायेगी।

सहप्र प्रबंधक (अर्बन सर्विसेज)

* Follow Us On *
 Facebook | Twitter | LinkedIn | YouTube | Instagram



SOUTH COAST RAILWAY

VISAKHAPATNAM

Follow us on @SCRailway_Website : www.scorailindia.gov.in

No. G/C/Auction Leasing/2026/27/01,

Dated : 17-08-2026.

For and on behalf of the President of the Indian, Senior Divisional Commercial Manager, Guntakal Division, South Coast Railway conducts e-Auction through <https://www.reps.gov.in> from the Indian nationals above the age of eighteen years and Companies / Firms registered under closed and e-auction.

Sl. No	Category	Locations	Date of Auction	Auction Start time
1. GTL-SLR/2627-2A	Leasing of SLRs	21 Trains 21 SLRs	24-08-2026	11:15 AM
2. GTL-SLR/2627-2A	Leasing of SLRs	01 Trains 01 SLRs	25-08-2026	11:00 AM

Sl. No.	e-Tender No	Category	Location	Date & Time of Tender Opening	Date of publishing
1.	RU-SNL/2627-2A	PCET Leasing Round trip Circuit	PCET from RU	07-09-2026 15:00 hours	11-08-2026

Interested parties and contractors to take note of this and go through the user manual downloaded from the learning centre (User manuals) link available in the left navigation bar of the home page of REPS site to understand e-Auction procedure and participate. And for further clarifications, bidders may approach office of Senior Divisional Commercial Manager, South Coast Railway, Guntakal.

SCOR-A233
Sr. Divisional Commercial Manager, Guntakal.

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF A PERSON ACCUSED

See Section 82 Cr.P.C. / 84 BNSS

Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused person **Karlitary Sharma S/o Lt. Pradeep Sharma R/o C-11, Street No. 67, Ajay Nagar, Kirtana Nagar, Delhi has** Committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in case **FIR No. 215/2019 U/s 392/394/114/134 IPC, P.S. Jagatpuri, Delhi** and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest thereupon issued that the said accused **Karlitary Sharma** cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said accused **Karlitary Sharma** has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant).

Proclamation is hereby made that the said accused **Karlitary Sharma** of case **FIR No. 215/2019 U/s 392/394/114/134 IPC, P.S. Jagatpuri, Delhi** is required to appear before this Court to answer the said complaint on or before **22.09.2029**.

By Order
Mrs. Anushita Srivastava
Judicial Magistrate (1st Class) -5
Room No. 27, 2nd Floor, Shahdara District
Court, Karkardoma Courts, Delhi

DP/1164/SHD/2026 (Court Matter) Karkardoma Courts, Delhi

OFFICE OF THE PRINCIPAL
GOVERNMENT COLLEGE JATAULI
HAILY MANDI, GURUGRAM

TENDER NOTICE

Tender is hereby invited for cleaning of premises, housekeeping, and gardening etc. service in Govt. College Jatauli Haily Mandi, Gurugram (Haryana) from the interested and eligible tenders/service agencies (approved by Govt. of Haryana) having at least three years' experience in providing similar services in past. Interested Tenderers/service agencies can collect tender form from the office of Principal, Govt. College Jatauli Haily Mandi, Gurugram, Haryana) by paying Rs. 500/-payable through demand draft/banker cheque of any nationalized bank (drawn in favour of Principal, Govt. College Jatauli Haily Mandi, Gurugram. In this regard a pre-bid meeting will be held on 14/09/2026 at 01:00 PM to 03:00 PM at Govt. College Jatauli Haily Mandi, Gurugram and only those firms/agencies can take tender which will attend the pre-bid meeting. All terms and conditions will be attached with the form.

Last Date of receipt of sealed tender documents: 21/09/2026 at 11:00AM and opening date: time 30/09/2026 at 1:00PM

Sd/-
Principal

G.C. Jatauli Haily Mandi, Gurugram

No 48366/HRY

AT LEAST \$80 BN EXPECTED FROM ALL THREE FOREX SCHEMES

FCNR(B) decision data-driven, well thought-out: Gov

It will not be correct to call it a U-turn; it is rather a calibration: RBI Governor Malhotra

Kshipra Petkar & Joydeep Ghosh
Mumbai, August 19

RESERVE BANK of India (RBI) Governor Sanjay Malhotra on Wednesday strongly defended the decision to advance the closure of the Foreign Currency Non-Resident (Bank) — FCNR(B) — swap window by a month, describing it as a well-thought-out, calibrated, prudent and data-driven response to evolving conditions.

FCNR(B) deposits allow non-residents to keep money in a bank in the foreign currency itself. While these deposits are available at all times, the RBI in June opened a temporary facility for banks to swap these deposits, with the central bank bearing the full currency risk of these foreign currency deposits.

"It will not be correct to call it a U-turn; it is rather a calibration," Malhotra said. The move demonstrated the central bank's ability to remain flexible and data-dependent amid rapidly changing conditions, he added.

Responding to criticism that his remarks after the August 5 Monetary Policy Committee (MPC) meeting had ruled out an early closure, Malhotra said the RBI was still assessing a situation that was evolving rapidly.

"I would like to highlight the use of the words 'as of now' when I mentioned that there



The decision to close the temporary facility early was part of the RBI's external-sector management, Malhotra said. ANH CHAKRABARTY

was no proposal to advance the last date," he said.

The RBI had also said it would keep stakeholders informed of any decision, clearly indicating that an early closure had not been ruled out, he added. According to Malhotra, the decision was taken from a position of strength.

The RBI expects the three schemes — FCNR(B), external commercial borrowings (ECBs) and overseas foreign currency borrowings (OFCBs) — to attract at least \$80 billion.

This reflected the country's strong macroeconomic fundamentals and would further strengthen its balance of payments, he said. Inflows had been stronger than the RBI and most market participants had expected.

"There is a diminishing marginal utility of every dollar that is swapped. At the same time, there is an increasing marginal cost because you need to sterilise it for a longer period," Malhotra said.

The decision to close the temporary facility was part of the RBI's external-sector management, Malhotra said. On Prime Minister Narendra Modi's hopes of having

an Indian bank among the world's top five, the RBI Governor said Indian banks have the scale and ability to achieve a larger global footprint and are on the right path. He added that they will have to continue improving governance and institutional strength, build a sound risk-management culture, sustain good customer service, and retain customer trust.

They also need to invest continuously in technology, reduce costs, improve efficiency, expand their reach, enhance the customer experience, and continuously train and equip their staff to adapt nimbly to a growing economy and a fast-evolving financial system, he said. "If they continue doing these fundamental things, I believe it is only a matter of time before they are among the world's top banks," Malhotra said. When asked if a merger of banks would hasten the aforementioned process, the central bank chief said what is needed is a "good, strong banking system with healthy competition".

"The government merged a few banks earlier. Whether there is a case for further merger is a call the government can take," he said. FE

IndiGo website hit by snag, online bookings & check-in hit

New Delhi: The reservation platform of the country's largest airline IndiGo was hit by technical issues on Wednesday, affecting its online booking and web check-in services. Several people complained on social media that they were unable to make bookings or perform web check-ins on the IndiGo website and mobile application, and even on some of the third-party online travel booking portals.

The airline, which has a domestic market share of over 65% and operates about 2,200 daily flights, said that the issues were intermittent and its teams were working with the service provider to fix them on priority basis.

According to sources in the know, while the issues, which they said prima facie don't appear to be major — impacted the booking platform servers, IndiGo's airport and flight operations remained unaffected. ENS

SpiceJet's bankruptcy cases to be reheard

New Delhi: A court on Wednesday said bankruptcy petitions filed by aircraft lessors against SpiceJet will be heard afresh by a new bench, after the airline reached a last-minute settlement with one lessor. The order is a setback for aircraft leasing companies that have waged a years-long battle against India's fourth-largest airline to recover debts, but is a reprieve for the airline, SpiceJet. PTI

MINUTES OF RBI'S MPC MEETING: GOV SAID INFLATION IS EXPECTED TO TAPER FROM ITS PEAK IN Q3

RBI policy panel signals rate hike risk as inflation rises

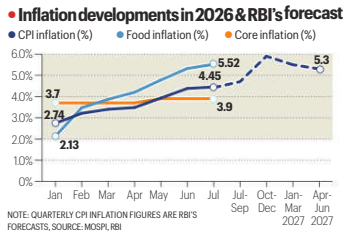
George Mathew
Mumbai, August 19

THE RESERVE Bank of India's (RBI) Monetary Policy Committee (MPC) has signalled a cautious, wait-and-watch approach on the policy rate, with members calling for close monitoring of inflation before going for any policy tightening.

Members of the MPC indicated that as headline inflation is projected to peak to a level as high as 5.9% in Q3 2026-27, a "case for a hike may emerge" during the course of the year.

According to minutes of the MPC meeting held on August 5, RBI Governor Sanjay Malhotra said he would prefer to wait for more certainty to emerge on the inflation trajectory in terms of the persistence of realised prints at these or higher levels, the forecast and the likely levels to which inflation may normalise and settle, for any recalibration of the policy rate.

"We also need to be watchful as the risks of higher food, fuel and other input prices translating into a broad-based increase in inflation, and de-anchoring of expectations persist. Any evidence of these risks



materialising may need policy tightening," Malhotra said as per the minutes of the meeting. The MPC kept the repo rate unchanged at 5.25% in the policy review. The panel marginally raised its growth forecast for FY27 to 6.7% from 6.6% and lowered its inflation projection to 5% from 5.1%.

No scope for further easing

Governor Malhotra said there are signs of a normalisation of inflation from its benign levels seen hitherto. The average inflation last year, when the

policy rate was brought down to 5.25%, was only 2%.

"Not only has headline inflation already averaged 3.93% this year, even core excluding precious metals is expected to converge to core inflation in the last quarter of this financial year, with core inflation projected to average 4.3% in 2026-27. This may suggest a recalibration of policy rate," he said.

"Inflation expectations, while slightly higher, are contained. Moreover, inflation is expected to taper from its peak in Q3. This shock does not therefore call for a monetary re-

sponse to curtail demand as of now," the governor said. According to Poonam Gupta, Deputy Governor, the scope for any further easing does not seem to exist at the current juncture. Instead, given that the headline inflation is projected to peak to a level as high as 5.9% in Q3 2026-27, a case for a hike may emerge during the course of the year.

"I believe that with persistent uncertainty on account of global developments and weather-related risks, the best course of action would be to wait and watch a bit more," Gupta said.

"The shift in the distribution towards higher inflation numbers warrants a careful vigil. One must look out for the extent of generalisation and risk of inflation expectations getting unanchored before contemplating any rate hike," said Indranil Bhattacharya, a member of the MPC.

Policy uncertainty, external shocks

MPC Member Ram Singh said high uncertainty still looms over several key monetary policy indicators.

"While the economy has withstood the conflict spillovers with limited impact so far, the strains are becoming increasingly visible. We have to closely watch if and how inflation-related risks resolve — El Niño's effect on food inflation and global oil prices. As of now, it makes sense to retain all the maximum operational flexibility needed to respond to an evolving inflation trajectory," Singh said.

"External shocks worsen or the second-round price effects spread widely, we should be able to swiftly adjust policy to protect macroeconomic stability," he said. "I judge it appropriate to await evidence of a further pickup in aggregate demand and generalisation of price pressures before taking the next policy action. Another factor which needs to be tracked are the levels of real interest rates," said MPC Member Saugata Bhattacharya. Despite this caution, the forecast normalisation of underlying inflation from earlier benign levels will require close monitoring of the growth-inflation dynamics, for the appropriate time to recalibrate the policy rate, he said.

FULL REPORT ON WWW.INDIANEXPRESS.COM

CAS manipulation will attract strict & swift action: SEBI chief

Akash Mandal
Mumbai, August 19

SECURITIES AND Exchange Board of India (SEBI) Chairman Tuhin Kanta Pandey on Wednesday said the regulator would take strict action against any manipulation of the recently-launched Closing Auction Session (CAS) mechanism.

Later in the day, SEBI banned two firms from the market for allegedly manipulating trades on the CAS mechanism. The capital markets regulator said the alleged violations by Cophal Mauritius Investment and Mansi Shree and Stock Broking happened on August 13 when weekly derivatives contracts linked to the Sensex expired.

"We want to make one thing clear, that if people manipulate the CAS system, then we will take strict action and do it immediately. CAS is for transparency. But if someone thinks that we will manipulate the CAS to defame it, then they are mistaken," said Pandey, speaking at FICCI's Capital Markets Conference in Mumbai.

"I think CAS participation is improving and will further improve. We are looking at the constraints for participation," he added. Launched by SEBI on August 3, the Closing Auction Session (CAS) uses a blind auction model between 3:35PM and 3:55PM to discover a single, manipulation-resistant closing price. It replaced the old Volume Weighted Average Price (VWAP)

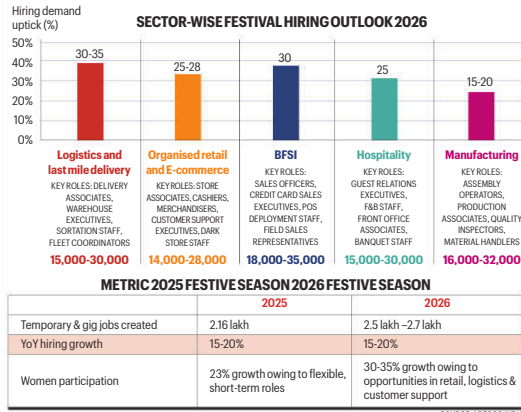
system for R&O-eligible stocks. He also said the regulator will release data for the futures and options (F&O) segment for 2025-26 on Thursday, which will indicate if the measures taken in recent times by the SEBI and the Ministry of Finance to curb excessive volatility in the segment have been fruitful. While SEBI has taken measures such as increasing lot sizes and limiting the number of expiries per exchange, the finance ministry hiked the Securities Transaction Tax on the segment in the latest Union Budget.

The regulator had released a similar study earlier, which had flagged that over 90% of trades by retail investors led to losses.

FULL REPORT ON WWW.INDIANEXPRESS.COM

TEMPORARY JOB POST TO MEET FESTIVAL DEMAND

The festival season is drawing close — Onam is likely to be celebrated on August 26. And with it, companies are gearing up to meet the demand rush. According to a report by Adecco India, the industry is set to cross 2.5 lakh temporary and gig jobs this time. It expects temporary staffing demand for the 2026 festival season to grow by 15-20% against the same period last year.



INDIA, THE WORLD'S BIGGEST CRUDE STEEL PRODUCER AFTER CHINA, MEETS 95% OF ITS COKING COAL NEEDS THROUGH IMPORTS

Steel mills face margin squeeze as global coking coal prices rise

Reuters
New Delhi, August 19

INDIAN STEEL mills are facing mounting pressure on margins as higher coking coal prices, driven by supply disruptions in Australia and China and the Iran war, raise steelmaking costs, executives and analysts said.

India, the world's biggest crude steel producer after China, meets 95% of its coking coal needs through imports, with at least half shipped from Australia. Coking coal accounts for nearly 40% of steel production costs.

Squeezed margins could impede investment and delay capacity expansion as Indian

steelmakers step up spending to meet buoyant domestic demand driven by infrastructure and strong economic growth. Premium hard coking coal prices jumped 25% from last year to average \$236 per metric ton freight on board (FOB) Australia in the first seven months of 2026, said Bannam Khurmi, lead, metallurgical coal and coke market service, at consultancy CRU in Sydney.

"Prices have been higher this year due to supply disruptions in Australia, slower-than-expected ramp-up at new mines, price support from the conflict in the Middle East and, more recently, a large accident in Shanxi, China," Khurmi said.



Every \$10 jump in coking coal price adds \$7-\$9 per metric ton to steelmaking costs. REUTERS

Costs are likely to remain high in the second half of the year, partly due to the loss of supply following the Shanxi coal mine

disaster, said Freddie Brooks, commodities analyst at BMI, a unit of Fitch Solutions. For blast furnaces-based steelmakers,

every \$10 a ton increase in coking coal prices adds approximately \$7 to \$9 per metric ton to steelmaking costs, said an executive at a large steel mill, who was not authorised to speak to the media.

Higher coking coal prices have squeezed margins, three other executives at leading steelmakers said, with little headroom to raise steel prices, given competition from cheap Chinese steel.

Shipments from China have increased despite import tariffs on some grades. Coking coal imports are expected to rise by between 2 million and 3 million tons in 2026-27 from 64 million tons a year earlier, commodities

consultancy BigMint said. With the higher demand for imports, comes higher transport costs, partly due to disruptions from the U.S.-Iran war.

"Trade flows have tightened with high demand from India and higher diesel, freight and insurance costs," said Hui Ting Sim, vice president at Moody's Ratings. Australia is expected to continue meeting at least half of India's coking coal needs, although imports from Russia, Mozambique and the United States are also set to rise.

Discounts on Russian coal, which accounted for 24% of India's coking coal imports in recent years, have diminished over the past two years, Khurmi said.

FM Sitharaman leads delegation to Singapore for 4th ISMR talks

New Delhi: Finance Minister Nirmala Sitharaman on Wednesday embarked on an official visit to Singapore with a ministerial delegation to participate in the 4th India-Singapore Ministerial Roundtable (ISMR).

Sitharaman is leading a delegation comprising S Jaishankar, Minister of External Affairs; Piyush Goyal, Minister for Commerce & Industry; and Jitin Prasad, Minister of State for Electronics & IT and Commerce & Industry. The roundtable is scheduled for August 19-20, the

finance ministry said in a post on X. Established in 2022, the ISMR is a key high-level economic mechanism between India and Singapore.

It provides a platform to review progress and explore new areas of collaboration across six pillars: advanced manufacturing, connectivity, digitalisation, healthcare, and medicine, skills development, and sustainability. "The 4th ISMR will build on the progress made under these pillars and explore new opportunities," the ministry said. PTI

FULL REPORT ON WWW.INDIANEXPRESS.COM

MARKETS

Sensex	NIFTY	Gold	US Dollar
76,909.68	24,078.30	₹1,53,868	\$795.76
-325.78	-76.60	Silver	Oil
-0.42%	-0.32%	₹2,29,225	\$92.11

NOTE: GOLD, SILVER RATES AS PER INDIAN BULLION AND JEWELLERS ASSOCIATION GOLD PER 100, SILVER PER 1 KG; CRUDE OIL (INDIAN BASKET) AS OF AUGUST 18, 2026

Trump says he plans to meet Kim who has 57 'powerful' nukes

Reuters
Washington, August 19

US PRESIDENT Donald Trump said Wednesday that he planned to meet with North Korean leader Kim Jong Un, and said the Asian nation held 57 "very powerful" nuclear weapons.

The remarks come as Trump ordered Pentagon officials to set short joint exercises with the South Korean military, writing in a social media post they sent a message to Pyongyang that was "totally inappropriate and hostile, to a Country that, as long as Donald Trump has been President, has been unthreatening and respectful."

During Trump's first term, Kim called Trump a "mentally ill" and "a dotard" between the leaders of South Korea and threatened that he had use of a "nuclear button" on his desk.

The leaders' relationship cooled after face-to-face meetings in 2018 and 2019, including a brief exchange at the demilitarized zone between the Koreas in which Trump became the first



President Trump with Kim Jong Un at the demilitarized zone separating the two Koreas, in Panmunjom, South Korea. FILE

sitting US president to step into North Korean territory.

"I know Kim Jong Un very well, and he's going to be very fine as long as we have a smart president," Trump told reporters Wednesday during a tour of the hellpache is constructing on the White House's south lawn.

"The fact that I got along with him—that's a good thing, not a bad thing. He has 57 very powerful nuclear weapons. They should have never allowed it. If I were president, I wouldn't have allowed it. But he's got them."

China considering summit with Seoul in November

Seoul: Chinese Foreign Minister Wang Yi said on Wednesday that Beijing was "actively considering" a summit between the leaders of South Korea and China at the Asia-Pacific Economic Cooperation summit in Shenzhen in November, Seoul's Foreign Ministry said.

He made the comment at a meeting with South Korean Foreign Minister Cho Hyun during a visit to Seoul, the ministry said

in a statement. Wang also invited Cho to visit China, and Cho accepted the invitation.

The ministers agreed to continue efforts to expand people-to-people exchanges, as the two countries forecast total travel between them to exceed 10 million visits, according to the ministry.

Cho urged China to play a role in bringing North Korea back to dialogue as soon as possible, the ministry said. REUTERS

TEHRAN DENIES LAUNCHING MISSILES TOWARDS UAE

UAE suspends trade ties with Iran after fresh missile attacks

UAE says missiles targeted maritime traffic in Hormuz

Associated Press
Dubai, August 19

THE UNITED ARAB EMIRATES suspended all trade with Iran on Wednesday after it said it had come under renewed fire from the country — a move that will further isolate the Islamic Republic, which is suffering under US sanctions and a blockade.

Incoming ballistic missile fire triggered nationwide warnings Tuesday night for UAE residents to seek shelter, the first time in weeks such an alarm had sounded. Early in the conflict, the UAE regularly came under intense fire from Iran, and most trade between the countries, which had once been important trading partners, ground to a halt. In late June, as hostilities eased, some maritime trade resumed. Iran's state-run IRNA news agency reported.

More time and data are needed to evaluate the full effect of war on Iran-UAE trade, but UAE is clearly a critical partner for Iran, said Mohammad Farzaneh, a professor of Middle Eastern economics at Germany's University of Marburg.

Beyond the trade in domestically produced goods, "the UAE has been very important for Iran as a re-export hub and



Iran parliament speaker Mohammad Baqer Qalibaf speaks at the Soleimani memorial site in Baghdad on Wednesday. REUTERS

has helped the country absorb some of the shocks caused by sanctions," he told The Associated Press. "Iran therefore depends heavily on the UAE not because the UAE itself produces one-third of Iran's imports, but because it serves as a major gateway for Iran to access third-country goods and commercial infrastructure."

Following the news that two ballistic missiles had been fired toward the UAE, both of which splashed down in the Persian Gulf late Tuesday, the Foreign Ministry said that while it remained committed to "dialogue, cooperation and regional integration," it had decided to impose the punitive measures.

"In light of regional escalations that undermine regional and international peace and security, all trade, commercial exchanges and financial transac-

tions with Iran have been halted until further notice," the ministry said in a statement.

The UAE's Defence Ministry said assessments showed that the missiles targeted maritime traffic. It has regularly attacked ships attempting to use waterway, including four tankers owned by Abu Dhabi's state-owned ADNOC oil and gas company over the past two weeks.

None of the attacks caused injuries, but they brought harsh condemnation from the UAE and others in the region, including Kuwait and Bahrain.

Pak govt seeks review of top court order to shift Imran to private hospital

Press Trust of India
Islamabad, Lahore, August 19

THE PAKISTAN government on Wednesday petitioned the Supreme Court, seeking a review and recall of its order to shift jailed former prime minister Imran Khan to private hospital.

The Supreme Court on Tuesday directed that 73-year-old Khan be taken to Shifa International Hospital in Islamabad "within the next two days", and he shall remain there until the next hearing on September 16. It also ordered the setting up of a medical board and allowed the former cricket-turned-politician weekly meetings with family. The order followed months of concern raised by Khan's family and supporters over his health, and repeated allegations of being denied access to adequate medical care.

Khan, who is the founder of the Pakistan Tehreek-e-Insaf political party, has been in Rawalpindi's Adiala Jail since 2023, with several cases against him.

On Wednesday, the federal government termed the order "discriminatory" and argued it could set a precedent for all convicts to seek similar treatment in case of health issues, as it filed the review petition.

Senior leaders of Khan's party criticised the federal government's move and accused it of adopting "delaying tactics" instead of adhering to order.

The SC directive in Khan's case came while hearing several identical petitions following the politician's eye ailment that surfaced earlier this year.

• BRIEFLY

CONGO

Ebola tops 5,000 cases, outpaces response efforts at record speed



Health workers at a treatment centre in Bunia, Congo. FILE

THE EBOLA outbreak in Congo has reached 5,000 cases, government data showed Wednesday, as responders warn it is spreading at an unprecedented speed outpacing efforts to slow it. It is one of the country's remotest regions. Data from Congo's Ministry of Health showed the outbreak had so far recorded 5,021 cases, including 2,378 deaths as of Sunday, as it rages in some of the most challenging conditions imaginable fueled by insecurity, displacement and intense population movements. AP

BRAZIL

21 killed after bus and truck collide head-on

AT LEAST 21 people died and four others were injured in a head-on collision between a bus and a truck in the BR-373 highway in Brazil's Parana state, the road operator said Wednesday. All the fatal victims were on the bus, Cita Aruavira said. The road was completely blocked with no estimated time for it to be cleared. REUTERS

UNITED STATES

Trump taps WH adviser Overton to lead FDA

US PRESIDENT Donald Trump Wednesday named White House policy aide Heidi Overton to lead Food and Drug Administration, writing online that she would push his "America First" policies. Overton, a doctor, was previously as deputy director of the White House domestic policy council. REUTERS

• NEIGHBOURHOOD WATCH

SRI LANKA

Former minister held in 2 separate corruption cases

SRI LANKAN authorities have arrested former minister Kehelviya Rambukwella in two separate cases over allegations of graft and conspiracy, the anti-graft commission said in a statement. The commission on Tuesday arrested Rambukwella, a former media and health minister, at around 11.30 am and 1.15 pm in connection with two cases. PTI

NEPAL

PM Balen skips meeting called by RSP chairman

THE GROWING differences between PM Balendra Shah and Chairman of the ruling Rastriya Swatantra Party Rabi Lamichhane came to the fore Wednesday with the former skipping a meeting of the parliamentary party summoned by the former. The meeting called was attended by most ministers and RSP legislators, but not Shah. YUBARAJ GHIMIRE

Ukraine's new defence chief takes office as predecessor urges fresh polls

Reuters
Kyiv, August 19

UKRAINIAN LAWMAKERS appointed a new defence minister on Wednesday, hours after his ousted predecessor dealt a major blow to President Volodymyr Zelenskyy with a call for elections in wartime.

Yevhenii Khmara, a former top special forces operative, takes up the critical defence portfolio amid fresh political turmoil for the president, who had faced weeks of protests over his dismissal of 35-year-

old reformer Mykhailo Fedorov. Khmara's appointment also took place just hours after anti-corruption authorities announced charges against a deputy chief of Zelenskyy's office as part of an alleged \$3 million money-laundering scheme.

Fedorov's removal as defence minister in July brought thousands of demonstrators onto the streets in rare wartime protests over a surprise shake-up seen as poorly communicated to the public at a critical time in the war with Russia.

His bold call for elections in



New Ukraine Defence Minister Yevhenii Khmara. REUTERS

the fifth year of fighting drew accusations of populism in a country where a majority of

people still oppose a wartime vote, even though many argue that Ukraine needs fresh faces in power.

"He chose to move on the populist trajectory, underlining the risks and challenges for democratic process of election," said Lesia Bidochko, a policy fellow at the European Policy Institute in Kyiv.

In his statement late Tuesday, Fedorov said the country faced a crisis of governance and that Ukraine's democratic process "cannot be held hostage by Russia". Wartime elections are

prohibited under law. AN August 5 poll by the Kyiv International Institute of Sociology showed 57% of Ukrainians believe they should only take place after the war, given that hundreds of thousands of troops are on the front line and Russian missiles and drones are raining down on Ukrainian cities, towns and villages.

"We must find a legal, safe and realistic mechanism that will allow Ukraine to renew its full democratic process even in the conditions of a long war," said Fedorov.

Fuel stations in Moscow limit sales

Moscow: Fuel stations in Moscow have reimposed limits on gasoline purchases due to fuel shortages linked to Ukrainian drone attacks on refineries and strong seasonal demand.

Shortages began to gather pace in May and had spread to most Russian regions by July, but fuel stations in Moscow were able to ease an earlier wave of restrictions in June. REUTERS

Israeli airstrike kills nine Palestinians at Gaza police station

Reuters
Cairo, August 19

AN ISRAELI airstrike killed nine Palestinians at a police station in Gaza on Wednesday, medics said, two days after US envoy Jared Kushner ended a trip to the region that failed to push forward Donald Trump's plan to end the war in the enclave.

Medics and police sources said several officers were among those killed at what the Hamas-led interior ministry said was the headquarters of the municipal police. Fifteen others were wounded, they said.

The ministry later said in a statement that those killed included eight top-level officers and also a 13-year-old girl who was in the vicinity at the time of the attack. Earlier on Wednesday, in Nuseirat refugee camp in central Gaza, a separate Israeli airstrike killed one Palestinian, medics said, taking Wednesday's death toll to at least 10.

The Israeli military said the Nuseirat strike had targeted a Hamas militant. It has not com-

mented on the strike on the police station.

In what had appeared to be a possible breakthrough at the end of July, President Trump announced that Hamas had accepted a roadmap which entailed the Palestinian militant group decommissioning its weapons in phases as Israel's military withdrew from Gaza.

The military would also stop its operations in the territory. However, Israeli PM Benjamin Netanyahu, whose ruling coalition is trailing in opinion polls ahead of an October election, rejected the roadmap, insisting the military would only withdraw once Hamas has disarmed.

Hamas has demanded that Israel adhere to the ceasefire and withdraw its forces from Gaza. Both sides have disputed the sequencing of how Trump's plan should be implemented. Israel said its strikes aimed to thwart imminent attacks by Hamas and Gaza militants. On Tuesday, an Israeli airstrike killed at least seven Palestinians, including a child, medics said.

Over 100 killed in Central African Republic gold mine collapse

Bangui: The death toll from a gold mine collapse in a western part of Central African Republic has risen to over 100. A Red Cross volunteer involved in relief efforts said Wednesday.

The low-tech, artisanal gold mine collapsed Tuesday morning in the village of Zambouye, in the Nana-Mambere prefecture, near the border with Cameroon. Gervais Ganagoroh, a local Red Cross volunteer involved in relief efforts, said more than 100 dead bodies have been recovered so far, while several survivors are critically injured.

Bertrand Be Yangue, a member of the Zambouye youth council, also said the death toll was more than 100, adding that it's likely to rise, as several people are still missing and others are

• Scene of Tragedy



trapped under the rubble.

"Finding them alive would be a miracle," Yangue said. "We are saddened and heartbroken to see young men and women perish after coming to the mines to save their families from despair," he added. AP

Bangladesh to hold presidential election today

Dhaka: Bangladesh will hold its presidential election Thursday, with lawmakers set to choose between the ruling BNP stalwart Mirza Fakhrul Islam Alamgir and 11-party opposition alliance candidate Colonel (ret'd) Oli Ahmed.

The voting will take place for the first time in a presidential election after a gap of 35 years. The voting will be held at the parliament from 2:00 pm to 5 pm on August 20.

Alamgir, 78, is the candidate of the ruling BNP, while Colonel (ret'd) Ahmed, chairman of the Liberal Democratic Party (LDP), is contesting as the candidate of the Jamaat-e-Islami-led 11-party opposition alliance. PTI



Jellyfish Heart

Moon jellyfish are displayed at the Jellyfish Museum in Florida, a facility that is home to about 20 unique species of jellyfish found across the world, on Wednesday. AP

FBI adds gangster Major Singh on its 'wanted' list

Washington: The FBI is on the lookout for Major Singh, an Indian national allegedly involved in narcotics and illegal arms smuggling, and has placed him on the list of "wanted" criminals.

"Major Singh is wanted for his alleged involvement in a transnational criminal organisation engaged in racketeer-influenced and corrupt organisations conspiracy; conspiracy to engage in the business of dealing in firearms without a license; conspiracy to distribute and possess with intent to distribute controlled substances; and distribution of controlled substances," the FBI said on Tuesday. PTI

• SOME AUTHORS USE THEIR WRITINGS TO CALL ATTENTION TO THE HARSH REALITIES OF LIFE FOR MIGRANT AND GIG WORKERS, WHILE OTHERS CELEBRATE THE HUMANITY THAT FLOURISHES IN SPITE OF TOUGH CONDITIONS

China's worker-writers strike a chord as economic gloom and job insecurity spread

Yan Zhuang
August 19

A CHINESE food delivery driver rushes from gig to gig, measuring time by the number of jobs he completes instead of by the passing of the seasons. He toils in cities across China to send money back to his family, but has been away so long his son calls him "that man" instead of "Dad."

These are scenes from the poems of Wang Lijun, a food delivery driver, one of several Chinese poets and authors who have turned their experiences of repetitive factory labor and insecure gig work into art.

This literary genre has ballooned in popularity in recent years, as many Chinese have grown pessimistic about the economy. For a wide swath of society, wages have stagnated, youth unemployment is high and the promise of a better life in return for hard work has faded.

Some authors use their writing to call attention to the harsh realities of life for migrant and gig workers, while others celebrate the humanity that flourishes in spite of those conditions. Their styles are often raw and straightforward.

Writers such as Hu Anyan, a courier who wrote a bestselling memoir about the jobs he has worked across the gig economy, and Fan Yusu, who left her children behind to work as a live-

in nanny in Beijing, have tapped into these themes. They have published essays online that have been shared widely and led to book deals. Some bestsellers have been translated and published overseas.

Last month, Wang's new poetry collection, "Low Flight," won the Lu Xun Literary Prize, in the highest institutional recognition for the genre yet.

For the Chinese public, curiosity about these workers is intertwined with anxiety about their own prospects. The concern may be pronounced for members of China's middle class. They "pay more attention to these kinds of narratives because they may represent their



Food delivery riders in Shenzhen, China. NYT

future lives," said Zhu Ping, a professor of Chinese studies at University of California San Diego's literature department.

Gig and factory workers are ubiquitous, yet the hardship and indignities they endure are rarely depicted by China's state-

controlled media, which prefers a more positive spin. As the literary world's influence has grown, Chinese officials, wary of power of workers' grievances to illuminate policy shortcomings or spawn unrest, have increasingly sought to shape it, experts said.

Since the 1980s, rural workers have powered China's factories and cities while often being denied health insurance, unemployment and retirement benefits available to urban residents. The literary movement's early authors wrote essays and poems about their experiences in factories, but as manufacturing jobs have begun to disappear, new stars are doing gig work.

One such star is Hu, the cour-

ier who wrote a bestselling memoir. The book, *I Deliver Parcels in Beijing*, was published in 2023 in China, where it was deemed that year's best book by Douban, China's equivalent to Goodreads. It is a diatribe against 19 jobs he held over two decades across China, including as a sorter at a logistics company, security guard, convenience store worker and courier.

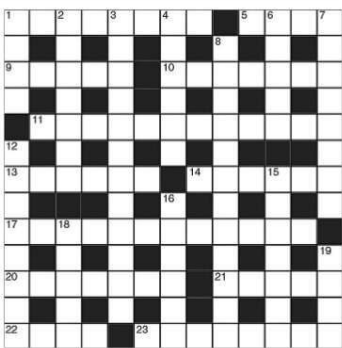
His work first came to public attention through an essay he posted online. It detailed his year on the night shift sorting packages at a logistics firm, where work was grueling and he struggled sleep during the day. "I passed by a row of houses on my way in every day. I could

smell the cooking going on inside, see the people collapsed on their couches, tired and content after a day's work. That, to me, was what true happiness looked like. Meanwhile I was already more exhausted than those people, and I hadn't even reached the warehouse. I cursed myself in those moments: My damned body cursed my willpower, and my damned willpower cursed it back. I swore I would go right to sleep when I clocked off in the morning. But then the morning came around, and everything went the same as the day before. I was trapped in a loop.

— *I Deliver Parcels in Beijing*, translated into English by Jack Hargreaves. NYT

CROSSWORD

6072



ACROSS

- 1 He keeps mum in order (8)
 5 Takes a choice sort of post (4)
 9 Father gets through one daily (5)
 10 A team won't be prepared to play without him (7)
 11 It won't keep you fully occupied (4-4,4)
 13 Suit the deed (6)
 14 Wrong option for a drink (6)
 17 Sporting event that has its ups and downs (12)
 20 Given command (7)
 21 Cuts a crop of crushed pears (5)
 22 Given the rent (4)
 23 It brings about a military rising (8)

DOWN

- 1 Do secretarial work of a sort (4)
 2 Stop when confronted by a snake on the road (7)
 3 Soldiers made to sort paper a form of it (12)
 4 Demonstrates it's in error (4,2)
 6 Point out a horse (5)
 7 Memorable industrial action (8)
 8 Don't bring prosecution for nothing (4,2,6)
 12 Narrow gap left for use to go between countries (8)
 15 Invest in a unit of the open market (7)
 16 Interfere being audibly cross (6)
 18 Spanish and German articles entitled to respect (5)
 19 Little land is left to the East (4)

SOLUTIONS CROSSWORD 6071 ACROSS: 1 Dashboard, 8 Ethos, 9 Assuage, 10 Divert, 11 Assign, 12 Decrease, 15 Tumblers, 16 Thumbs, 20 Reload, 21 Produce, 22 Siege, 23 Signoria DOWN: 2 Asses, 3 Hours, 4 Organic, 5 Denier, 6 Cheater, 7 Isotherms, 11 Austerity, 13 Cast-iron, 14 Implics, 16 Leaves, 17 Murder, 19 Bacon

JUMBLED WORDS

Given below are four jumbled words. Solve the jumbles to make proper words and move them to the respective circles below. Select the letters in the shaded circles and jumble them to get the answer for the given quip.

Nothing is more conducive to peace of mind than not having any ____ at all. - Georg Christoph Lichtenberg (8)

PSWOO



BELYN



ITVIS



OTUWNP



SOLUTIONS: PSWOO: Swallow, Vial, Byline, Laptop
 BELYN: Nothing is more conducive to peace of mind than not having any ____ at all. - Georg Christoph Lichtenberg (8)

OVER THE HEDGE



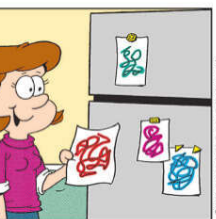
BY MICHAEL FRY & T LEWIS

CALVIN & HOBBS



BY BILL WATTERSON

MARVIN



BY TOM ARMSTRONG

DIFFICULTY LEVEL 2s

INSTRUCTIONS
 To solve a Sudoku puzzle, every digit from 1 to 9 must appear in each of the nine vertical columns, in each of the nine horizontal rows, and in each of the nine boxes.

DIFFICULTY LEVEL

1s = Very easy; 2s = Easy;
 3s = Medium; 4s = Hard;
 5s = Very Hard;
 6s = Genius

SUDOKU6416

5		2	9			1
	9	7	3			5
	9	8	1	4	3	
8	1				6	4
4	7	3	6	9		
2					8	
	7	8	2			
6		1	2			5

SOLUTION SUDOKU6415

2	9	8	1	6	7	4	3	5
1	7	3	2	5	4	9	8	6
4	5	6	9	8	3	7	1	2
8	4	2	5	3	1	6	9	7
9	6	7	8	4	2	3	5	1
3	1	5	6	7	9	2	4	8
7	2	9	3	1	8	5	6	4
6	3	1	4	2	5	8	7	9
5	8	4	7	9	6	1	2	3



RVNL: Suyash Trivedi has joined Rail Vikas Nigam Ltd (RVNL) as ED / Metro will lead the organisation's major metro and railway infrastructure projects. With 29 years of experience in planning, procurement, project execution, contract management and delivery of big infrastructure projects, he is an accomplished civil engineer. Previously, he has served in Engineers India Ltd, Military Engineer Services, Delhi Metro Rail Corporation and Mumbai Metro Rail Corporation. At RVNL, he is entrusted with strengthening our presence in metro and multimodal urban transport infrastructure.

EIL: reported a strong financial performance for Q1 FY2026-27, with standalone PBT rising 55% year-on-year to Rs145 crore from Rs94 crore. PAT also increased 55% to Rs109 crore from Rs70 crore. Operating margin improved to 14% (Rs108 crore), compared with 7% (Rs59 crore) a year earlier, while EBITDA rose to Rs155.44 crore, with an 18.55% margin. Consolidated PAT surged 141% to Rs157.94 crore from Rs65.40 crore. EIL's order book stood at Rs14,424 crore as of June 30, 2026, comprising Rs10,498 crore in consultancy and Rs3,926 crore in turnkey projects. The company remains focused on diversification, operational excellence, international expansion and opportunities across energy, energy transition and infrastructure sectors, supporting sustainable growth and long-term value creation.

CENTRAL BANK OF INDIA celebrates the 145th Birthday of its founding father Sorabji Pochkhanwala ji by organising a Plantation Drive with great enthusiasm and commitment towards the environment and society. As part of the celebration, Zonal Head, TARSEEM SINGH ZIRA, Deputy Zonal Head T C Meena and other staff members participated in a tree plantation drive under the Ek Ped Maa Ke Naam initiative, reaffirming our collective responsibility towards environmental conservation and a greener future. The occasion was also marked by taking a pledge for the Nasha Mukta Bharat Abhiyan, demonstrating our commitment towards building a healthy, responsible and drug-free society.

RECPDCL handed over Vizag Power Transmission Limited, a project-specific SPV, to Adani Energy Solutions Limited recently. Adani Energy Solutions emerged as the successful bidder through the Tariff-Based Competitive Bidding process for developing the interstate transmission system supporting proposed green hydrogen and green ammonia projects in Vizag, Andhra Pradesh. The project includes major substations and transmission lines spanning over 770 km, along with associated works. Scheduled for completion in 30 months, the project has an estimated cost of Rs8,386 crore and will strengthen power infrastructure for emerging green energy projects. The initiative will also support reliable power connectivity for the region's growing clean energy ecosystem.



PETRONET LNG hosted its second Finance & IT Meet, titled - "Catalyst", a platform to inspire ideas, foster collaboration and drive meaningful transformation on 7-8 August 2026 at the Corporate Office, New Delhi. The two-day meet together Finance & IT professionals from across PLL's locations for insightful discussions, brainstorming and knowledge-sharing, along with engaging sessions led by domain experts. Speaking about the event Saurav Mitta, Director (Finance) & CFO, said "Catalyst reflects the continuing journey to build a more agile, technology-enabled and future-ready organisation. As Petronet LNG Ltd. grows and diversifies, Finance must evolve alongside the business, using technology to enable growth, strengthen governance and support faster, informed decision-making."

BANK OF BARODA has raised USD 700 million through a dual-tranche overseas bond issuance under its USD 4 billion Medium-Term Note Programme. Issued through its IFSC Banking Unit at GIFT City, the offering comprised USD 400 million of three-year notes at a 5.114% coupon and USD 300 million of five-year notes at 5.318%. The issue attracted strong investor interest, with the order book peaking at USD 2.67 billion, nearly 3.8 times the final issue size. Strong demand enabled the bank to tighten pricing significantly from initial guidance. The issuance achieved the tightest-ever spread over US Treasuries in the bank's bond-issuance history. The bonds are rated BBB (Stable) by S&P BBB- (Stable) by Fitch and BBB (Stable) by CareEdge Global.

CORPORATE BRIEFS



PMSG A National Vendor Meet under the PM- Surya Ghar: Muft Bijli Yojana was jointly conducted by WBSEDCL and REC Ltd. at Hotel Taj Bengal, New Alipore, Kolkata, with an aim to strengthen the implementation of the scheme and accelerate rooftop solar installations across West Bengal. The meeting was chaired by Santanu Basu, IAS, Principal Secretary, Power Department, Government of West Bengal. Officials from REC Ltd, CESC, the Government of West Bengal, State and National Vendors, and Training Partners also participated in the meeting. Addressing the gathering, the Principal Secretary, Power Department, Government of West Bengal, emphasised that the implementation of PMSG-MBY in the state would be further strengthened through the active participation and coordinated efforts of both State and National Vendors.



BHEL: A strategic collaboration between BHEL and Norway-based Hyster AS will enable the phased indigenisation and local manufacturing of PEM electrolyser systems for green hydrogen projects in India. The agreement was signed by Mr. Y. Srinivas Rao, ED (Heavy Power Equipment Plant, Hyderabad), and Sutripto De, GM & Head (New & Renewable Energy Business), on behalf of BHEL, and Fredrik Mowill, CEO (Hyster), on behalf of Hyster AS, in the presence of Arvind Ekeland Gadgil, Chargé d'Affaires, Royal Norwegian Embassy in New Delhi, and other senior officials. BHEL had earlier entered into a strategic tie-up with thyssenkrupp nucera India Private Limited for alkaline electrolyser systems. The collaboration will further strengthen BHEL's project execution capabilities for green hydrogen projects in India, supporting India's clean energy transition and self-reliance.

INDIAN OIL: Arvind Kumar, Director (Refineries), Indian Oil, led the 80th Independence Day celebrations at the IndianOil Township in Noida, joined by Team IndianOil and their families. The event featured the Rashtra Gede, marking 150 years of Vande Mataram, followed by flag hoisting and the National Anthem. Addressing employees, Kumar called for an economically resilient, technologically advanced, environmentally responsible and energy self-reliant India. Highlighting IndianOil's role in sustaining energy supplies through crises, he described IOCIans as "Energy Soldiers". He outlined priorities including safety, innovation, digital transformation, AI, indigenous technologies and sustainable energy. He also urged children to dream fearlessly and contribute to Viksit Bharat@2047.

PETRONET LNG reported a 33% year-on-year rise in standalone PBT to Rs1,514 crore in Q1 FY2026-27 from Rs1,136 crore, while PAT also grew 33% to Rs1,133 crore from Rs851 crore. Dahel terminal processed 192 TBTU of LNG during the quarter, compared with 207 TBTU a year earlier, while overall LNG volumes stood at 207 TBTU against 220 TBTU. Capacity utilisation at Dahel was 66%, compared with 92% a year ago, following the terminal's capacity expansion to 22.5 MMTPA from 17.5 MMTPA. Company-wide utilisation stood at 58%, compared with 76% in the corresponding quarter.

ROYAL STARS

BY GEORGIA NICOLS



ARIES (MAR 21 - APR 20): You might be interested in unusual, powerful ideas today. They might even be related to improving yourself somehow. Be aware that this is also a mildly accident-prone day for you. Pay attention to everything you say and do. Tonight: Explore.



TAURUS (APR 21 - MAY 21): Yes, you're a financial wizard; however, today you have to be on your toes. You might be confused about something, financially speaking. You might be deceived. Something unexpected could impact your assets. Tonight: Check your finances.



GEMINI (MAY 22 - JUNE 21): You might genuinely want to help a friend today. You also might be moved by philosophical or powerful ideas. Someone might surprise you today. Stay light on your feet. Tonight: Genuinely listen.



CANCER (JUNE 22 - JULY 23): Today you might have a strong desire to make improvements to your health or your job. This is coming from a desire for perfection, perhaps. Something out of the blue could be unsettling. It might make you change your mind suddenly. Tonight: Work.



LEO (JULY 24 - AUG 23): This is a romantic day for you. You're also in touch with your muse, which is why you can express your creative talents. A friend or a member of a group might throw you a curveball. This is a mildly accident-prone day for your kids. Tonight: Socialise.



VIRGO (AUG 24 - SEP 23): Your home routine might be interrupted today. A minor appliance might break down or a small breakage could occur. If you're making a decision to share property or money with someone, double-check your information. Tonight: Relax at home.



LIBRA (SEP 24 - OCT 23): This might be a lovely day for you to shop for wardrobe items. It's also a mildly accident-prone day for you. A romantic connection might be powerful. Tonight: An interesting conversation.



SCORPIO (OCT 24 - NOV 23): Keep an eye on your money and possessions today, because an element of confusion is present. You might feel generous and then later regret it. You might be confused or even deceived about finances. Tonight: Check your belongings.



SAGITTARIUS (NOV 24 - DEC 22): Today, your idealism is aroused and you might feel sympathetic to children and romantic partners. Tonight: You win!



CAPRICORN (DEC 23 - JAN 20): You might be happiest today by being low-key and working alone or behind the scenes. Keep an eye on your money and possessions. Be realistic when dealing with a family member. This could be an accident-prone day for your pet. Tonight: Privacy.



AQUARIUS (JAN 21 - FEB 19): Friendships are important to you today. You might idealise a friend or want to help them in some way. Something out of left field could impact a friendship. It might relate to romance or children. Or you might meet a real character today. Tonight: Friendships.



PISCES (FEB 20 - MAR 20): People notice you today. They might admire you; they might even attribute qualities to you that you don't think you have. However, something unexpected related to home and family might surprise you. Steady as she goes. Tonight: You're admired.

PNB:

The 124th meeting of the SLBC, Delhi was held on recently at Hyatt Regency, New Delhi, chaired by Principal Secretary Santosh D. Vaidya and M. Paramasivam, ED, PNB. Senior officials and banking sector dignitaries, including Sarada Prasan Mohanty, Regional Director, RBI; Nazim Kumar, MD, DSIIID; and Rajneesh Gupta, Joint Commissioner of Delhi Police, attended the meeting. Santosh D. Vaidya reviewed the performance of banks under PM Surya Ghar and various social security schemes. Nazim Kumar briefed banks on the Delhi State DGS scheme, under which 95% covers are available, and urged banks to extend finance to eligible beneficiaries, highlighting the role of credit support in promoting entrepreneurship and economic development in Delhi.



UGB:

A new partnership between UGB and SBI Pension Funds Pvt. Ltd. aims to expand pension awareness and retirement planning solutions across Uttarakhand through an MOU for the MSF Distribution Agreement. The MOU was signed in the presence of Harihar Patnaik, Chairman, Uttarakhand Gramin Bank; Pranay Ranjan Dwivedi, MD & CEO; and Mukhtyar Singh, CBO, SBI Pension Funds Pvt. Ltd. Under the MSF framework, customers will benefit from enhanced retirement planning solutions through Jeevan Swarna and Akshay Dhara schemes. The partnership will strengthen pension inclusion and financial security, contributing to the vision of "Pension for All" across Uttarakhand.



POWERGRID

received the PMIS Recognition of Partner Company Award in the 'Innovation in Exit Pathways' category on August 14, 2026, in New Delhi. The award was presented by the Ministry of Corporate Affairs and received by Dr. Yatindra Dwivedi, Director (Personnel), along with the POWERGRID team. Since joining the Prime Minister Internship Scheme, POWERGRID has offered 6,265 internship opportunities through the first two pilot rounds. It has also facilitated employment pathways by uploading intern details on the Rozgar portal of the Power Sector Skill Council. As of July 31, 2026, POWERGRID operates 292 substations and over 1,86,889 km of transmission lines.



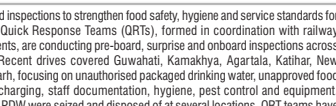
REC:

Under its CSR initiative, REC Limited provided 36 Mobile Medical Units worth Rs 7.21 crore to Chhattisgarh. Hon. Governor Ramen Deka flagged off the units at Lok Bhawan on August 15, 2026, in the presence of REC officials and representatives of the Indian Red Cross Society, Chhattisgarh. The initiative aims to bridge healthcare gaps and strengthen last-mile medical services in underserved areas, bringing essential care closer to communities. It reflects REC's commitment to inclusive and sustainable development and supports the vision of a healthier, more inclusive Viksit Bharat.



IRCTC:

has intensified inspections to strengthen food safety, hygiene and service standards for railway passengers. Quick Response Teams (QRTs), formed in coordination with railway commercial departments, are conducting pre-board, surprise and onboard inspections across trains and stations. Recent drives covered Guwahati, Kamakhya, Agartala, Kathihar, New Jalpaiguri and Dibrugarh, focusing on unauthorised packaged drinking water, unapproved food and beverages, overcharging, staff documentation, hygiene, pest control and equipment. Unapproved food and PDW were seized and disposed of at several locations. QRT teams have been activated across IRCTC zones and regions. IRCTC has advised catering providers to ensure strict compliance, warning that violations will invite penal action under applicable licence terms.



ITPO:

celebrated India's 80th Independence Day with a flag-hoisting ceremony at Bharat Mandapam, New Delhi. Amb. Javed Ashraf, Chairman, ITPO, hoisted the National Flag in the presence of officials, followed by ceremonial honours by the CISF contingent, a march past and the National Anthem. The ITPO fraternity participated with patriotic fervour and enthusiasm, reflecting unity and national pride. Addressing the gathering, Amb. Ashraf reaffirmed ITPO's commitment to strengthening India's trade and enterprise ecosystem in the spirit of an Atmanirbhar Bharat. He emphasised empowering Indian businesses and helping them expand their reach across India and global markets.



Duleep Trophy final relocated to Chennai



MA Chidambaram Stadium will host the summit clash. CREMAS

Express News Service Mumbai, August 19

THE DULEEP Trophy 2026-27 final has been moved from the Centre of Excellence (CoE) in Bengaluru to the M.A. Chidambaram Stadium in Chennai, allowing spectators to attend the summit clash. The final will take place from September 6-10, with the venue change aimed at giving fans an opportunity to watch the domestic first-class tournament's title clash live at the stadium.

"The Duleep Trophy is an important first-class tournament in the calendar and carries rich legacy. The quality of cricket is always high, and we want fans to have the opportunity to watch the final live at the stadium," BCCI secretary Devajit Saikia said in a statement.

The decision to move the final was primarily driven by restrictions on noted attendance at the CoE. Saikia said that shifting the match to Chennai would allow supporters to be part of the occasion while also providing a more suitable setting for the tournament's final fixture.

"There are certain restrictions regarding crowd attendance at the CoE, and we felt it was appropriate to move the final to a venue where fans can attend and be part of the occasion," he added.

The board secretary had said earlier this month that restrictions imposed when the land for the CoE was procured meant spectators could not be allowed at the facility. "There are some restrictions while this land was adopted here..., that we cannot have a crowd in this campus. So, that is a government restriction. We cannot violate that," he had told select media in Bengaluru.

The remainder of the tournament will go ahead as scheduled at the CoE, beginning on August 23. East Zone will face Northeast Zone in one quarter-final, while North Zone will take on West Zone in the other.

Three of the four quarter-finalists feature high-profile players, including Ishan Kishan, Mohammed Shami, Arshdeep Singh, Vaibhav Sooryavanshi and Ruturaj Gaikwad.

South Zone and Central Zone are already in the semi-finals, which will also be played at the CoE from August 30.

The BCCI has also increased the tournament's broadcast coverage this season. All Duleep Trophy matches will be streamed live, while television coverage will be available for one quarter-final, one semi-final and the final.

Central Zone are the reigning Duleep Trophy champions.

Manav's 10-wicket haul powers Gill & Co to 165-run win, securing a 1-0 lead

Venkata Krishna B
Chennai, August 19

AS THE top-edge from Dhananjaya de Silva's bat lobbed into the hands of Manav Suthar at fine leg, one could hear the relief as Ravindra Jadeja cleared his throat. Since being given a lifeline by the spinner via a no-ball late on Day 4, he was waging an improbable battle, frustrating India in the company of Sonal Dinusha before he made the only mistake of his innings, off the 151st ball he faced. Jadeja provided the desperate breakthrough India sought; in the next 22.2 overs they wrapped up a 165-run win before the dark clouds hovering over Galle opened up for one final time.

The downpour was five minutes too late for Sri Lanka, who are now facing a third successive home series defeat to India if they fail to win the next Test at Colombo beginning Sunday.

Having started the day at 84/4, the hosts had an enormous task ahead of them to prevent India from going 1-0 up in the series. The pitch didn't have any hidden demons, and to make any inroads, the bowlers had to be patient and be consistent in their line and lengths. And the right-left pair of De Silva and Dinusha was in no mood to make the win any easier for India. For 202 deliveries, during which time they stitched a 95-run stand for the fifth wicket, they ensured India had to use every ounce of energy to separate them. You could hear Suthar, who ended up with six wickets and, ended up with a match ball of 10/131, almost grunting each time he rolled his arm. Ditto with Kuldeep Yadav. It was one such surface, where the spinners had to put everything in to get the rewards. They would keep massuers busy for the next couple of days as there is only a three-day turnaround before the second Test at Sinhalese Sports Ground.

When Jadeja had overstepped late on last evening after dismissing De Silva with a



Prasidh Krishna celebrates taking the wicket of Sri Lanka's Niroshan Dickwella on Day Five of the first Test match in Galle. CREMAS

Scorecard

SRI LANKA vs INDIA, GALLE TOSS: India won, chose to bat

India 1st innings	462	EXTRAS (b 5, lb 1, nb 3)	9
Sri Lanka 1st innings	284	• TOTAL (77/4 Overs)	206
India 2nd innings	193		

SRI LANKA (O/N 84/4)

Djaya de Silva c Suthar b Suthar	59 (15b, 7x4)
Sonal Dinusha c Jurel b Suthar	50 (15b, 7x4)
Niroshan Dickwella c Pant b Suthar	84 (12b, 8x4, 1x6)
Keshara Nuwantha c Gill b Jadeja	10 (17b, 1x4)
Prabath Jayasuriya b Suthar	20 (6b, 3x4)
Lahiru Kumara c Pant b Suthar	0 (1b)
Aisitha Fernando not out	0 (1b)

peach, little did India know they had to work so hard for this win. When it comes to batting in the second innings, the Sri Lanka captain is the only subcontinent batsman to have an average over 50. So when it comes to applying himself on a deteriorating pitch, Sri Lanka could bank on De Silva. Of course, the win was far out of their sight.

Hard toil

But right through the stand, the approach from De Silva (59) and Dinusha (84), who were unfortunate not to end up with a century in each innings, didn't enter a shell. They were not going in search of boundaries either to put pressure on India's attack. But they found a middle ground - rotate the strike and don't allow the spinners the opportunity to tie one of them at one end. It meant the trio of Suthar, Jadeja and Kuldeep had to keep switching their angles and lines.

With the pitch getting Test slower, to their credit, both Suthar and Jadeja showed the patience that the conditions demanded. It was always

going to be a matter of one wicket, and it was De Silva who went back kicking the turf. Right through his knock, he had shown restraint when it came to picking the right deliveries to sweep.

But sweeping ones in the line of stumps, particularly from the only rough patch on the pitch, brings its own risk

into play. And as soon as he swept Jadeja from the line of stumps, he knew the writing on the wall was getting clearer. The lone remaining threat for India was the unpredictable Niroshan Dickwella, who had scored 80 in the first essay, curbing his natural instinct to a large extent.

Here, with a game to save,

more than Prasidh Krishna, it was Yashasvi Jaiswal who ensured his stay was short.

As Prasidh was tempting to take on the short ball, Dickwella was hesitant at first before Jaiswal urged him to take on. It was a fun banter, but he ended up with Dickwella making room and trying to slash Prasidh over covers, only to nick to Rishabh Pant. The laughter said it all.

Thereafter, Dinusha, in the company of Keshara Nuwantha, frustrated India again, adding 43 off 91 deliveries as the lunch break arrived at the right time for the visitors. And once they came back after the break, Suthar wrapped up India's 600th Test with a win in the space of 16 deliveries.

First he had Dinusha caught at leg-slip; with extra bounce, he generated the key. Off the next delivery, he cleaned up Prabath Jayasuriya's stumps before finishing that over with his second five-wicket haul. Having picked up four in the first innings, Suthar castled Nuwantha as India took a crucial step in the direction of qualifying for the World Test Championship final.

Robinson rips through Pakistan in Headingley Test

Associated Press
Leeds, August 19

SEAMER OLLIE Robinson made another dramatic return for England as he hammered the Pakistan top order on the first day of the test series on Wednesday at Headingley.

Pakistan was collapsing at 150-7 as tea after an extended three-hour session due to the morning short by rain.

Robinson took out four of the top five batters - all bowled or unassisted - including a

wicket with the first ball of the three-match series.

He had 4-39 from 16 overs in his first test since June at Lord's, where he took a match-winning 7-77 against New Zealand and in his first test in two years.

A knee injury and doubts about the fitness prevented his return in that series that England lost.

The other three wickets were grabbed by Josh Tongue, who broke Pakistan's biggest partnership then, right on tea, dismissed interim captain Salman Agha and Ali Usman in

consecutive deliveries. Tea was immediately called, delaying Tongue's hat-trick ball.

Featuring in a four-prong pace attack, Robinson made a sensational start when he pinned Azeem Azhar first ball with a nip-bowling from around the wicket. Then he went over the wicket and trapped Shan Masood.

Only 94 overs into the game, rain forced a delay of two hours.

Abdullah Shafiq and Imam, together from 6-2, endured a

cautious return in the afternoon and gradually became comfortable enough to push the run-rate.

But after 91 runs together, Imam drove at a wide ball by Tongue and nicked to second slip. Walking off with 42, Imam castled himself. From 97-2, Pakistan lost five wickets for 53 runs.

After Shafiq brought up his 13th fifty-plus score from 82 balls, Saud Shakeel was given out lbw to Robinson by umpire Allahuddin Paleker, who took his time. Shakeel also took his time to review the decision and

was timed out by umpire Chris Gaffaney. Video showed the ball missing the top of leg stump.

Shafiq departed soon after, for 61, bowled by Robinson, who by then had wicket-keeper Jamie Smith standing up to the stumps for added pressure. In the last five minutes before tea, Tongue bowled Agha and Usman.

BRIEF SCORES: Pakistan 150/7 (Abdullah Shafique 61, Ollie Robinson 4/39) in 44.4 overs vs England at Tea on Day 1.

With an arm-ball in his repertoire, Suthar is a genuine threat

Venkata Krishna B
Chennai, August 19

LEFT-ARM-SPINNER Manav Suthar's long-time coach Dheeraj Sharma had a simple piece of advice for him ahead of the first Test against Sri Lanka in Galle. His message was short: "Keep attacking the stumps."

The Galle pitch had turned, but patience and consistency were non-negotiable for bowlers. Dheeraj wanted Suthar, playing only his second Test but with 33 First-Class matches under his belt, to force a batsman into making mistakes. "Only if he plays, will the batsman make mistakes," Dheeraj told *The Indian Express* from Sri Ganganagar district in Rajasthan. The 24-year-old returned figures of 10/131, with six of these wickets coming in Sri Lanka's second innings as India won by 165 runs. In two Tests, Suthar has two six-wicket hauls — the first coming against Afghanistan on his debut in June. For someone who is being looked at as Ravindra Jadeja's eventual replacement, Suthar's success comes well for India.

"They (team) had put their trust in him. If he didn't get wickets, then questions would be raised. We knew he didn't have many wickets (domestic cricket) to show. But what we did together was to ensure he was ready to play in any condition. Our target was when an opportunity comes, make most out of it. And for that we had been busy since the off-season," Dheeraj said.

For a spinner who predominantly delivered the ball with the seam facing the first slip, there were concerns if batsmen would be able to pick him from the hand easily. Over the course of this Test, Suthar showed he had a bag of tricks. At times, he delivered with the seam facing the square and more importantly showed he can deliver an arm ball. It is a delivery he has been working a lot.

A left-spinner with a straighter one makes life hard for batsmen. "Personally, I was so happy with the three wickets which came off the straighter one. Because, we have been working on it for a while," Dheeraj said.

Since Rahul Dravid's tenure as coach, Suthar has been on the radar of the selectors and the team management. But playing for Rajasthan, a team that hasn't been in the top bracket of Ranji Trophy, Suthar didn't have compelling numbers. At different times, different selectors have taken note of his ability to be effective on green tops, slow decks, raging turners and flat pitches. Gautam Gambhir & Co. put their faith in him.

When the selectors picked Suthar, they had a plan of India



Left-arm spinner Manav Suthar had figures of 10/131. CREMAS

“We knew he didn't have many wickets (domestic cricket) to show. But what we did together was to ensure he was ready to play in any condition. Our target was when an opportunity comes, make most out of it.”
DHEERAJ SHARMA, MANAV SUTHAR'S COACH

having a settled spin combo by the time of the next Border-Gavaskar Trophy at home early next year. Against Afghanistan, Suthar showed glimpses of his talent. And at Galle, he outshined not just his teammates Jadeja and Kuldeep Yadav, but also the main home spinner Prabath Jayasuriya. Suthar has everything that makes him a classical, old-school spinner, but inexperience couldn't be overlooked. "With the wicket being on the slower side, we just discussed about finding that one spot from where you can keep attacking. And given his hip movement and the balance, we knew that if we kept bowling on the full length, he has more chance of succeeding because he was getting more turn than the rest and he extracts bounce with his high-arm release," Dheeraj said.

Arm speed

KL Rahul, who got to witness it all from the first slip, had a good idea of what a batsman was up against. "It's the subtle variations. The same actions, the same angles. Without changing his arm speed, he's able to bowl slower, and with the same arm speed, he's able to bowl quicker as well. Sometimes the angles, especially in the air, when the wind is blowing from one side, he used that drift really well here in Galle, and from there the ball straightens or comes in. Just using subtle variations, he's able to do that through the day," he said after the match.

Kyrgios suspended after testing positive for cocaine

Express News Service
Mumbai, August 19

NICK KYRGIOS has been provisionally suspended from tennis after testing positive for cocaine, with the Australian acknowledging that he made a "huge mistake" and taking full responsibility for the violation.

In a statement posted on Instagram, Kyrgios apologised to his fans, family, sponsors and those close to him. He expressed particular regret over the example his actions could set for young supporters. "I made a huge mistake, and I take full responsibility for it," Kyrgios wrote. The Australian said the past few years, during which persistent knee and wrist injuries have severely limited his career, had taken a significant toll on him mentally and physically. "My body hasn't been able to do what my mind expects it to do. None of that excuses what I did," he wrote.



Nick Kyrgios. REUTERS

He added that he would step away from social media and public life for 28 days to focus on his well-being.

Kyrgios submitted a sample during the Mallorca Open on June 22 that was found to contain benzoylecgonine, a metabolite of cocaine. A WADA-accredited laboratory confirmed the finding on July 17.

• CHASING NORMS, BREAKING NORMS

Chess prodigy Deekshitha's father starts crowdfunding

Amrit Kamath
Mumbai, August 19

IT'S BEEN a year since Deekshitha Modipalli made headlines in the world of chess, with a rating jump of 484 Elo points over the course of a month that also lifted her world rank by 29,200 spots. Her results, across just four tournaments, also earned her an International Master norm, opening new ambitions for the 14-year-old.

But in the days after that rise, reality followed. The costs of keeping it going had gone up just as fast. Her game came over the course of one trip to Europe. To keep raising her rating and picking up the norms she needed, she'll need several more such trips. So her father, M. Sheshadri Nayudu, decided to try crowdfunding to help fund her path toward becoming an International Master, and perhaps, eventually, a grandmaster.

Sheshadri, an IT professional from Hampapur vil-

lage in Andhra Pradesh's Anantapur district, started the campaign on Ketto four days ago. With donations from 14 supporters so far, the family has raised Rs 51,000 toward a target of Rs 15 lakh, set over 45 days. On the campaign page, Sheshadri broke the target down: Rs 4 lakh for coaching and training fees, Rs 3 lakh for accommodation, Rs 2 lakh for airfare, Rs 2 lakh for tournament preparation, Rs 2 lakh for food and other travel expenses, Rs 1 lakh for tournament entry fees, Rs 50,000 for local transport, and Rs 30,000 for visas.

The plan is to use the funds raised to sponsor a couple of tournament trips to Europe. Deekshitha is already headed to the 2026 Chess Olympiad back tournaments. Beyond that, if she is to reach the level of family and coach, Krishna Teja, believe she's capable of, considerably more will be needed. Crowdfunding remains a route rarely taken in Indian



Deekshitha's family is trying to raise Rs 15 lakh. LECA OPEN

chess. Ethan Vaz, who went on to become India's 96th grandmaster, international master Muhammad Imran, and Woman Candidate Master Shihmshika G., have all attempted it before. "Over the past week, despite all the headlines, no one has contacted me from the government or from

private sponsors. In the past, I had seen a few players try out fundraising through various platforms. So I decided this could be an option," Sheshadri told *The Indian Express*.

It's a hard truth of Indian chess that sponsors tend to gravitate toward established super-GMs, who often already

receive "conditions" from tournament organisers, waived entry fees, boarding and lodging covered, sometimes flights too, and appearance fees in certain cases. It's the players still chasing rating and norms through open tournaments in Europe who have to fund all of it themselves.

Cost of ascend

Any player looking to move up from the 2200-rating range needs top-tier coaches, whose costs are often billed hourly rather than at a flat fee. Sheshadri said that until a certain level, he had paid an annual coaching fee. As his daughter's rating rose, that shifted to an hourly rate.

Deekshitha's coach, international master Krishna Teja, said Sheshadri's Rs 15 lakh target is the bare minimum, with little room to spare.

"The ideal budget for any prodigy chasing norms and rating gains is around Rs 25 to 30 lakh annually. That would be the scenario where the player

has everything they need: a parent travelling with them to handle logistics during tournaments, one-on-one coaching, and so on," Krishna Teja told *The Indian Express*.

The bare minimum, according to the coach, is Rs 15-17 lakh. "That's if she travels alone, without a parent, and trains in a group with higher-rated players. That budget would include three to four trips to Europe for tournaments, which alone would run to around Rs 10-12 lakh. Since her level has risen, coaching fees will also be around Rs 3.5 to 4 lakh, because she now needs one-on-one sessions too. She needs coaching with a stronger group, and personal classes as well. At the moment, the coaching fee is around Rs 3.5 to 4 lakh for a year" he added.

Teja said that if Deekshitha manages to raise Rs 15 lakh within a year, there is a real possibility she could become an IM within that time.

BWF WORLD CHAMPIONSHIPS

Lollipop low lifts lay Lakshya low against unknown American

Indian beaten by 18-year-old Tan in a display that left coach Vimal Kumar saying 'there's no excuse'

Shivani Naik
New Delhi, August 19

SAIPAN, FULLERTON, Aguascalientes, Lima, Sao Paulo, Uppsala, Markham, Jotunhallen, Council Bluffs, San Salvador. These are some of the venues where American teenager Garret Tan, who defeated Lakshya Sen at his first-ever World Championships, has been plodding away, playing lower-level tournaments.

The 18-year-old has no fixed training base and no permanent coach. He moves to and from Taiwan, camping at his grandparents' because quality sparring is difficult to get in California. Tan isn't even firmed up yet on singles and won the mixed doubles at Junior All England.

His childhood coach Paula Lynn travelled to Delhi to sit for his matches at his debut Worlds. Fellow American shuttler Lauren Lam completed an all-women coaching bench, with his mother helping out with assorted support, while he evicted the big Indian hoo, ranked 14th, 19-21, 21-19, 21-17, sending shockwaves through the arena.

The next generation isn't creeping upon Sen. They are at his throat. His potential roadblocks were expected to be batchmate Kunlavut Vitidsarn (25) or junior Alex Lanier (22). Not Tan, who played the World Juniors in Guwahati last October and put twice All England finalist through the wringer.

There was no glaring injury concerns for Sen, though the shoulder was strapped like



Lakshya Sen lost 21-19, 19-21, 17-21 to American Garret Tan in the second round. P11

usual. He had trained for a week in Guwahati, though on this day, it wasn't the drift that messed up his judgment. It was his wobbly confidence, and wrecked intent.

Tan plays the typical doubles player's aggressive ambush - a whacking smash when he's offered the length to hit. It's not Sen's favourite style to tackle, but it's something he hasn't doused before.

What was inexplicable was Sen offering his rookie opponent lollipop low lifts - the length so short that he contributed to his own downfall.

"There is no excuse for this performance," coach Vimal Kumar would say. Sen simply couldn't close out the match in two games, as he repeatedly blun-

dered through rushed brawny rallies, prolonging which would've given him the space to bring his brains to the table.

Familiar failing

Vimal had been peeved by Sen's approach in Round 1 too, in which he dropped the opening game. On Wednesday after he was edged out 21-19 in the second, it was assumed he would blitz past Tan in the decider, once sides changed. But it was never about the drift.

The short lifts were such a tactical trip-up that the passive, pensive, ponderous Sen stood no chance as long as he was serving them up as if he was Tan's junior sparrer. He betrayed a crisis of confidence, as he looked like he was in no

mood to grit it out in rallies. Sen simply gets bogged down when he runs into anyone with a half-decent back corner. He has the mind, the manipulation smarts, the montage of tricks to outlast the best. But he seems to tie in his game's self-worth to muscle, like he's some gym-bro.

It meant if he couldn't match Tan in style and swagger, he wouldn't put in the court mileage to get under the shuttle and belt the downward shots. If he was on a wrestling mat, he would've been warned for passivity, such was his phlegmatic play.

Tan, an unusually tall Asian-American, who has been in the habit of asking his coach many questions since he was

young, happily took the initiative and went the distance.

Sen restored parity by winning the second game with a start-to-finish lead. But it still went to 21-19. Later, Sen would say he was always playing catch-up.

"Always covering the leads, and under pressure. He was solid on the attack game," the Indian would say.

Change of plan

If only Sen had known that Tan had his return tickets booked for Friday - Thursday mostly penciled in for Qutub Minar and Janpath - and paced himself better and calmly. When his reflexive defence came under heavy shelling, Sen folded. Yet again. Just like he did against Viktor Axelsen and Lee Zhi Jia at the Olympics and Lin Chun Yi at All England.

In the decider, he fell to a 4-12 deficit. One would back Sen to rumble back. And he did till 10-13. But the aggressive gear kicked in far too late, far too desperately. The American women had done a smart SWAT on Sen - given the Indian puts pressure on opponents with his explosive stomp from the front court, using his half-smashes and net tricks, he needed to be pinned to the backline.

All Tan did was keep ping-pong tosses and clears to Sen's forehead back corner - where countless upstarts have fancied their chances to bury him.

What sets him apart as a shuttler not to be trifled with is how Tan switched up his attack like when Sen cut the lead to 16-18. "Last couple of points I changed my flank," he would disclose.

A slide in defence saw Tan glaze out, checked out by the doctor for concussion. What was unmissable though was Sen sitting down panting heavily himself. He played a disastrous floater to go 16-19 down. Tan wrapped up with two slashing smashes. Sen wasn't even in the same frame.

Sindhu and Ayush have easy day, tough one ahead

Prithish Raj
New Delhi, August 19

AYUSH SHETTY and PV Sindhu took a combined 61 minutes to finish their matches on a day when a lot of contests went to three games, with Anders Antonsen and Nhat Nguyen engaging in a 102-minute battle.

It was in the best interests of the two Indian star shuttlers to have short matches, given the opponents they will be facing in the next round of the Badminton World Championships. Sindhu - who defeated Wen Yu Zhang of Canada 21-16, 21-17 - will be up against World No. 3 Wang Zhi Yi. The Chinese leads the head-to-head 5-3 and has won their last three meetings. However, Sindhu prevailed when they met at last year's World Championships.

"It will be difficult. When we are playing top athletes, we can't expect easy matches or easy points," Sindhu said after

her match on Wednesday. "We know each other's game. I need to play my game and give my best." Sindhu, who recently won the Japan Open Super 750 title, has an 8-0 record against Chinese shuttlers at the World Championships.

"Pressure will always be there. Expectations will always be there. In such a game, one needs to be adaptable to the conditions. If one plan is not working, go for the other one and make a comeback," she said.

The conditions at the Indira Gandhi stadium have been tricky this week but Sindhu will have the advantage of playing in front of a home crowd.

"Today, I felt the court was different from the first day. According to my understanding, there were some unforced errors where I was hitting side-outs. That's what I felt. Going into tomorrow's match, I need to focus on playing my best, playing a safe game and being consistent," the double Olympi-



PV Sindhu defeated Canada's Wen Yu Zhang 21-16, 21-17. P11

pic medalist explained.

During the pre-tournament interaction, Wang had said that familiarity with Sindhu's game will be helpful for her in the two faced off. "She is coming on the back of the Japan Open win and we have shared many

The conditions at the IG stadium have been tricky this week but Sindhu will have the advantage of playing in front of a home crowd

duels in the past. I know her game and will just focus on being better than her," the Chinese had said.

Wang also had an easy encounter as she defeated Leshana Karupatharajah of Malaysia 21-16, 21-9 in 42 minutes.

With Unnati Hooda losing to Michelle Li 21-11, 9-21, 21-23, Sindhu remains the only Indian left in the women's singles draw.

Familiar foe

Ayush, who stunned World No. 1 Shi Yuqi of China in the first round, wrapped up his match against Dumindu Abe-

wickrama of Sri Lanka 21-8, 21-10 in 26 minutes. "It was a breather as compared to the previous game. I have played him in the past, so I just wanted to test some of my shots," Ayush said after his win.

In the next round, he will face 11th seed Alwi Farhan of Indonesia and it is not going to be an easy outing for him.

The duo have come up against each other four times at the senior level and the head-to-head is tied at 2-2. "I have played Alwi in the past and we are familiar with each other's games. It is not going to be easy for me. I am counting on my confidence and the crowd's support," the Indian said.

The last two met at the China Open Super 1000, with Ayush coming out on top. However, ranked 12 in the world, Alwi is one of the best Indonesian shuttlers in recent times and his stock is rising with consistent performance at the elite level.



Harmanpreet Singh (L) and Abhishek Nain scored two goals each. HOCKEY INDIA

India beat Pakistan 5-3 in a game far messier than the scoreline suggests

Mihir Vasavda
Mumbai, August 19

FOR A while, it looked as if India might make a mockery of the occasion. Then, Pakistan made a mess of the script.

India were 3-0 up. Then 4-1. Twice they appeared to have done enough to drain the life out of Pakistan's World Cup hopes. By the time the final whistle went at the Wagoner Stadium, India had won 5-3 and booked their place in the next phase. But the eight-goal scoreline concealed a much tighter, much messier contest.

Pakistan had arrived with their World Cup survival on the line. India needed only a draw to progress. It was Pakistan, though, who succeeded in dictating the mood of the match. India began like a team that knew exactly what it wanted. A good measure of their comfort on the field was how easily they switched to the aerial game. Against England, India had to wait till the fourth quarter for Harmanpreet Singh to launch his first overhead pass.

On Wednesday, they had done it four times in the first five minutes, assign of how well, and how deep, India had positioned themselves into the Pakistan half, cutting their midfield out of the game entirely. India moved the ball with purpose, attacked the circle and opened up a 3-0 lead, with a brace from Harmanpreet (5', 27') and a field goal from Abhishek Nain (11'). Pakistan looked close to being overwhelmed.

But Pakistan had little reason to play cautiously. Defeat meant elimination. They attacked with the desperation of a team with nothing left to protect, and slowly turned the match into something India did not want it to become.

The structure began to fray. Possession changed hands rapidly.

Attacks became more direct. Defensive errors crept in. Pakistan found goals and, with them, belief. That was the first significant victory for Pakistan, not on the scoreboard, but in changing the nature of the contest. India

Pool D

	P	W	D	L	GD	Pts
England	3	3	0	0	11	9
India	3	2	0	1	2	6
Wales	3	0	1	1	-5	1
Pakistan	3	0	1	1	-8	1

Women face England, eyes open in next round

The Indian women's team will look to seal a place in the second round when they take on a desperate England in their final Pool D match on Thursday. A draw will be enough for India to progress as pool toppers. India and China are locked on four points each, but India sit atop the pool on a superior goal difference, having scored eight goals and conceded three. England, on three points, have no such cushion and need a victory to keep their campaign alive. P11

LIVE ON Star Sports Network and JiHotstar, 6.30pm

had started the game as the more polished team. Pakistan made it a fight.

The scoreline tells the story, but not quite the right one.

A frenetic three minutes and 53 seconds in the second quarter resembled two heavyweights trading blows and refusing to get knocked out. Harmanpreet scored India's third with the clock at 20:07. Shahid Hossain pulled one back for Pakistan at 21:55. A minute later, Abhishek scored his second to restore India's three-goal cushion, but 48 seconds after that, Sufyan Khan dragged Pakistan back into the contest with a fierce drag-flick.

At 4-2, the game was suddenly alive in a way that had seemed impossible half an hour earlier.

It was chaotic, occasionally untidy and utterly compelling.

For India, there was an uncomfortable familiarity to it. They had surrendered a half-time lead against England in their previous match. Here, they had twice built what looked like commanding advantages, only to find Pakistan breathing down their necks again.

Yet this time there was a difference. India did not panic. They found one more goal, through Hardik Singh, finally putting enough daylight between themselves and Pakistan to close the door. The result was their continued dominance over their neighbours, and a spot in

the next phase of the World Cup. But this was hardly a stroll.

Fortunately for Craig Fulton's side, Harmanpreet seems to have hit his stride. Through all the noise, the captain remained the constant. He has spent much of the build-up to this World Cup carrying the weight of expectation that comes with being India's most feared penalty-corner weapon. On an afternoon when India needed somebody to restore order every time Pakistan threatened to take control, he repeatedly provided it.

Harmanpreet's value isn't simply measured in the goals he scores. It's the sense of security he gives India when a match begins to slip beyond their control. He ventured forward, created attacking opportunities, converted penalty corners, and absorbed moments of pressure.

If Pakistan succeeded in pulling India into their game, frantic, emotional, unpredictable, played at a pace that made every mistake feel dangerous, Harmanpreet kept India from being consumed by it.

India will take the 5-3 victory, the points and the passage into the next round. But they will also take a warning. At a World Cup, giving a team as desperate as Pakistan a way back from 3-0 and 4-1 is dangerous business. India survived it.

The Netherlands, India's likely opponents on Saturday, might not be so forgiving.

FROM THE SIDELINES

'Every sport is going green & badminton going plastic': Debate over new shuttles

Shivani Naik
New Delhi, August 19

MIXED DOUBLES Shuttler Marvin Seidel plays Bashminton to unwind. The toy set with oversize rackets and a crazy-ball shuttle bird ends up with wild trajectories. Not in his wildest, did he imagine that a synthetic shuttle or a hybrid might actually make its way onto a real badminton court, where he is a former European champion.

A promotional event for the experimental synthetic birds that the Badminton World Federation is looking to introduce in the future, saw Seidel toss them around for 30 odd minutes. His feedback? "It's fine. The sound it makes is a little off compared to feather shuttles. And you have to adjust to spin because it tumbles longer," he



said after his mixed doubles loss at the Delhi Badminton World Championships, even as he anticipates them being unrolled sooner than in the next five years.

But sitting in Germany, Seidel perceived the shortage of feather shuttles last summer and the increase in prices of shuttle tubes as something of an artificially created crisis. "Perhaps due to monopolies," he ventures.



Without digital advertising, volunteers turn physical boards mid-match to give each sponsor air time. EXPRESS PHOTO

The shortages stemmed from China's changed dietary preferences - duck to chicken, whose ripple effect saw a shortage of geese feathers and a 300% rise in shuttle costs. Even as feather shuttles need substitutes for the sport to

stay sustainable, Seidel flags a larger long-term concern. "The whole world and every sport is going green, and badminton is going plastic! I don't see the benefit of mass plastic usage. After one use they will just be lying somewhere because

plastic can't be recycled. I think we are shooting ourselves in the foot," he added.

The German badminton federation approved of synthetics earlier this year, and at the German Open, top players ended up playing a 'triple format' - a three-

a-side as demonstration on the day of the semifinals.

The synthetics, still being tested, but almost inevitable in coming years, aren't exactly widely available, which brings skepticism about them being adopted. Pitched to replace the

feathers for their durability and with the geese feathers becoming scarce, the synthetics are raising a fundamental question - is badminton really on the path to being sustainable?

Surfeit of sponsors sees ad board rotations

There are no digital advertising boards at Delhi's Badminton World's HQ and the Delhi Worlds don't have a title sponsor. But the Badminton World Federation has invited a surfeit of secondary sponsors for their mega spectacle in India, numbering 16 at least. It also means there are limited spots on the court, with 14 boards visible on broadcast cameras at any given point. It's why a mid-match manual

switch of boards happens.

Two volunteers lift the A-board and invert the side which has two distinct names on the two sides of the triangular boards. The initial plan was to dim the lights at the 11-point mark and switch like a stage play set prop. But the organisers have refused risking electric malfunctions by turning lights off and on. "We switch the boards after every game," BAI secretary Sanjay Mishra explained. It happens when cameras are on the mid-match parleys between coach and player, allowing volunteers to turn boards around. Badminton court aesthetic barely helps back boards register, but if you notice revolving sponsor names, there's a rehearsed manual switch happening in this low-tech sport.